Lesson Plans for Teaching Youth

Morals in the Life Story of the Buddha



Margaret Lisa Buschmann

Buddhism/Children

BPC 04

Morals in the Life Story of the Buddha

This manual, for teachers or parents to teach moral values to youth of ages 8 and up, is a set of fully prepared lesson plans, making it very easy to teach.

Stories from the life of the Buddha are told in simple modern English familiar to today's youth, both Buddhist and non-Buddhist. Along with each story are the Buddha's words from the Dhammapada or another Buddhist text highlighting the moral illustrated by the story, and a detailed Dharma discussion. Students can easily relate to the discussions that directly show them how to apply the moral to their day-to-day life with its modern challenges. Crucial values for developing wholesomeness are the topics of these discussions. In addition, there are questions, games, quizzes, puzzles, and other entertaining activities to help students remember and apply the teachings.

This manual makes the Dharma come alive in every aspect of life of youth. It promotes the understanding of Dharma and stimulates the practice of the moral values.

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Morals in The Life Story of the Buddha

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Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato
Sammā Sambuddhassa

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Contents

Acknowledgements iv
Contents v
Introduction ix
Opening Chants xv
Meditation xvi
List of Sources xviii

1. Moral Value: Reverence
   Story: Birth of Prince Siddhattha 3
2. Moral Value: Compassion
   Story: Prince Siddhattha's Childhood 11
3. Moral Value: Avoid Arguments
   Story: Devadatta and the Swan 19
4. Moral Value: Understand Suffering
   Story: The Four Signs 27
5. Moral Value: Avoid Bad Influence
   Story: Leaving Home 35
6. Moral Value: Self-control
   Story: The Ascetic Life 43
7. Moral Value: Effort
   Story: Māra's Challenge and Sujātā's Offering 51
8. Moral Value: Understand The Path And Goal
   Story: Enlightenment 59
9. Moral Value: Gratitude
   Story: The First 7 Weeks After Enlightenment 67
10. Moral Value: Show Gratitude
    Story: Deciding to Teach 75
11. Moral Value: Humility
    Story: Yasa and the Kassapas 85
12. Moral Value: Avoid Jealousy
    Story: Moggallāna and Sāriputta 95
13. Moral Value: Diligence
    Story: Return to Kapilavatthu 103
14. Moral Value: Avoid Possessiveness

Story: Bhaddiya the Happy Monk 113
15. MORAL VALUE: TRUTHFULNESS
Story: Ven. Rāhula and the Dipper 123
16. MORAL VALUE: GENEROSITY
Story: Generosity of Anāthapiṇḍika 131
17. MORAL VALUE: LOVING-KINDNESS (METTĀ)
Story: Kaṭhina 139
18. MORAL VALUE: AVOID VANITY
Story: The Order of Nuns, Khemā and Nandā 147
19. MORAL VALUE: OBEDIENCE
Story: Nāgasamāla and Meghiya 155
20. MORAL VALUE: AVOID ANGRY SPEECH
Story: River Rohini? 163
21. MORAL VALUE: ADMIT MISTAKES
Story: Quarrel at Kosambi 171
22. MORAL VALUE: AVOID BAD COMPANY
Story: Quarrel at Kosambi Part 2 179
23. MORAL VALUE: CONFIDENCE
Story: Aṅgulimāla 187
24. MORAL VALUE: FORBEARANCE
Story: Sundarī 197
25. MORAL VALUE: MEDITATION
Story: Soṇa Kolivisa 207
26. MORAL VALUE: MERIT
Story: Visākhā 217
27. MORAL VALUE: SELFLESS SERVICE
Story: The Sick Monk 225
28. MORAL VALUE: COURAGE
Story: Sopāka 231
29. MORAL VALUE: CONTROL ANGER
Story: Devadatta's Anger 241
30. MORAL VALUE: AVOID CONFLICT
Story: Devadatta Divides the Sangha 251
31. MORAL VALUE: AVOID WASTING OPPORTUNITY
Story: The Passing Away of the Buddha 259

Introduction

About Teaching

Teaching children Dharma is one of the most wonderful and challenging opportunities in life. It is wonderful for many reasons, which include enjoying the children's ideas, sharing their humor and enthusiasm, admiring their art and talent, understanding and encouraging them to overcome their difficulties, and being inspired by their efforts, their beautiful personalities and their expressions. It is challenging mostly because the teacher must constantly—every day and every minute of the day—be aware of and practice the moral values he or she is teaching. As the Buddha says:

> *One should first establish oneself in what is proper; then only should one instruct others. Thus the wise man will not be reproached. One should do what one teaches others to do; if one would train others, one should be well-controlled oneself. Difficult, indeed is self-control.* (Dhammapada 158–159/12:2–3)

As a teacher, during the interval between the last class and the class in which a particular moral value is being taught, you can focus your practice on that moral value. Then you will teach with the confidence and understanding of one who practices what he or she preaches. In some instances, particularly with older children, you might even have your own anecdote to share with the class regarding your experience in practicing that value.

Whether you are an experienced teacher, a parent, or someone who has never taught before, I encourage you to accept the wonderful and challenging opportunity to teach Dharma to children with the help of this book, and with an open, understanding and loving heart. You can teach your own children at home or with a small group, you can organize and teach a Dharma class at a local temple or meditation center, or you can assist or substitute in an

ongoing Dharma class. More than ever, with the negative influences of modern society, children need guidance in becoming aware of their own moral weaknesses and how to overcome them—how to practice the moral values in their daily life, given today's norms and challenges.

I have observed that children in India and Sri Lanka are generally well disciplined, which appears to be enforced by a policy of not tolerating boisterousness, aggressiveness, or unruliness. This policy is much more difficult to enforce in western countries due to the general permissiveness of the modern culture, emphasis on self-expression and competition, and the fear of hindering healthy self esteem. However, youth can learn best in an environment of strict but loving discipline. Otherwise, teachers must raise their voices above children's murmurings and outbursts, and must interrupt the lesson to correct behavior, so the students' attention and the flow of the class are disrupted. An integral part of any spiritual or religious education is self-control and compassion for others. It is good to start a new class by asking the students to create class rules for all to obey, so they will accept their own rules. Rules should include entering and exiting the classroom quietly and in a line (like the monks), waiting to be called on before speaking, and observing silence in the meditation or puja area. Small prizes such as pens can be awarded for improved behavior if enforcement is necessary.

About this Book

This book was written with the idea that the most important aspect of teaching youth is to facilitate the growth of their good character by learning and practice of spiritual (moral) values. In the terminology of Buddhism, we would refer to guiding them along the path of Dharma toward the ultimate goal of enlightenment, or liberation from the cycle of rebirth. This book is not, however, exclusively for Buddhists. It is instructive for youth of any religion to become acquainted with a great historical religious figure, Gotama

Buddha, and to learn moral values which are central to all religions. This book does not delve into doctrines and nomenclature which are strictly Buddhist, but does refer to Buddhist beliefs in rebirth and kamma, and describes basic Buddhist principles such as the Middle Path, the Four Noble Truths, and the Eightfold Path. Therefore, this book was written with the intention of being used for teaching youth in Buddhist dharma school, Sai Spiritual Education, Education in Human Values, and Hindu, Jain, interfaith and unitarian classes. It is hoped that anyone of any faith will find this book instructive and inspiring for teaching youth.

The stories of the Buddha contained in this book do not follow the direct translations from the Pali texts. These texts include vocabulary, grammar and speaking styles which may be distracting or incomprehensible to young students of today's world. Instead, the stories are told in modern English which is easy for even the youngest students to understand. In addition, some details which are often included in popular renderings of these stories are omitted from the stories in this book to encourage focus on the moral value being taught.

The Lesson Plans

This book is organized into lesson plans, each of which is suitable for teaching a class of about 90 minutes duration. The teacher should review the lesson plan thoroughly prior to teaching the class, so that it will run smoothly, and so that any materials needed for the activities are ready for use in class. Each component of the lesson plan should be included in each class, for the reasons stated below.

1. Opening chants, meditation, and review of last lesson

Group chanting helps to calm the students' minds so that they are ready to learn in a disciplined environment. Suggested Buddhist chants are included in this book. For youth of different cultures or religions, group prayers, mantras and/or bhajans or group devotional singing may

be added or substituted. Any of these create a serene vibration, purifying the environment.

Meditation helps to further calm and focus the mind. Sample meditations are provided in this book, and more information about meditation is included in Chapter 25. The teacher should make sure the students are sitting with a straight back, relaxed shoulders and eyes gently closed, and discreetly observe whether the students are sitting still during the meditation.

Review of the last lesson means that the teacher calls on a student to summarize the story from the previous class. Most students enjoy an opportunity to speak, and it encourages students to try to remember the story, which helps to develop their memory. For shy students, the opportunity to summarize the story helps them build confidence in speaking to an audience in a relaxed and accepting environment. The review creates continuity in the stories, and helps students who missed a class to be up to date.

2. Question to think about before the story

The question is not to be answered aloud, but is only a suggestion of the topic that the students should focus on in the story. It elicits students' memories of their own experiences with the moral value, so that they can personally relate to it and so that it is clearly understood.

3. The story

Whether students are very young or teenagers, they all love to hear stories, particularly when they are presented in an interesting way. I encourage teachers to observe a professional or popular storyteller for inspiration on how to tell a story. In general, the teacher should feel free to use tools of drama: facial expressions, voice that acts out each character in the story, body language, hand movements, pauses to create suspense, and humor when appropriate. The story should be mostly memorized by the teacher before

presentation to the class, so that the teacher has good eye contact with the students. Descriptive embellishments may be added for effect by the teacher, such as a vivid description of the scene, or the physical appearance of a character.

4. Questions after the story

The questions included with each lesson can be modified or substituted to adjust to the ages of the students. Some questions are very simple to encourage the youngest and shyest students to answer. Encourage all students to participate in answering the questions.

5. Quotation of the Buddha about the moral of the story

The quotation gives the direct teaching from the Buddha for the lesson, and the discussion following it relates the quotation to the students' daily life. One student should be called upon to read the quotation.

The quotations chosen often do not reflect the only moral value in the story. For example, in "Devadatta and the Swan," the obvious morals of the story are compassion and to abstain from killing or injuring animals. Because most children naturally have compassion for animals, there is little need to address those issues. It is very important to teach the moral values that children are most lacking. Therefore, the moral chosen for that lesson is to avoid arguing, given that many youth nowadays tend to argue about the slightest things.

Most quotations are taken from verses of the Dhammapada. The Pali is included mostly for the benefit of teachers who are familiar with Pali, so that they can impart the full meaning of the verse. Depending on the age and culture of the students, it may be appropriate for them to read along in Pali also.

6. Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives

Preaching morals to students does not mean they will practice them. They know generally what they should and

should not do, but in their day-to-day lives, they often tend to flow more with popular trends than to go against the flow in favor of higher moral standards. Many pre-teens and adolescents act one way while with their parents or in class, and quite another when alone with their peers. Therefore, it is particularly important to discuss the very challenges to maintaining good values that they actually face with their peers. They should be encouraged to bring up these problems so they can be discussed freely in the class. Students prefer to participate in a discussion rather than to be preached at.

However, the discussion should be well moderated by the teacher. It is most effective for the teacher to ask often for the students' responses, opinions, and/or experiences during this segment of the lesson, as it encourages them to think more deeply and more fully absorb the lesson.

The text provided is best used as merely guidance for the teacher, who should supplement or revise as appropriate to reflect the students' ages, needs, and culture.

7. Activity to reinforce the lesson

Children are usually very creative and enjoy expressing themselves in various arts, so role plays, drawing, painting and sculpture are included as activities to make the class fun and exciting. They also enjoy games and puzzles, so those are included also, as fun ways to remember what they learned. In general, activities are meant for students to carry the lesson beyond the classroom—either as an artwork for display in their home or at the temple, or as a fun memory. If some activities are too advanced for some students in a class with mixed ages, the younger ones may use crayons to draw and color pictures as an alternative.

8. Closing chant

The closing chant is to encourage the practice of loving-kindness. Also, a class should end as a disciplined group, not with individual students straying out of the classroom, and the closing chant is a method of encouraging this discipline.

OPENING CHANTS

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa
Homage to the Blissful One,
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa
the Worthy One,
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa.
the Fully Enlightened One.

Buddhaṃ Saraṇaṃ Gacchāmi
I go to the Buddha for refuge
Dhammaṃ Saraṇaṃ Gacchāmi
I go to the Dharma for refuge
Saṅghaṃ Saraṇaṃ Gacchāmi.
I go to the Sangha for refuge.
Dutiyam pi Buddhaṃ Saraṇaṃ Gacchāmi . . .
A second time I go to the Buddha …the *Dharma, …the Sangha.*
Tatiyam pi Buddhaṃ Saraṇaṃ Gacchāmi . . .
A third time I go to the Buddha…. the *Dharma …the Sangha.*

Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi
I abstain from taking life
Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi
I abstain from taking what is not given
Kāmesu micchāchārā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi
I abstain from sexual misconduct
Musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi
I abstain from false speech
Surāmeraya-majja-pamādaṭṭhānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi.
I abstain from intoxicants.

MEDITATION

BREATHING MEDITATION

(Teacher or parent can say this aloud, softly and slowly, and when referring to the breath, speak in rhythm with very relaxed breath, pausing for one or two breaths in between each sentence)

Sit cross-legged on the floor, or with your bottom on a cushion and your legs (cross-legged) on the floor. Put one hand in the other palm, with your thumbs touching. Close your eyes gently. Sit up very tall, but relax your shoulders, arms and hands. Let your arms feel heavy so they relax. Pull your chin in just slightly toward your neck. Let your body relax so much that you could fall asleep, but sit up tall. Take a deep slow breath in, and out. Try to breathe through your nose only, slowly and naturally. When we breathe slowly and deeply, our mind can slow down and relax. Notice how it feels to breathe in, and how it feels to breathe out.

Notice the feeling at the tip of your nose as you breathe in, and notice the feeling in your nose as you breathe out. The tip of your nose may feel cool as you breathe in, and warm as you breathe out. Notice your stomach moving as you breathe in, and out. Your stomach moves out as you breathe in, and it moves in as you breathe out. Let your stomach move naturally out, and in, as you breathe. Notice the feeling in your chest as you breathe in, and out. Your lungs fill with air as you breathe in, and empty as you breathe out. Notice any feeling in the throat as you breathe in, and out. Notice the feeling deep in your nose as you breathe in, and out. Now you can choose one place to focus on that is easy for you—the tip of the nose, deep in the nose, the chest, or the stomach. Keep your attention only on that place as you breathe in, and out, for several breaths, as long as you can. Try to notice if you are thinking about something else, and bring your attention back to that place, breathing in, and breathing out.

Mettā Meditation

Start with the first paragraph of the Breathing Meditation, above, and then continue as follows:

Imagine that you are holding a cute baby animal, maybe a rabbit, bird or puppy. Imagine you hold him close to your heart, cuddling it gently. You feel you want to protect it and take care of it so it is always happy. You know that it is perfectly good and innocent. Notice how happy and loving you feel toward the baby animal. Now let us take that same loving kindness (*mettā*) we have to the baby animal, and offer that to others. We have that same loving-kindness to everyone in this room as we imagine everyone holding their baby animal. And to our parents who have given and loved us so much. We have that same loving-kindness to our other family members, who have helped us so many times. We have that same loving-kindness to our friends, who have been so kind to us. We have that same loving-kindess to our teachers who have patiently taught us. Imagine that you now give the baby animal to someone at school who you don't know very well, and that person feels very happy holding the baby animal, smiling and cuddling it. You have given happiness to that person. Imagine that you give the baby animal to other people at school who you don't know, and to neighbors, and they smile with happiness and love. Now think of someone who has annoyed you before. Imagine you give the baby animal to that person, and he or she smiles at it and looks at it lovingly, and then looks at you very kindly. When you smile, he or she smiles back. You have given happiness. Think of everyone who has annoyed or upset you, and imagine giving the baby animal to each of them to hold, and they become happy and loving as they open their hearts to the baby animal, and then to you.

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Lesson 1
Reverence

Lesson 1
REVERENCE

Opening chants & meditation.

Question to think about before the story: What are some special things about the Buddha that are different from most people?

Story: Birth of Prince Siddhattha

About 2500 years ago, in Kapilavatthu at the base of the Himalaya Mountains in a place now called Nepal, lived the Sakya clan, ruled by King Suddhodana. He had two wives, Queen Mahāmāyā and her younger sister, Gotamī. King Suddhodana and his wives were very kind, good people, but they had no children. One night, Queen Mahāmāyā dreamed that she was carried by four heavenly beings to the Himalaya Mountains, where she bathed in a lake and wore heavenly clothes and was adorned with flowers. She lay on a couch, with a silver mountain nearby. A white elephant appeared, holding in its trunk a white flower, and he trumpeted and went around the Queen's couch three times, and then disappeared inside her. When she awoke, she told the King about the dream. At the time of that dream, the Bodhisatta (one who will become a Buddha) came from a heaven-world (Devaloka) and became Queen Mahāmāyā's child.

Ten months later, she was riding in a golden palanquin with friends on her way to her parents' home to give birth, and at Lumbini Park there was a garden, and the Queen wanted to stop and relax. She walked to a huge Sala tree and reached for a branch, which moved toward her and formed a curtain, and as she stood she gave birth to the Bodhisatta. Four deities held the new baby and presented him to the Queen, saying, "Rejoice, O Queen, a son of great power has been born to you!" The newborn Bodhisatta stood on the

ground and took seven steps toward the North, and at each step, a lotus bloom appeared under his foot. With a white umbrella held over him, he looked in the four directions and said, "I am the Highest in the world, I am the best in the world, I am the foremost in the world. This is the last birth, there will be no more births for me." A powerful light went through the whole universe, the heaven-worlds and even to the darkest areas of the universe.

Asita, a great sage (which means a wise holy man), was a friend of King Suddhodana. Asita heard about the birth of the King's son and came immediately from the Himalaya Mountains to visit. When he arrived at the palace, Queen Mahāmāyā held the baby Prince with his head toward the great sage so the baby could bow to him. Bowing to the feet is a way of showing reverence. But the baby Prince turned his feet toward Asita. The King then held the baby to bow toward Asita, but again the Prince turned his feet toward Asita. The King tried three times, but the baby did the same thing each time. But Asita was full of joy and saw the 32 signs of a great being on the baby Prince, including long earlobes, long arms, long fingers and toes, golden color skin, long thick eyelashes, very dark eyes, and the shape of a wheel on his feet. Asita told the King not to stop the baby from turning, but to allow him to worship the baby's feet. Then Asita had tears in his eyes and looked very sad. The royal family became worried, seeing the great sage's tears, and asked, "Is there any danger to the Prince?" Asita said, "No harm will touch the Prince, but he his not an ordinary person. He will become enlightened and with great compassion he will be a great teacher of Dharma. My life will end before that and I will not hear his teaching, so I feel sad."

A few days later, the King invited some astrologers to the palace to tell the Prince's future. They looked at the baby Prince, and said that if he has a family, then he will be king of the world, but if he chooses not to have a family but to be a renunciant, which is a holy man who gives up all worldly

things, then he will become the Enlightened One, and will teach truth to the world. The baby Prince was named Siddhattha, and his family name was Gotama.

When Prince Siddhattha was seven days old, his mother Queen Mahāmāyā died and went to a heaven world, and her sister Gotamī took care of him as a mother.

Questions after the story:

1. What does "Boddhisattva" mean?
2. What happened during Queen Mahāmāyā's dream?
3. What *loka* (world) did the Bodhisatta come from?
4. What unusual things happened when the baby was born?
5. Why do you think the baby turned his feet toward Asita?
6. How did Asita show reverence to the baby?
7. Why did Asita feel sad?
8. What did the astrologers predict about the baby's future?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"*Pūjārahe pūjayato, Buddhe yadi va sāvake, papañcha samatikkante, tiṇṇa sokapariddave. Te tādise pūjayato, nibbute akutobhaye, nasakkā puññam saṅkhātum, imettām iti kena ci.*"

"He who reveres the worthy ones, the Buddhas and their disciples, who have overcome all challenges and unhappiness, he who reveres such peaceful and fearless ones has more merit than can be measured." (Dhammapada 195–196; 14:17–18)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

What does it mean, to "revere" the Buddha, or to have "reverence"? We might say it means to "respect" the Buddha. When we "respect" someone, we usually mean that we act in a proper manner and do not do anything that is disrespectful. For example, we respect our teachers and other students. The word "revere" means something more

than just "respect." To understand the word "reverence," we can remember how Asita felt toward the baby Bodhisatta. How do you think he felt when he first saw the baby Prince? He felt great joy and admiration, knowing how great this baby is—that he will become enlightened and be a great teacher of Dharma. He also felt sad about not living long enough to see him teach the Dharma. So, he felt that the baby Bodhisatta was very precious, very valuable to be with.

The word "reverence" or to "revere" means admiring the person's great qualities, understanding and appreciating the value of that person, how important he is to us, and feeling happiness to see or know about that person. When we revere the Buddha, we think of his special qualities—not the unusual marks that he had on the body, but his personality and the way that he behaved. What are some of these qualities of the Buddha's personality? He had a virtuous character, self control, great teaching, compassion, and many other qualities that we will learn about in future lessons.

Also, when we revere the Buddha, we feel happiness and gratitude that he has helped the whole world by teaching the Dharma, and that we can learn the Dharma. So, when we bow to the Buddha, we should not bow artificially just because it is proper to bow. Instead, what should we think about? We should carefully think about the good qualities of the Buddha, how special he is, and how fortunate we are to have the Dharma.

Activity to reinforce the lesson: (next page)

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

WORD SEARCH
FIND AND CIRCLE 10 WORDS FROM THE STORY:

R	A	M	F	E	E	T	K	L	U	N
A	D	A	S	I	T	A	I	P	N	E
B	N	H	J	W	R	A	L	H	I	P
H	S	A	K	Y	A	P	K	L	V	A
L	U	M	B	I	N	I	O	R	I	L
O	W	A	G	Y	S	D	A	L	R	Y
T	P	Y	S	R	A	Q	U	E	S	A
U	D	A	V	H	L	Y	O	T	E	L
S	I	D	D	H	A	T	T	H	A	P

Lesson 2
Compassion

Lesson 2
Compassion

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Can you think of a time when you were very young when you felt compassion for a person or an animal?

Story: Prince Siddhattha's Childhood

The young Prince Siddhattha had the best of everything – the best food, the best clothing, and even three lily ponds with swans on them. There were 32 ladies to help take care of the young Prince, and someone to hold a sunshade over him always. The king gave the young prince three palaces—one for summer, one for winter and one for the rainy season. He played with his friends in his palaces and in the gardens around them. The king remembered what the astrologers had said, that Siddhattha would be either a king of the world or an Enlightened One. King Suddhodana wanted his son to be a great king rather than a great holy man. So, he gave his son wonderful luxuries so that he would be happy living his life as a king in the future.

One day, King Suddhodana went to a ploughing ceremony with the young Prince Siddhattha and the ladies who took care of him. The King went to participate in the ceremony while the ladies looked after the young Prince. The ladies spread a soft rug on the ground and placed the young Prince on it. The ladies wanted to see the singing, dancing and music of the ceremony, so they went closer to the ceremony and forgot about little Siddhattha. After some time, the ladies returned to look for Prince Siddhattha, but he was no longer on the rug.

Prince Siddhattha had watched the men sweating in the hot sun working with the heavy ploughs, he saw the oxen

straining their muscles to pull the ploughs faster, and he saw the birds killing insects to eat. Prince Siddhattha not only saw, but he also deeply felt, the pain and misery of the men, the oxen and the insects. Understanding their suffering and wishing he could take away their suffering, he felt compassion (*karuṇā*). As he felt great compassion for them, he sat cross-legged under a rose-apple tree with his eyes closed, and meditated. As he meditated, he felt great happiness. The ladies and King Suddhodana found Prince Siddhattha meditating. Seeing his son meditating, the King remembered again what the astrologers had said, that if he does not have a family life, he will be an Enlightened One. The King decided to give little Siddhattha more and more luxuries and to train him to be a great king.

So, when Siddhattha was eight years old, he became the student of the best and wisest teacher, Viswamitra, along with many other children. He learned math, science, languages, history, geography, archery, wrestling, and the art of war and the military. Siddhattha was a very intelligent student, and was very strong, respectful and kind to all. Although Siddhattha already had read many books before he started school, and knew many things, he was humble; he did not show off to other students.

Questions after the story:

1. Why was Prince Siddhattha given the best of everything?
2. What did Prince Siddhattha see at the ploughing ceremony?
3. What did he feel when he saw the men, the oxen and the insects?
4. What was he doing with his eyes closed?
5. What does the word "humble" mean?
6. What is "*karuṇā*" in English?
7. Why do you think the king wanted his son to be a king rather than a holy man?

Quotation of the Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Sabbe sattā, sabbe pāṇā, sabbe bhūtā ca kevalā, sabbe bhadrāni passantu, mā kañci pāpam āgamā."

"All beings, all those with life, all who have taken birth, May all see what is good; may suffering not come to anyone." (Khandha-paritta)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Compassion, or *karuṇā* in Pali and Sanskrit languages, is one of the main teachings of the Buddha. What does compassion really mean? Compassion does not mean only to feel sorry for someone, or to feel sad about someone's pain or unhappiness. Sometimes when we see someone else's pain or difficulty, we feel afraid that it may happen to us too. That is a self-centered feeling, fear or worry about ourselves, which is not compassion. Compassion means that we really understand the suffering of another living being. The Pali word "*dukkha*" means suffering, dissatisfaction, pain, sorrow, stress and unhappiness. We understand the dukkha of another being because we have felt that way before; we have experienced it and we remember how it feels. More importantly, compassion means that we genuinely wish to take away the pain, stress and unhappiness of the other living being, and fill him or her with happiness and peace. So, what does compassion mean? It means to understand the dukkha of another being and really wish to remove it from him or her.

Do you know about the Law of Karma? It means that for each action that we do, we receive the result of that action. For each good act we do, we get a good result—something pleasant, something that is good for us—maybe not immediately, but some time in the future. For each bad act we do, we get a bad result—something painful or unpleasant will happen to us in return for our bad act.

So does that mean that when we see someone else suffering, we should think that is because that person did

something bad? If we do, then we may not care about the person, or we might be unkind to him or her. Then we become unkind and uncaring. It is better to think that we all have done bad things in our past lives, and we all must suffer the results of it at some time. We never know when we will get the result. We may be following the Dharma, doing what the Buddha taught us to do, but still we experience the painful results of our past deeds. So, we should have compassion for others without judging whether they are good or bad.

Why is compassion so important? Why is it one of the main teachings of the Buddha? If we don't have much compassion, then we only think about what we want. What type of person are we if we only think about what we want? Selfish and greedy.

If we understand how others feel, and we care about how they feel, then it helps us to be less selfish. When we have compassion for others, then we are more kind to them, and we may look for opportunities to help them. When we are kind and helpful, they can become happier. When others around us are happier, then we have a peaceful, friendly, happy environment.

It is good to feel compassion for everyone, but can we always help everyone? It is not always appropriate to help everyone. Little Prince Siddhattha did not go and help the sweating men or the straining oxen, and he did not go and protect the insects from the birds. Why not? He might have gotten hurt if he went near the oxen, and he would be interfering with the ceremony. He would be starving the birds, preventing them from getting food, if he protected the insects. So, if we see an opportunity to help, we should first determine whether it is safe for us to help, whether our parents would approve, and whether our help would be appreciated. If we are not sure whether someone would want our help, we should first offer to help.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

MATCHING

Draw a line from the word in the left column to the matching words in the right column:

humble	predicted that Siddhattha would be a king or enlightened
meditation	to understand someone's suffering and wish to relieve it
luxuries	the King, Siddhattha's father
rose apple tree	how Siddhattha felt toward the other students
karuṇā	suffering, unhappiness, stress
dukkha	to calm and focus the mind
Suddhodana	where Siddhattha was found meditating
Astrologers	good actions give good results, bad actions give bad results
Law of Karma	what the King gave Siddhattha

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 3
Avoid Arguments

Lesson 3
AVOID ARGUMENTS

Opening chants, meditation, and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever had an argument with someone, each of you saying "It's mine"? Have you ever had an argument when someone did something wrong and you were trying to correct him or her?

Story: Devadatta and the Swan

Prince Siddhattha was extremely kind and compassionate to all. He never hurt others; he wanted to make others happy and was always ready to help both human and animal beings. He even loved snakes and other animals that other people did not care about. Prince Siddhattha often played in the park with his friends and his cousin, Devadatta. Devadatta had a bow and arrows and he liked to hunt animals.

One day when the Prince and his friends were in the park, Devadatta saw a swan flying and shot it with an arrow, and the swan dropped to the ground. Prince Siddhattha quickly ran to the swan and saw that it was alive, but in great pain. He removed the arrow, caressing the swan tenderly, and got some healing leaves and squeezed out some juice from the leaves onto the wound. He bandaged it with a cloth. Just then Devadatta rushed up to Siddhattha and angrily demanded, "Give me my bird. I shot it." Prince Siddhattha relied, "No, I'm not going to give it to you. If you had killed it, then it is yours. But it was wounded and alive, and I saved it, so it is mine." Devadatta argued and demanded that Prince Siddhattha give him the bird. Prince Siddhattha said, "Let's go to the pundits (wise men) and ask who owns it." Devadatta agreed.

They explained the situation to the pundits, who discussed it and said, "A life must belong to him who tries

to save it. A life cannot belong to one only trying to destroy it. So, the swan belongs to Prince Siddhattha."

Prince Siddhattha took care of the swan until he was healed. Then Prince Siddhattha released him so he could live in freedom as a wild swan. But Devadatta began to hate Prince Siddhattha.

Questions after the story:

1. How did Devadatta feel about other beings?
2. What happened when Devadatta's arrow hit the swan?
3. Why didn't Prince Siddhattha give the swan to Devadatta?
4. If the swan was dead, would Prince Siddhattha argue with Devadatta to keep it? Why not?
5. Why did the Pundits say that Prince Siddhattha should have the swan?
6. What do you think would have happened if Prince Siddhattha did not argue with Devadatta?
7. How did Prince Siddhattha and Devadatta settle the argument?
8. Why do you think Prince Siddhattha decided to go to the pundits rather than try to win the argument himself?
9. When someone does something wrong, or wants to do something wrong, should we always argue? Should we always keep quiet? Should we always go to an adult to settle it?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"*Na tena ariyo hoti, yena pāṇāni hiṃsati; ahiṃsa sabbapāṇānaṃ, ariyo ti pavuccati*."

"He is not noble who injures living beings. He is called noble because he is harmless to all living beings."

(Dhammapada 270/19:15)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

We know that it is wrong to kill or injure the body of another being, human or animal. But harm can be done to others in many ways. One way is the body can be hurt or injured. What are some other ways that we can feel harm or hurt? How do you feel when someone argues with you? We often feel annoyed, or we may feel angry. Or, if we "win" the argument, the other person gets annoyed or angry, and may try to hurt us in return. So, arguing is often harmful. Also, others who hear the argument get annoyed or may join in the argument, causing more people to lose their temper, which is harming them. Arguing can become a bad habit.

Buddha teaches us to be harmless to all living beings—to practice *ahiṃsa* (which means non-harming, non-violence). This means not to harm others with our acts or our words or even our thoughts. So usually, arguing is not a good thing. We should not argue just because we want to have something, which is selfish. We should not argue to force someone to do what we want. We should not argue to avoid doing something that we should do. And we should not argue with parents or teachers.

But we see from the story that there are times when arguing is the right thing to do. When is it OK to argue? You can argue to save the life of another being, or to prevent another being from harm. This does not happen very often, right? Sometimes it is difficult to decide whether arguing will really protect someone from harm.

It is also sometimes difficult to decide whether arguing will protect ourselves from harm. We might argue to defend ourselves, to stand our ground, and not give in to what other kids say. We may believe that we will look weak if we don't argue. We don't like some kid bossing us around, bullying us, bothering us, or treating us unfairly. How can we defend ourselves without arguing? It is alright to say our opinion, to disagree, to ignore someone trying to argue with us, to walk away, or to refuse to do something we think is wrong.

We should protect ourselves from being abused by others. This is not harming others. But if we try to force others to do something or to agree with us by speaking harshly, loudly, angrily, or with threats or insults, then we are arguing. We are disturbing all those people who hear our loud unfriendly voices, which is harming them. Before we do that, we need to determine whether we *should* argue.

We must decide whether arguing is more helpful to others or more harmful to ourselves and others. So, we have to carefully think, are we arguing to really help or protect someone? Or are we arguing to impress others, to "win" the argument, or to get what we want but don't really need? These are not good reasons to argue.

When we are trying to protect someone, protect an animal, or protect ourselves, we may have to go to an adult to settle the argument. Prince Siddhattha saw that Devadatta was very angry and forceful, so it was best to go to the pundits to settle the argument rather than continue arguing.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Class discussion—In each of the following scenarios, should you argue or keep quiet? Under what conditions is it wrong to argue? Under what conditions is it good or OK to argue?

1. Your little sister wants to play with your toy. Should you argue and prevent her from playing with it?
2. Your little brother is eating cookies and you ask him to stop eating so many, but he doesn't stop. Should you argue and prevent him from eating them?
3. A student says something insulting to another student. Should you argue with him or her?
4. Your sister drops food on the floor, you point it out, but she does not clean it. Should you argue?
5. You and your brother are watching TV and he turns it to another channel. You ask him to put it back, and he refuses. Should you insist that he turn it back to the other channel?

6. You are standing in line at school and a student cuts in front of you. Should you argue?
7. Your brother borrows your clean bike and returns it full of mud, and you ask him to clean it but he says no, he didn't make it muddy. Should you argue and insist that he clean it?

Suggested Answers:

1. No if you just want to play with the toy or you don't like her to have it. Yes if the toy is dangerous for her.

2. No if you just want to eat or save the cookies for yourself. Yes if you think he may get sick from eating too many.

3. If you think the student was really hurt by the insult, you may say something to point out that insulting is wrong. If he or she argues back, it is best to keep quiet and avoid arguing. If it seems likely that he or she may harm the other student again, then it is appropriate to tell an adult.

4. You can kindly point out the food on the floor again, but if she still does not clean it, arguing probably won't make her do it, but only causes annoyance. You can clean it and discuss it with your parents.

5. Yes if the other channel is violent (harmful). No if you just want to watch your channel. You can kindly agree to watch a show you both like, or a show that you like for some time and a show he likes for an equal time. (But you should not watch too much TV, and only what your parents permit!)

6. If you are last in line and you think the person didn't notice you, you can politely say "I'm in line also." If others are in line behind you, they may be unhappy if you allow him to cut in line, so you can kindly say "excuse me, they are all waiting also." If he ignores you, arguing probably won't help, it only causes annoyance.

7. No, it probably won't help anyone to argue. You can discuss it with your parents.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 4
Understand Suffering

Lesson 4
UNDERSTAND SUFFERING

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever thought about how every living person feels suffering (dukkha) in their lives?

Story: The Four Signs

Prince Siddhattha grew up with all of the comforts and wealth given to him by his royal family's palaces in the city of Kapilavatthu. When he was 16 years old, his father King Suddhodana met with his council and they discussed Prince Siddhattha's future as a king, to govern the Sakya people. The council members suggested that Prince Siddhattha get married. King Suddhodana wondered which young lady would be the right one to be Prince Siddhattha's bride, and each council member wanted his daughter to be married to Prince Siddhattha. The King asked his son what type of bride he would accept, and Prince Siddhattha replied that she must not be an ordinary girl, but she must have no envy, she must be truthful, careful, not proud of her beauty, generous, content, religious, pure in mind and speech and respectful to all. The King sent messengers to search for a bride for his son, and they invited all of the daughters of the neighboring kings and nobles to his palace. They came to the palace dressed beautifully. Prince Siddhattha presented each young lady with a gift. The daughter of King Supprabuddha, Princess Yasodharā, who was Prince Siddhattha's cousin, was one of the young ladies invited. But after all of the other young ladies received a gift from Prince Siddhattha, he had no extra gift for Princess Yasodharā, so he gave one of his own pieces of jewelry to her that he was wearing, maybe a gold ring. Prince Siddhattha saw that Princess Yasodharā had the qualities that he had told his

father he was looking for, and decided that she would be his bride. Soon, they were married.

Prince Siddhattha lived happily with his wife Yasodharā, with the best food and entertainment – musicians, dancers and singers. One day, Prince Siddhattha asked Channa, the driver of his chariot (horse drawn carriage), to drive him outside the palace grounds to the park. An old man was walking along the road, bent over, shaking, holding on to a large stick for support. Prince Siddhattha asked Channa, "What is wrong with that man? Why is his hair so white and his face wrinkled?" Channa replied, "He is very old." Prince Siddhattha had never seen an old person before, and asked, "what is the meaning of 'old'?'" Channa said, "He will not live long." Prince Siddhattha asked, "Will I become old like that?" Channa said, "You and I and all people get old." Prince Siddhattha felt unhappy and said, "Enough of this journey. Let's go back home." He was filled with sorrow and distress, thinking that everyone who is born must get old. When King Suddhodana saw his distress, he sent more dancing girls to entertain the Prince.

On another day, Prince Siddhattha went in his chariot to the park with Channa. Along the road they saw a man lying down, wailing in pain, trembling and thin, breathing loudly. Channa said, "Let's get away from here." Prince Siddhattha asked, "Who is he? Why should we get away?" Channa replied, "He is a sick man. Everyone gets sick some time. It is painful. Anyone can get sick at any time." Prince Siddhattha asked, "Could I get sick? Can royal people get sick?" Channa said, "Yes, no one knows when they will get sick." Prince Siddhattha was again very upset and distressed, and when King Suddhodana observed this, he ordered more entertainment for the Prince, and guards to watch him.

On another day, Prince Siddhattha went with Channa to the park, and they saw a body being carried on a stretcher, with people crying around the body. Prince

Siddhattha asked Channa, "What is this? Why are those people crying? Is the man sleeping on the stretcher?" Channa answered, "The body is a dead man." Prince Siddhattha asked, "What is the meaning of 'dead'?" Channa said, "A dead person cannot walk or even move, and they cannot feel anything. The body will be cremated, burned to ashes." Prince Siddhattha asked, "Will I die? Will my father die? Will all the people I know die?" Channa said, "All living beings die. We cannot avoid it. No one can live forever." Prince Siddhattha returned to the palace, filled with sorrow.

On yet another day, Prince Siddhattha went with Channa to the park, and they saw a man wearing an orange cloth, with a bowl. His face looked very serene. Prince Siddhattha asked Channa about this man. Channa explained that he is a renunciant, a person who has given up family life to live a simple life without a home and other comforts, to develop his virtues. Prince Siddhattha liked the idea of a renunciant, and he stayed in the park happily. He had many deep thoughts after seeing these four sights: the old man, the sick man, the dead man and the renunciant. He thought, "If I get old, sick and die, be reborn again and have unhappiness and bad thoughts, then why should I seek those things that lead to getting old, sick and dying, rebirth, unhappiness and bad thoughts? What if I seek that which is not born, that which does not age, does not get sick, does not die, and does not have sorrow and impurity." He did not enjoy the pleasures at the palace anymore, the singers, dancers and musicians. He wanted to be a renunciant, like the one he saw.

Questions after the story:

1. Did Prince Siddhattha want the most beautiful lady in the country to be his bride? What type of lady did he want as his bride?
2. What did Prince Siddhattha see during the first ride to the park with Channa?

3. What did he see during the second ride and the third rides to the park?
4. Do you get upset when you see old, sick or dead people?
5. Why do you think Siddhattha felt upset when he saw these three sights?
6. Why do you think King Suddhodana ordered more entertainment for Siddhattha, and guards to watch him?
7. What did he see on the fourth ride to the park?
8. What is a renunciant?
9. How did he change after seeing the renunciant?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"*Dukkhānupatitaddhagū*"

"A person who is in saṃsāra (continuing cycle of birth, death and rebirth) experiences suffering."

(Dhammapada 302/21:13)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Does everyone suffer? Do you think that some people are always happy and do not experience real suffering (*dukkha*)? Many students at school, movie stars, sports stars, and other people we see seem to have a life full of pleasures and fun. We don't see them unhappy, crying, or in pain. But we should know that however wealthy, famous, intelligent or popular a person is, each person experiences illness, pain, fear, worry, stress, anger, frustration, loss, grief, embarrassment, agitation and other unpleasant feelings, which are all dukkha. Many people don't like others to know that they are unhappy or distressed, so they do not show their unpleasant feelings. Many people experience years of an easy life without many big difficulties. But everyone experiences some dukkha every day—some worry, pain, disappointment, feeling uncomfortable (such as being too hot, cold, hungry or thirsty), someone disappointed with us, someone expecting us to do something we don't

want to do, forgetting something important, losing something, something not working properly, or someone ignoring us or acting unpleasant toward us. We feel happiness, we have fun, we enjoy, but some type of dukkha always comes afterward. It is said that pleasure comes only between two pains. And everyone experiences extreme dukkha at some points in their lives—loss of someone they love, getting in an accident, having a serious illness, losing something precious, failure, loneliness, or fear.

Siddhattha felt such compassion for others that he felt very sad seeing illness, old age, death, and pain. He could not be happy knowing that others are suffering. He wanted to relieve people from suffering by finding a way to escape it.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Bean bag toss: Students sit in a circle, and try to think of several situations which cause dukkha in their lives (for example, getting a bad grade, being late for class, rejection, broken toy, not being invited to a party, being bullied, making your team lose, disagreement with a friend, boredom, too much homework). As the teacher or parent tosses the bean bag toward a student, he/she calls out a situation which causes dukkha. The student catching the bean bag must immediately toss the bean bag to another student while calling out a different situation which causes dukkha. Students continue the bean bag toss while calling out a situation which causes dukkha. If a student pauses more than three seconds with the bean bag, calls out a dukkha situation after throwing it, or calls out a situation which someone else already called, he is "out" and is no longer in the game. The last one in the game wins.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 5
Avoid Bad Influence

LESSON 5

AVOID BAD INFLUENCE

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever decided to stay away from a friend because you think he or she has become a bad influence?

STORY: LEAVING HOME

Prince Siddhattha very often thought about the renunciant that he saw, the man who had given up family life and comforts to live a spiritual life of meditation. His face was so calm and peaceful, he seemed to have no worries at all, although he had no home, belongings or family. Prince Siddhattha thought, "Living in a palace is a crowded life, like living in a dusty atmosphere. The life of a renunciant is like living in wide open fresh air. It is not easy, living in a household, to lead a holy life of purity. Suppose I shave off my hair and beard, put on a yellow robe, leave the household life and live my life as a renunciant?" King Suddhodana noticed that Siddhattha seemed uninterested in the entertainment at the palace, so he worried that his son may decide to abandon the royal life and become a renunciant. King Suddhodana wanted his son to become the next king when he passed away, so he ordered the best musicians and dancers to entertain at the palace.

Prince Siddhattha's wife Yasodharā was going to have a baby. When Prince Siddhattha was away from the palace one day, he heard the news that his son was born, and he thought to himself, "An eclipse has arisen. Another bond to the world is created which is an obstacle to my renunciation." The baby was named Prince Rāhula.

As Prince Siddhattha was returning to the palace, he passed the mansion of Princess Kisāgotamī, who was standing out on her balcony. When she saw Prince

Siddhattha, she felt joy and admiration for him, and thinking that his family must feel great joy to be with him, she said, "His mother, father and wife must be *nibbuta*, very peaceful." Prince Siddhattha heard her say this, and he thought, "*Nibbuta* is such a wonderful word. I am looking for nibuddha, which is not selfish happiness but true peace. Today I must give up my householder life. Princess Kisāgotamī inspired me with the word *Nibbuta*, so I will give her a gift." So he gave her some jewelry as a gift, which made her feel very happy.

When he arrived at the palace, he had dinner and the finest dancers and musicians were there to entertain him. To please his father, he watched them late into the night, until he fell asleep. Then one by one, everyone started falling asleep. When Prince Siddhattha awoke in the middle of the night, he saw the dancers asleep. Some of them had their mouths open, some had saliva dripping from their lips, some were snoring, and some were grinding their teeth like demons. The dancers who had looked so beautiful now looked so disgusting. He got up and told Channa to secretly prepare his favorite white horse, Kanthaka, for a long journey.

Then he silently went to the bedroom to see his newborn son. Yasodharā and the baby Rāhula were sleeping so peacefully. Yasodharā had the baby cradled in her arms, holding him close to her, and her arm was covering baby Rāhula's face. Prince Siddhattha wanted to see his son's face, but he thought, "If I move her arm, she will awaken, and my concentration will be ruined. I won't have the strength to leave her and become a renunciant. But I will find Enlightenment, and then I will come back to them."

So that night, when he was 29 years old, he left the palace, riding his horse, along with Channa. As he rode away he looked back at his home city, Kapilavatthu, and thought, "I will not return until I have found the end to old age, sickness and death." When he got to the deep Anoma River, the powerful horse Kanthaka jumped over the river.

Prince Siddhattha got off the horse and told Channa, "Please take my jewelry and the horse and go back to the palace. I will become a renunciant. Tell my parents and Yasodharā not to worry, that I have gone to find a way to end old age, sickness and death." Channa said, "Please let me go with you!" But Siddhattha said, "No, when I have found the way to enlightenment, I will return. Then everyone will be happy." With his sword, he cut his hair. As soon as each small bunch of hair was cut, it curled around to the right in a circle and stayed that way. (That is why statues and paintings of the Buddha show his hair as they do.) Channa bowed to Siddhattha, and started to ride back to Kapilavatthu. But as Siddhattha disappeared into the distance, Kanthaka's heart broke with love for Siddhattha, and he died. Channa cried with sorrow, also missing his dear Prince Siddhattha.

Siddhattha saw that his beautiful clothes were not appropriate for a renunciant. A great heavenly being named Ghaṭīkāra, who is a Mahā Brahmā, knew that Siddhattha would become a renunciant, so he brought the eight necessities for a monk: three robes, a bowl, a razor, a needle, a belt, and a water strainer. Siddhattha accepted the gifts from Ghaṭīkāra, and went to meditate in the forest.

Questions after the story:

1. How did Siddhattha feel when he heard that his son was born?
2. What did Princess Kisāgotamī say that inspired him?
3. What did Prince Siddhattha think of the dancers when they were asleep?
4. Why did Prince Siddhattha leave the palace?
5. Why did he not see his son's face before he left the palace?
6. Why do you think Siddhattha did not let Kanthaka and Channa come along too?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Asevanā ca bālānaṃ, paṇditānaṃ ca sevanā, pujā ca pūjanīyānaṃ, etaṃ maṅgalamuttamaṃ."

"Not to follow or associate with the ignorant, associating with the wise, honoring those who deserve honor, this is the best way." (Mahāmaṅgala Sutta)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Prince Siddhattha gave up, "renounced," his family life—he left his wonderful loving wife, his newborn son, his dear parents and all of his friends and relatives. This is not because Yasodharā was ignorant or misbehaved; she was an extremely good person. If he had stayed with them, he could not have become enlightened, to find the way to end the cycle of old age, sickness, death and rebirth. So, even though it was very difficult to leave them, he knew it would be better for him to leave. It was so difficult for him that he knew that if Yasodharā woke up as he was leaving, his love for her would distract him from doing what was best for everyone, and he might not leave.

Sometimes when we like someone, it is difficult to leave that person. We like to be with the person even if it is not good for us. For example, we don't want to leave a friend even if his or her behavior is not good. Sometimes friends whom we thought were nice change, and their behavior gets out of line. For example, they disobey or talk disrespectfully to their parents or teachers, hurt or say bad things about others, lie, bully, act arrogantly, or take others' things without permission. We might make excuses for their behavior because we don't want to lose their friendship. They may be popular, fun, or make us laugh. But when their behavior goes out of line, they are ignorant, they are not being wise. If we associate with them, then we are associating with the ignorant, which Buddha warned us not to do.

But, maybe we think we can be a good example to them, and their behavior will improve. Have you ever

thought like that? Is it a good idea? It is not a good idea. Why did Buddha warn us not to associate with the ignorant? It is because no matter how confident we are that we can be a good example, or that we will not get drawn into misbehavior, the fact is that one person's misbehavior very easily spreads to others who associate with him or her. Adults are very often led into wrong acts, bad talk or bad thoughts by one person's bad influence. So, certainly as young people, it is impossible to follow Dharma if we associate with those who violate Dharma.

If it is difficult to leave a friend who misbehaves, we can remember the example of Prince Siddhattha. We can remember how difficult it was for him to leave his wife and family so that he could do what was best for him, and eventually what was best for everyone. And, making one good decision leads to making other good decisions! Leaving one bad influence makes it easier to leave other bad influences in the future. Then we have a habit of making good decisions.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Make a poster: Each student copies the quotation of Buddha (above) on paper with colored markers or colored pencils. The quotation is then decorated with various art materials, perhaps with a drawing showing how the student will stay away from others who misbehave. The poster can be hung on a wall in the student's room or on the refrigerator at home to remind him or her of this very important teaching.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 6
Self Control

LESSON 6

SELF-CONTROL

Opening chants, meditation, and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever been uncomfortable—too hot, cold, hungry, thirsty, or feeling pain—and there is no way to get rid of the discomfort anytime soon? What did you do, did you complain or did you have self-control?

STORY: THE ASCETIC LIFE

Siddhattha walked to the city of Rājagaha, and in the morning, holding his bowl, he went up to some houses in the city and stood at the door silently. People offered him food and put it in his bowl. Many people seeing him thought he was a deva (heavenly being), because he looked so handsome, young and noble, and he walked very slowly and dignified, like a self-controlled person, with his eyes looking down only a few feet in front of him. After receiving the food, Siddhattha walked to the Pandara Mountain, where he sat down to eat. The food was all mixed together in the bowl, and when he tasted it, he felt sick. He always got the best fancy foods served to him neatly on plates at the palace, and he did not like this mixed up food. He thought, "I wanted to be a renunciant, which means I must eat the food that people offer me. Why am I so repulsed? What is the meaning of this repulsion?" He thought about why he was disgusted with the food, and controlled his thoughts so he could eat it with contentment.

He then looked for a great master of meditation, to learn the way to end suffering, old age and death. He went to the famous teacher Ālāra Kālāma, and told him he wanted to live the holy life in Dharma and discipline. Ālāra Kālāma said, "Venerable one, you may stay here. With the teaching I give, a wise man can realize through direct

experience what I know." Siddhattha soon learned his teachings, and then asked Ālāra Kālāma what he had experienced through direct knowledge with this teaching. Ālāra Kālāma said that it led to nothingness. Siddhattha concentrated well on the teachings and experienced nothingness, and told Ālāra Kālāma, who said, "You are now like me. You can help me teach my students." But Siddhattha thought, "His teachings do not lead to purity, the highest peace, full enlightenment, Nibbāna." So, he left that ashram (hermitage) to find a teacher who could help him to become enlightened.

He went to the famous teacher Uddaka Rāmaputra, and became one of his many students. Siddhattha studied and practiced the system taught by Uddaka Rāmaputra, and when he mastered it, he told his teacher, who then honored Siddhattha by asking him to teach all of his students. But Siddhattha realized that the system he taught did not lead to purity, full enlightenment, Nibbāna, so he left the ashram.

Siddhattha went to a place near Uruvela, a beautiful forest with a river, shade trees, and a village where the villagers might give him food (alms). This was an ideal place, so he decided to stay there. The sons of four of the wise men, and the youngest of the wise men who had seen the marks of a great Dharma teacher on Siddhattha when he was a baby, had come to Uruvela. They were now ascetics, people who live in very harsh conditions so that they can practice self-control, trying to control and purify their minds. The five ascetics knew about the marks on Siddhattha's body indicating that he will be enlightened, and they decided to stay near him so they could get enlightened too.

At first, staying in the forest was frightening. Siddhattha thought that any sound might be a wild animal which could kill him. So he thought deeply about fear and horror, and tried so hard to fight his fearful thoughts with good thoughts that his body sweated. He did many ascetic

practices that were supposed to help control and purify the mind. He practiced holding his breath until he went into a trance, and then until he heard a sound like wind roaring in his ears. He held his mouth, nose and ears until his stomach burned with pain, but it did not purify his mind. He stayed out in the hot sun in the day and endured cold nights without a blanket. He controlled his food so at first he ate only roots, leaves and juice, then only a cup of soup, then he ate only once every 2 or 3 days, then he ate nothing, and then he ate only what dropped into his bowl. After six years of doing these ascetic practices, his body became emaciated (terribly thin) and his muscles started withering away. His ribs showed, his backbone looked like beads along his back, and his eyes were sunken. His skin, even the skin on his head, was wrinkly, his complexion was very unhealthy, and when he touched his stomach, he could feel his backbone.

Someone very powerful and evil was watching him: Māra, a most powerful and frightening demon. Māra did not want people to become enlightened, because then his demon armies would be weakened. So, he was determined to prevent Siddhattha from becoming enlightened. Māra told Siddhattha, "You are thin and pale, near death; why don't you live a religious life making merit by doing rituals? Your path is too difficult." Siddhattha replied calmly, "O Evil One, you came here for your own selfishness. I do not need merit now. I have confidence, determination, understanding, and self-control, so I will have greater concentration and wisdom. Your armies are selfishness, craving, laziness, cowardice, doubt, hatred, stubbornness, seeking fame and gain; for cheap popularity they show off and speak badly of others. Conquering these armies leads to happiness. Death is better than losing the battle against those evils. I meet you in battle, with your armies, so I will not be driven off my path to enlightenment. I will conquer your armies with my wisdom, like an unbaked clay bowl is broken with a stone." Māra went away, and Siddhattha was left alone in peace.

Siddhattha could hardly walk, and he often fell down from weakness. One day when he fell, lying on the ground he thought, "Whatever pain any monk has felt from extreme self-torture cannot be worse than this. But I have not gained wisdom and enlightenment. This only leads to weakness of the body and mind. Is there another way to enlightenment? On the day of the ploughing ceremony when I was young, sitting alone in the shade of the rose -apple tree, I could meditate with happiness. Might that be the way to enlightenment? Yes! It is not possible to meditate happily with a weak, starving body. Suppose I ate some solid food, some boiled rice and bread?" He then ate some boiled rice and bread, and it revived him. The five ascetics saw him eating food, and they thought, "That monk wants a life of luxury, he has failed." So, they deserted him.

Questions after the story:

1. Why didn't Siddhattha like the food given in his bowl?
2. Why did Siddhattha leave his teachers Ālāra Kālāma and Uddaka Rāmaputra?
3. What did Siddhattha do for 6 years in the forest?
4. What is an ascetic?
5. Why did Māra approach Siddhattha?
6. What do you think Siddhattha meant when he spoke of conquering the demon armies? Was he really going to kill some demons in a war? Or was he going to conquer all evil thoughts and prevent them from weakening his mind?
7. What did Siddhattha think about when he fell?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Kāyena saṃvutā dhīrā, atho vācaya saṃvutā, manasā saṃvutā dhīrā, te ve suparisaṃvutā."

"The wise are controlled in action, speech and thought. They are truly well-controlled."

(Dhammapada 234/17:14)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

When Siddhattha was given food that he didn't like, what did he do? What do you do when you are given food you don't like? Siddhattha didn't throw the food away. Instead, he controlled himself and then ate the food with contentment. He learned not to be spoiled and choosy, but to be content with what he had and not complain. He walked slowly in a self-controlled way, looking only a few feet in front of him, instead of walking fast and looking around everywhere, or shuffling along in a lazy way. When Māra approached, Siddhattha was not afraid or angry; he did not shout, but he talked calmly and confidently.

When the body is controlled, or disciplined, then the mind can be more easily controlled for good concentration. Good concentration is important for almost everything we do, not just for meditation, but also for learning in school, or learning anything; for playing sports, playing an instrument, reading, and so forth. If we concentrate well, we learn well, we perform well, and so we also get confidence. How do we behave if we are undisciplined? If we are undisciplined, we are boisterous, aggressive, lazy, or we eat too much, or we do what we want to do rather than what is good for us. When our voice is undisciplined, what does that mean? It means that we shout, speak too much at the wrong time or speak in an unkind or harsh way. When the body and voice are undisciplined, then the mind is uncontrolled, so it is easily distracted and cannot concentrate. Of course, children should play as appropriate for their age, but it should be at the correct time and place and should not be too aggressive. So in this way, self-control is very important for our success in almost everything we do.

Renunciants and monks try to discipline their minds very much so that they can deeply meditate and purify their minds. To control the mind that much, they obey many rules that are only for them, not for laypersons, to control the body, voice and thoughts. That is why Siddhattha did not

look around everywhere when he walked, and did not chat freely with others, but spent time alone in the forest. But Siddhattha also learned that controlling the body in an extreme way, by not eating, not breathing normally or not protecting the body to keep it healthy, is NOT the way to purify the mind. By torturing the body that way, what happens? Both the body and mind become weak.

But at the other extreme, by indulging the body with many comforts and luxuries, what happens? What happens if we eat anything we want at any time? What happens if we watch too much TV? What happens if we don't do much work? What if we don't control our talking? Both the body and mind become uncontrolled and undisciplined.

The Buddha said we should follow the Middle Path—not starving or torturing the body, but not spoiling it with too many comforts.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

"Statue" game: All students except one sit facing the same direction, in a meditation position, perfectly still. The other student walks around them and tries to make each sitting "statue" student move or smile, without touching anyone. For example, he can be silly, joke, wave a hand near them, or pretend to tickle them. If a student moves (smiles, frowns, grimaces, etc.), then he is "out." The last person to be "out" wins.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 7
Effort

Lesson 7

EFFORT

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever had determination to do something, but later you thought that it's too much effort, and you wanted to give up?

Story: Māra's Challenge and Sujātā's Offering

After Siddhattha decided that it is best to keep the body healthy by eating normally, he went daily to the village called Senāni so people would give him alms (food) in his bowl. He was now 35 years old. Now that he started to eat again, his strength and noble beauty returned, and the 32 special marks of a Buddha appeared again on his body.

The chief of the village of Senāni had a daughter, Sujātā, who had wished to get married. She had made a vow (promise) at a big beautiful banyan tree, saying to the tree's deity: "If I marry a good husband and have a son, then I will offer 100,000 gold coins to the deity of this tree every year." Soon thereafter, she got married and had a son. Now she knew she must perform the vow. She fed her cows special food so they would make sweet, rich milk.

When the moon was full in the month of Visākhā in the Springtime, Sujātā ordered the cowherds to milk the cows. As soon as the new cans were placed under their udders, the milk flowed from them immediately! Sujātā stared in wonder. Then she boiled the milk, and large bubbles rose up and turned to the right, and none spilled. Sujātā was thrilled, and she turned to her servant, Puṇṇa, and exclaimed, "Our deity is pleased! Run to the banyan tree and prepare the place for the offering."

Meanwhile, the night before, Siddhattha had five dreams which indicated to him that he would be enlightened that day. Siddhattha found that same big beautiful banyan tree where

Sujātā made the vow. He thought it was a good place to meditate, and he sat under it, with his face radiant, golden and serene, deep in meditation. When Puṇṇa arrived at the banyan tree, she saw Siddhattha sitting there and she thought that was the deity of the tree waiting to receive the offerings. She ran back to Sujātā and told her what she saw. Sujātā was overjoyed, and gave her gifts of beautiful clothes and jewelry. Sujātā took a golden tray worth 100,000 gold coins and put the milk-rice (kiribat) on it, and covered it. She put on a fresh dress, and carried the tray on her head to the banyan tree. Thinking that Siddhattha was the tree deity who she had made the vow to, she placed the tray in Siddhattha's hands, asking him to accept her offerings, and then walked away. Siddhattha said to her, "Sister, what is to be done with this tray?" Sujātā replied, "It is for you." Siddhattha said, "It is of no use for me." Sujātā said, "You may do with it whatever you wish." Siddhattha got up and went to the river to bathe, and then made 49 lumps with the milk-rice, and ate it. He threw the tray into the river, thinking, "It will go upstream against the current if I will be successful in becoming enlightened." The tray traveled far upstream, to where a Black Nāga, a powerful snake deity, received it.

Siddhattha then found a beautiful place near the Nerañjara River and placed a pile of dried grass beneath a Bodhi Tree. He sat cross-legged on the grass under the tree and made a firm determination: "Even if my skin, flesh and blood become dry, I will not leave this seat until I attain Enlightenment, the highest wisdom, Nibbāna, the end of suffering."

Then Māra, hoping to prevent Siddhattha from becoming enlightened, approached Siddhattha at the Bodhi Tree and tried to scare him, telling him that his home town Kapilavatthu had been conquered and his clan, the Sakyans, had been chased away, and showing ghostlike visions of Yasodharā, Devadatta and the Sakyans escaping. Siddhattha did not panic, he did not even worry; he was unmoved. Māra said "It is impossible for you to get enlightened!" Māra was

very angry, and as he approached Siddhattha, he shouted to his demon helpers, "Seize and bind this low-born! He doesn't know he is a worm born as a human being!" He threw a fire-shower at Siddhattha, with black smoke and terribly loud thunder, and shouted, "Siddhattha, how is it that you are in my seat? Get up or I'll tear your heart out!"

Siddhattha calmly looked into the terrible face of Māra, and with great love and compassion looked at Māra as a father looks at his son playing at his feet. Siddhattha said, "I have come to point out death and decay, and help people cross over from this Earthly existence. Your army I will conquer by wisdom, like an unbaked clay bowl broken with a stone. This throne is for me. The Earth is my witness." Siddhattha put his hand to the ground and it shook, and a great noise came from the Earth, and a thunderbolt came roaring through the air. Māra felt terror that he had never known before and ran away.

Questions after the story:

1. Why did Sujātā offer Siddhattha the milk-rice?
2. Why didn't Siddhattha keep the golden tray?
3. What did Siddhattha do when he sat down under the Bodhi Tree?
4. Why did Māra approach Siddhattha?
5. How did Siddhattha look at Māra?
6. What did Siddhattha say he would use to defeat Māra's demon army?
7. Why did the ground shake and thunderbolt come when Siddhattha touched the ground?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Yo ca vassasataṃ jīve, kusīto hīnavīriyo, ekāhaṃ jīvitaṃ seyyo, vīriyamārabhato daḷhaṃ."

"Better than living a lazy life for a hundred years without making effort, is to live for one single day strongly making effort."

(Dhammapada 112/8:13)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Viriya means perseverance, persistent effort, when we determine to do something good and keep trying, struggling, overcoming difficulties and failures, not giving up. Siddhattha had viriya, confidence and determination to keep seeking enlightenment even when he had starved and tortured his body trying to become enlightened, and all his extreme efforts failed. He had viriya and courage even when Māra tried to scare and threaten him to make him give up his effort. Because of his viriya, he had developed good habits and self-control. Instead of getting angry at Māra, how did Siddhattha act? He was calm and compassionate. Instead of getting frustrated that after six *years* of suffering starvation, severe discomfort and pain struggling to be enlightened, he still did not get enlightened, Siddhattha did not get angry and did not give up.

Anger makes us agitated and unable to concentrate, and wastes our energy. After the angry mood ends, we feel more weak and exhausted. If Siddhattha had gotten frustrated and angry that he failed to get enlightened, or gotten angry at Māra, he may not have had the strength to keep trying; he would have given up, or collapsed and died when he was starving himself. When he became healthy again from eating food, he had so much viriya and determination to become enlightened that the golden tray went *up* the river, against the flow, and the ground shook and the thunderbolt came when he touched the ground under the Bodhi Tree.

What are some experiences that you have had with viriya? Learning to ride a bicycle, to swim, to play a musical instrument; memorizing a gatha, or doing a difficult project for school, like a science fair project. We make mistakes, we don't do things perfectly, things go wrong, it's not fun, but we keep trying. Also, it takes a lot of viriya to be able to meditate well. When we overcome problems and failures with our viriya, we gain more courage and confidence. We

also gain more concentration, willpower, and energy to do good things, and so it won't feel so difficult. Then we can do many more good things.

What happens if we don't have viriya? We allow ourselves to be lazy, we don't try very hard, we make excuses and we give up easily. Then, we develop a bad habit of laziness and doing things halfheartedly, and we lose confidence.

We are not exactly like Siddhattha, but when we are trying to do something good and we are having difficulties, we can remember Siddhattha's challenges and failures. So, if we feel lazy, frustrated or angry, we want to avoid doing something we should do, don't want to finish our work, don't try to do it well, what can we do? Remember the strength and confidence Siddhattha had even after he had tried extremely hard and failed. Then we get inspired to keep trying, not to give up. Each time we decide not to be lazy and not to give up, we build up our viriya to become a stronger and more confident person.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Draw a scene from the story with crayons, markers or colored pencils, for example: Siddhattha and Māra, Siddhattha sitting under the tree accepting milk-rice from Sujātā, or Siddhattha throwing the golden tray.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 8
Understand the Path and Goal

LESSON 8

UNDERSTAND THE PATH AND GOAL

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: What is Nibbāna?

STORY: ENLIGHTENMENT

After sitting down under the Bodhi Tree, Siddhattha determined that he would not leave until he attained Enlightenment. He concentrated his mind and meditated deeply until his mind was perfectly calm. He concentrated on breathing. Then in the first part of the night, he remembered his previous lives. In his inner vision he could see his many past lives over eons of time. He knew the way he looked, the food he ate, what pleasures and pains he experienced, the way he died, how he was reborn, what his name was in that life, and the details of so many of his lives.

In the middle part of the night, he developed the "divine eye" that can see the past and future of different beings. He could see that they die and take a new birth according to the good deeds and bad deeds they have done. Depending on their deeds they were pretty or ugly, intelligent or not, happy or unhappy, lucky or unlucky. Depending on how good or bad their deeds were, they were born in heaven, hell, or as animals or humans.

In the last part of the night, he could understand the deepest mysteries and laws of life. He understood how to destroy wrong behavior and suffering. All of his ignorance disappeared. With his pure mind, he suddenly knew the Four Noble Truths, which are: (1) Suffering (*dukkha*) (2) The cause of suffering (*samudaya*) (3) The end of suffering (*nirodha*), and (4) The way to the end of suffering (*magga*). That is, he knew that all living beings feel suffering, that the reason for suffering is craving, and that the end of suffering is Nibbāna. He suddenly knew that the way to the end of

suffering is by these eight factors: right view, right thought, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration. He knew that was the ancient Noble Eightfold Path discovered by all of the past Buddhas from ages ago.

He also realized that he was fully Enlightened, that he reached the goal of life. The first words that came to his mind were: "For many births I was traveling to find the builder of this house, that is, the cause of birth over and over again, which is so painful. I have seen the house builder (the cause of birth), he shall not build the house again (shall not cause rebirth). The roof has been broken. My mind has attained Nibbāna and reached the end of every kind of craving." Siddhattha had now become a Buddha, which means a person who discovers by himself the Dharma, including the Four Noble Truths, and becomes fully Enlightened. He was then known as Gotama Buddha.

Questions after the story:

1. What tree did he sit under on the full moon day of Visākhā, after he ate the milk-rice?
2. What did he concentrate on?
3. What did he remember in the first part of the night?
4. What did he see in the second part of the night?
5. What did he suddenly know in the third part of the night?
6. What is a Buddha?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

Ārogya paramā lābhā, saṇtuṭṭhi paramaṃ dhanaṃ, vissāsaparamā ñatī, nibbānaṃ paramaṃ sukhaṃ.

"Health is the greatest gift and contentment is the greatest wealth. A trustworthy person is the best kinsman, and Nibbāna is the highest bliss." (Dhammapada 204/15:8)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

How would you feel if you did not have any more dukkha, not even the tiniest bit, at all, ever? You would have the most extreme peace and happiness, or "the highest bliss," which is Nibbāna. What causes dukkha? Wanting something and not getting it, or not getting exactly what we want, enough of what we want, when we want it. We want to protect and keep what we like, so we are upset if we lose it. We want to avoid or get rid of discomfort, things, places or people we don't like. All these "wants" make us feel anxious, agitated or unhappy. So dukkha is caused by wanting, also called craving (*taṇhā*). The Buddha says "contentment is the greatest wealth." Contentment means being happy with what we have, not wanting anything. Contentment is the "greatest wealth" because we are most peaceful and happy (our mind is wealthy) when we aren't wanting anything. So, if we don't ever have any craving at all, then we don't ever have any dukkha, and that means we have attained Nibbāna. The Second and Third Noble Truths teach us that the cause of dukkha (suffering) is craving (*taṇhā*) and the end of dukkha is Nibbāna. Nibbāna is not like happiness that we experience, because we know that after the fun comes more dukkha—fun and enjoyment doesn't last very long. With Nibbāna, there is no worry about the extreme happiness stopping, decreasing or becoming boring. There is no disappointment, worry or fear about anything. Nibbāna is also the end of ignorance, because someone who has attained Nibbāna knows the truth of everything, so his mind is "enlightened" with all wisdom, and we say he has attained "Enlightenment." A person who has attained Nibbāna will not be born again after his body passes away, so he will not have to suffer birth, sickness, old age and death ever again.

What does this mean for young people? Should we just forget about Nibbāna because we are not monks and we are not even adults yet? No! A good Buddhist should always

remember the goal, Nibbāna, just like a person driving should remember where he is going, so he doesn't get lost and have to suffer more. And, a Buddhist must know how to reach the goal, that is, by practicing the Eight-Fold Path, just like the driver must know how to get where he is going, by a map or instructions how to get there. So the Eight-Fold Path is the path, the way (*magga*) or the map, to get to Nibbāna. This is the Fourth Noble Truth.

But, do we follow the Eight-Fold Path only so we can eventually get to Nibbāna in the distant future? No, that is not the only reason. We also follow the Eight-Fold Path so we can be happier right now, in this life. How do we feel when we do helpful actions, when we don't harm others, when we speak kindly and honestly, when we think compassionate thoughts toward others, and when we develop good habits? We become happier, more confident, and more peaceful. So we make our future lives better. Siddhattha saw this while he sat under the Bodhi Tree; he saw that the good deeds of a person resulted in a better future birth—with a nice healthy body, intelligent mind, and pleasant things happening in their lives.

Activities to reinforce the lesson

(Choose A or B as appropriate):
A. Students can memorize the elements of the Eight-Fold Path with the following method:

Point to your eyes and say "Right View" (or "Sammā Diṭṭhi")

Put the palm of your right hand on your heart and say "Right Intention" ("Right Thought" or "Sammā Saṅkappa").

Point to your mouth and say "Right Speech" (or "Sammā Vācā").

Raise your hands in front of you and move your fingers in and out and say "Right Action" (or "Sammā Kammanta").

Lower one of your hands on your side and pretend you are carrying a briefcase, and say "Right Occupation" (or Sammā Ājīva").

Move both hands over your head and lower them all the way down and say "Right Effort" [whole mind and body effort] (or "Sammā Vāyāma").

Point to your head and say "Right Mindfulness" (or "Sammā Sati").

Place your hands in front of you with palms up and say "Right Concentration" (or "Sammā Samādhi").

The teacher can demonstrate first a few times, then the teacher does each action and asks students to say the corresponding words until they all say it correctly. Then the teacher asks students to volunteer to demonstrate, one at a time, until each student demonstrates the process.[1]

B. Write the Four Noble Truths neatly on paper, and decorate the paper. Students may write next to each Noble Truth what it means in their own words.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

1. This technique of teaching children to memorize the Eight-Fold Path was presented by Mr. Souksomboun Sayasithsena of Wat Lao Buddhavong of Washington, D.C.

Lesson 9
Gratitude

Lesson 9
GRATITUDE

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: What do you feel grateful (thankful) for in your life?

Story: The First 7 Weeks After Enlightenment

After the Buddha became enlightened, he stayed sitting under the Bodhi Tree for one week. He was feeling the ultimate happiness and peace of enlightenment. He concentrated on the causes and effects (results) of many things. He knew exactly how suffering arises, and how it can end. He knew that everything has a cause, and everything changes; nothing of the world lasts forever. He was very peaceful, he had no disturbing thoughts, and he did not even need to eat.

The second week after his enlightenment, he got up and stood near the Bodhi Tree for seven days, looking at it without moving his eyes, meditating with gratitude to the tree for sheltering him during his enlightenment. The third week, the Buddha became aware that the devas (who are kind, shining beings who live in a heaven-world) did not know whether he was completely enlightened. To show them that he was, he created instantly a golden bridge with jewels on it, and he walked on the bridge for one week. The fourth week, the Buddha instantly created a jeweled chamber with a seat in it, near the Bodhi Tree. He meditated in it for one week, understanding the highest wisdom. A halo made of rays of light surrounded him, with blue light the closest around him, then yellow light a little further out, then red light a bit further, then white, then orange, and then a mix of all of the colors.

The fifth week after his enlightenment, the Buddha walked away from the Bodhi Tree and walked to the Ajapāla

Banyan Tree, where he sat for seven days in deep peaceful meditation. A brahmin walked up to him. A brahmin is a person who was respected as a member of the highest caste, which included many priests. The brahmin walked up to the Buddha and greeted him, and then asked, "What is a brahmin, Master Gotama? What things make a person a brahmin?" The Buddha replied, "A brahmin has no evil about him and is not arrogant. He is pure and self-controlled, perfect in knowledge and living a moral life. He does not want to show off." The brahmin thought about what weaknesses he had, bowed to the Buddha and went away.

Then Māra appeared to the Buddha, and said, "You are alone. Aren't you in grief? Do you have no friends? Do you want friends?" The Buddha replied, "I have gotten rid of the cause of suffering, so I have no desire, no attachments. I am peaceful in meditation." Māra said, "If you think that anything is yours, there is no escape from me." The Buddha said, "Nothing is mine. There is no 'me' or 'mine.'" Māra was disappointed, and left. His three daughters, Taṇhā, Rati and Rāga, saw their father looking upset. They asked, "Why are you upset? We will bring Gotama to you." So they went to the Buddha, and bowed to him, and said, "We will serve you." The Buddha ignored them. They danced and made themselves look very beautiful to tempt him to look at them. But he did not pay any attention to them, so they disappeared.

The sixth week after enlightenment, the Buddha walked to another tree. A big storm came, with big dark clouds, wind and rain. Mucalinda, who is a great royal Nāga, a celestial being in the form of a huge snake, came from his celestial world and wrapped his body around the Buddha. Mucalinda coiled his body around the Buddha's body seven times, and spread the great hoods with his five heads over the Buddha to protect him, thinking, "Let the Buddha not feel any cold, heat, insects, wind, sun or creeping things on his body." After he protected Buddha

from the storm, the sun came out, and Mucalinda unwrapped his coils from the Buddha and changed his form into a brahmin boy, standing in reverence before the Buddha. Thankful for his protection in the storm, Buddha taught him some Dharma, saying, "Being alone is happiness for a person who is contented, who has learned and understood the Dharma. Friendliness to everyone in the world is happiness for a person who does not harm any living beings. Detachment from the world is happiness for a person who does not have desires. But to stop thinking about 'I' is the greatest happiness of all."

The seventh week after enlightenment, the Buddha went from the Mucalinda Tree to the Rājāyatana Tree and stayed there for seven days, meditating and feeling the peace of enlightenment.

At the end of the seventh week after the Buddha's enlightenment, two merchants (salesmen), named Tapassa and Bhalluka, heard a message from a relative who had passed away and been born as a deva. The message was for them to go to the Rājāyatana Tree, where the newly enlightened Buddha was, and offer him rice cake and honey, and they will be blessed with welfare and happiness. So, they went to the Buddha and bowed, and offered the rice cake and honey. The Buddha thought, "The Buddhas do not accept food into their hands. How shall I accept the rice cakes and honey?" Then the devas of the four directions, who were aware of his thought, brought four crystal bowls, and offered them to the Buddha, who then accepted the rice cake and honey into one of the bowls and ate. Then Tapassa and Bhalluka said, "We go for refuge to the Buddha and to the Dharma. From today may the Buddha consider us as his followers."

Questions after the story:

1. Why did the Buddha look at the Bodhi Tree for a week without moving his eyes?
2. Why did the Buddha create the golden bridge?

3. What are the colors of the halo light rays that came from the Buddha (the "Buduras")?
4. Which people and other beings came to the Buddha in the first 7 weeks after he was enlightened?
5. What did the Buddha mean when he said to stop thinking about "I"?
6. How did the Buddha show gratitude to Mucalinda?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"*Gāravo ca nivāto ca, saṇtuṭṭhī ca kataññutā, kālena dhammāsavanaṃ, etaṃ maṅgalamuttamaṃ.*"

"Reverence, humility, contentment, gratitude and listening to the dharma, this is the best way."

(Mahāmaṅgala Sutta)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

What does gratitude mean? Being thankful; for example, being thankful to those who helped us, being thankful for the things that we have, being thankful that we are healthy, that we have a nice family, that we have enough food, that we have good teachers. What happens if someone has no gratitude, if he is ungrateful? He does not appreciate the efforts that people make for him, he just expects them to do things for him and give to him. He does not think of how they feel. So he expects to get what he wants, and when he gets it, he only thinks of his own pleasure. When he doesn't get what he wants, he is unhappy. He loses friends by not appreciating what they do for him. An ungrateful person is not thankful for the fortunate things that he has, such as his wealth, his job, his family, his food, his home. He just thinks that he should have them and also have more and better things. So an ungrateful person is selfish, arrogant and often unhappy.

On the other hand, a grateful person notices all the good things he has, and remembers the good things that people have done for him and given to him. These are happy thoughts! When you have thankful thoughts toward others,

you are feeling mettā (loving-kindness) to them and wishing that they are happy. So, gratitude makes you have happy, kind and wholesome thoughts. Other people like your gratitude toward them, so then you have good friends. Remembering often to be thankful becomes a good habit which keeps you happy.

Sometimes it is easy to forget the good things that we have when we are thinking about what we don't have. For example, there is a story of a person who was miserable that he had no shoes until he saw someone who had no feet. He did not have gratitude that he had a healthy body that can walk, but only thought about what he didn't have – shoes. The Buddha showed us by his example of looking at the Bodhi Tree to be thankful even for the shade of a tree! And he showed his gratitude to Mucalinda for protecting him from the storm, by giving him something extremely valuable—a Dharma teaching. We can think of so many things in our lives that we are lucky to have, or lucky to experience. So, when we find ourselves thinking unhappy thoughts about what we don't have, we can remember to be thankful for what we do have, even the little things.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Each student writes: "I am grateful for . . ." and writes a list of things, people, events, experiences and circumstances that he or she is grateful for. This list can be kept by the student in his or her room to look at when he is feeling unhappy.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 10
Show Gratitude

LESSON 10

SHOW GRATITUDE

Opening chants, meditation, and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: What is the best way to show your gratitude?

STORY: DECIDING TO TEACH

After the merchants Tapassa and Bhalluka became his first followers, the Buddha left the Rajayatana Tree and went back to the Ajapāla Banyan Tree and sat under it. The Buddha thought, "The Dharma that I have discovered is hard to understand; it is for the wise to experience. But people have so many desires and attachments they want to enjoy, that they cannot understand the Dharma. If I taught the Dharma, others would not understand me, and I would get worn out and troubled trying to teach them. So, maybe I will not teach the Dharma." In a brahmā-world, which is a heaven-world for the wisest and noblest beings, was a brahma named Sahampati who in a past life was a monk ordained by a Buddha who lived long ago, named the Buddha Kassapa. Knowing the Buddha's thoughts, Brahmā Sahampati thought, "The world will be lost, totally lost, if the Perfect Fully Enlightened One does not teach the Dharma." He immediately vanished from the brahmā-world and appeared with his palms together before the Buddha, saying, "Lord, teach the Dharma. There are beings with little dust on their eyes [only a little ignorance] who are wasting by not hearing the Dharma. Some of them will get final knowledge of the Dharma. Let them hear the Dharma you have found. O all-seeing Wise One, see the humans who are suffering. Arise, O Victorious Hero, Bringer of Knowledge, and wander in the world. Teach the Dharma, for some, O Blessed One, will understand."

The Buddha felt compassion for all of the suffering beings in the world, and with his divine eye he could see beings who had very little ignorance and those with a lot of ignorance, those who were pure and those who were impure, those who were easy to teach and those who were difficult to teach, just like there are lotuses growing under the water, other lotuses that grow up onto the surface of the water, and other lotuses that grow up out of the water and bloom without getting wet. He decided to teach the Dharma. So, Brahmā Sahampati was happy, bowed and vanished back to the brahmā-world.

The Buddha thought, "Who should I teach first? Who will soon understand the Dharma? My teacher Ālāra Kālāma is wise—he would understand it." But some devas told Buddha that he had died seven days ago. Buddha thought about teaching his other teacher Uddaka Rāmaputta, but the devas said that he had died just last night. Then the Buddha thought about the five ascetics who were very helpful to him for the six years in the forest, and with his divine eye, he could see that they were in the Deer Park near Bārāṇasī, at a place now known as Sārnāth. So, he started traveling to the Deer Park, which is a holy place in India where previous Buddhas had taught the Dharma.

On his way, a monk called Upaka saw him on the road and said "You look so serene, friend, and your skin is clear and bright. Who is your teacher? Whose Dharma do you practice?" The Buddha answered, "I have mastered all, I know all; purified, I have destroyed craving by my own wisdom. I have no teacher, there is no one like me in the world. I alone am enlightened with all craving destroyed. I go now to set the Wheel of Dharma in motion, in a blindfolded world." The monk Upaka then said "May it be so, friend," and went on his way.

When he arrived at the Deer Park, the five ascetics saw the Buddha coming, and agreed, "Here comes the monk Gotama who wanted luxuries and gave up the struggle. We shouldn't bow to him or stand up and receive his bowl and

outer robe, but we can prepare a seat for him." But as soon as the Buddha came close, they couldn't keep their agreement; they took his bowl and when he sat down, they washed his feet. They greeted him, calling him "friend Gotama," but he replied, "Don't address the Perfect One by his name and as 'friend': the Perfect One is fully enlightened. Listen, monks, I shall teach you, and if you practice the teachings, you will realize yourselves directly the goal of the holy life that monks try to reach." The five ascetics said, "Friend Gotama, your difficult ascetic practices did not take you to the goal, and now that you have given up and gone into the luxurious life, how can you have reached any goal?" The Buddha said, "The Perfect One has not given up and fallen into the life of luxury, but is fully enlightened. Monks, have you ever heard me speak like this before?" The five ascetics replied, "No, Lord." Finally the Buddha convinced them, and they listened.

And then the Buddha taught them the first Dharma discourse, which set the Wheel of Dharma in motion. He taught them that monks should avoid the two extremes of luxury and self-torture, both of which are harmful and not noble. The Middle Way avoids these two extremes, and gives knowledge, peace, enlightenment and Nibbāna. He taught them what he discovered when he became enlightened: the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path. He taught the First Noble Truth (*dukkha*), that all of these are suffering: birth, ageing, sickness, death, pain, being with what is disliked, being separated from what is loved, not getting what you want. He taught the Second Noble Truth (*samudaya*), that the cause of suffering is craving, wanting, enjoying things and wanting more. He taught the Third Noble Truth (*nirodha*), the end of suffering happens when wanting and craving (*taṇhā*) is faded away, given up, let go and stopped. If you stop wanting, then you stop the agony of not getting what you want. He taught the Fourth Noble Truth (*magga*), that the way to the end of suffering is the Eightfold Path: right view, right thought, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right

effort, right mindfulness and right concentration. The Buddha explained that to fully understand the Four Noble Truths, one must experience them.

The devas and brahmas in all the heaven-worlds were extremely happy that the Buddha had begun teaching Dharma, that is, he set the Wheel of Dharma rolling, which cannot be stopped by anyone. Their happiness made earthquakes and a great light appear.

While the Buddha was giving this teaching, one of the five ascetics, Venerable Kondañña, fully understood the Dharma that everything that arises must end. The Buddha exclaimed, "Kondañña knows, Kondañña knows!" and from then on, he was known as Aññata Kondañña, which means "Kondañña-who-knows." He had full confidence in the Buddha's teaching, and said "Lord, I wish to become ordained as a monk by you." The Buddha said, "Come, bhikkhu." The word "bhikkhu" means monk. The Buddha said, "The Dharma is well taught. Live the holy life for the complete end of suffering." And that was the way Kondañña became the first Buddhist monk.

After the Buddha taught more Dharma, the other four fully understood that everything that arises must end, and they asked to become monks, and the Buddha ordained them also. The five new monks were very happy, and thrilled to hear him teach. Listening to his teachings, all of their remaining impurities vanished, they had no more desires or craving (taṇhā), so they became Arahants, humans who are fully enlightened and will never take another birth.

Questions after the story:

1. Why did the Buddha at first not want to teach the Dharma?
2. When Brahmā Sahampati knew the Buddha's thoughts, what did he say to the Buddha?
3. What did the Buddha see with his divine eye?
4. Who did the Buddha want to teach first?
5. Why did the monk Upaka talk to the Buddha?

6. What happened when the Buddha first saw the five ascetics?
7. What did the Buddha teach them?
8. Who was the first Buddhist monk?
9. What does "Arahant" mean?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Dhīro ca dānaṃ anumodamāno, teneva so hoti sukhī parattha."

"The wise man rejoices in giving, and by that alone does he become happy hereafter." (Dhammapada 177/ 13:11)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

In the last lesson, we talked about gratitude. How did the Buddha show his gratitude? He stood looking at the Bodhi Tree without moving his eyes for a week, meditating on it with gratitude, and he taught some Dharma to Mucalinda in gratitude for protecting him from the storm. In today's lesson, we heard that Buddha wished to teach the Dharma that he discovered to his teachers and the five ascetics. He thought that they were wise and therefore may be able to understand the Dharma. Do you think there was any other reason? The Buddha remembered how the five ascetics had helped him for the six years in the forest. Maybe he was feeling gratitude for their help, and gratitude to his former teachers for teaching him and letting him stay at their monasteries. The Buddha set an example of not just feeling gratitude, but *showing* our gratitude to those who help us. He gave to Mucalinda and the five ascetics the most valuable thing that he could give them and that they could appreciate. What was that? The Dharma. The five ascetics did not own anything, and they were so happy and grateful for the Buddha's teachings, so in gratitude, what did they give him? They gave him the most valuable thing that they could give and that the Buddha could appreciate: sharing the Dharma in the best way they could, by dedicating their lives as Buddhist monks.

What is the best way to show your gratitude? Sometimes we say "thank you," or we give a gift, a thank-you card, a hug or a smile when we are thankful for something. But what about if we get something very valuable, are those enough? Can we show our gratitude in a bigger way than that? When adults are thankful for their job, they work very hard for their boss. When they hear a monk teach the Dharma very well, because of their gratitude, they serve the temple in many ways, like bringing food, helping the monks, cleaning the temple, and giving donations. What very valuable things are you grateful for? Your parents' hard work in taking care of you, and your teachers' hard work preparing the class for you—your teachers at school, music teachers, dance teachers, scout masters. You can be thankful to your parents that you are happy, healthy and intelligent, and to your teachers that you are gaining knowledge and skill. What can you give them to show your gratitude? They appreciate when you learn well from them, when you show interest in what they teach, when you practice what they teach, and when you are respectful, obedient, patient, polite, and helpful. So, you can give then your attention, respect, obedience, help, and best efforts in practicing what they teach.

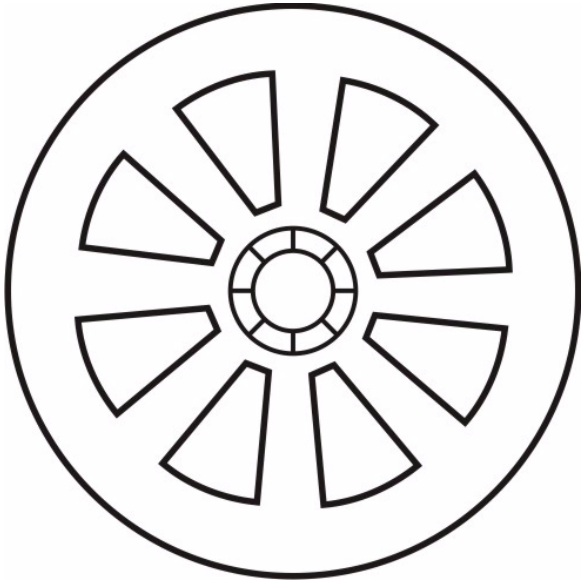
What else do you have that is very valuable that you can be grateful for? The Dharma! How can we show gratitude for having such a precious and special teaching? By *practicing* the Dharma – for example, by showing mettā (loving-kindness) to all beings, by being kind to them and helping them however we can. That means we have to *remember* to be helpful, be *aware* of how we can help, and then offer help. Also, we can brighten someone's day by just smiling! People love to see a child's smile. Sometimes people are unhappy, lonely or stressed out, and when they see you smile, it makes them feel appreciated. They remember it and feel happier. Feeling thankful for our good fortune, we can share our happiness, making others happier, with just a smile or kind words or help. It also makes *us* happy knowing that we are giving to others.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Each student traces or rubs the side of a crayon around a cardboard cut-out of the Buddhist Wheel on poster paper, then labels one element of the Eight-Fold Path (i.e., "Right View") on each spoke of the Wheel. Then students decorate it, and display it at home where the family can see it. For example, they can hang it on the refrigerator or frame it and hang it on the wall. By bringing the Dharma Wheel home and displaying it, students show their gratitude to family members by giving them a reminder of the valuable Dharma.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!



Lesson 11
Humility

Lesson 11
HUMILITY

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Did you ever think, "I'm better than he (she) is"?

Story: Yasa and the Kassapas

An extremely wealthy young man named Yasa was listening to his lady musicians one evening in his palace, and he fell asleep. When he awoke, he saw them asleep with their instruments in their hands. One had untidy hair, one was drooling and others were mumbling in their sleep, and they looked so disgusting, like corpses, that Yasa exclaimed, "This is horrible," and left his palace. The doors and gates were opened by unseen celestial beings who knew what was going to happen and wanted to make sure he would become a monk. He walked to the Deer Park, where the Buddha saw him. Yasa said, "It is horrible." The Buddha said, "This is not horrible. Come Yasa, sit down. I will teach you the Dharma." Yasa went to the Buddha and bowed, and the Buddha taught him about giving, virtue, heaven-worlds, the danger, pride and impurity of enjoying worldly things, and the blessings from being a renunciant. The Buddha saw that Yasa's mind was ready, and taught him the Four Noble Truths. Yasa understood fully that everything that arises must end.

When Yasa's mother could not find him at the palace, his father followed his son's footprints and went to the Deer Park. The Buddha made Yasa invisible, and the father asked whether the Buddha had seen his son. The Buddha told him, "Sit down, and maybe while you are sitting here you will see Yasa sitting here too. The Buddha began teaching Dharma to Yasa's father, who then fully understood the Dharma, and humbly took refuge in the Buddha, Dharma

and Sangha: "*Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi, Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi, Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi.*" He was the first person to take refuge in the Triple Gem. Then he saw his son Yasa sitting there, and said, "Yasa, your mother is sad and upset. Go to your mother." The Buddha said, "If your son has seen the Dharma as you have, would he be able to go back to the palace life? That is what Yasa has done; he cannot go back to what he has left behind and enjoy the home life." The father said, "It is a great gain for Yasa that he has given up clinging and purified his heart. Lord, please accept today's meal from me, with Yasa as your attendant monk."

Yasa then asked to be ordained, and the Buddha ordained him simply as he did the five ascetics. When the Buddha and Yasa went to his parents' house for lunch, Yasa's family and friends heard and fully understood the Dharma. The men asked to become ordained, and became Buddhist monks and Arahants. Now there were a total of 60 Arahants, and the Buddha told them, "Go and wander for the welfare and happiness of many, out of compassion for the world, and teach the Dharma. There are some who have only a little ignorance who would be lost if they don't hear the Dharma, and they will understand it." He told them to ordain men who wish to be ordained by having their hair and beard shaved off, putting on a robe like Buddha's robe, bowing to the Arahant and taking refuge in the Triple Gem.

The Buddha went to Uravela where three ascetics who were brothers were living, all named Kassapa, with a total of 1000 students, all with long matted hair. The Buddha asked one of the three, "Kassapa, if you don't mind, I would like to spend one night in your fire chamber." Kassapa said, "I don't mind, but there is a savage royal nāga there with supernatural powers. He is terribly poisonous and can kill you." A nāga is a celestial being in the form of a snake. The Buddha said, "Maybe he won't destroy me, so allow me to stay there," and he went to the fire chamber and sat meditating. The nāga was angry seeing him there and

produced smoke, blowing it at him, and then fire. The Buddha produced smoke, and then fire, too, but did not injure the nāga.

In the morning, the Buddha put the nāga in his bowl and showed it to Kassapa, who thought, "The great monk is very mighty and powerful. But he is not an arahant like me." During the night, four powerful devas, lighting up the forest, went to visit the Buddha and sat like pillars of fire in four corners around him. Kassapa saw it and he thought again, "The great monk is very mighty and powerful. But he is not an arahant like me." The next two nights, Sakka, the King of the Devas, and Brahmā Sahampati came to the Buddha, and Kassapa saw them, and again he thought, "The great monk is very mighty and powerful. But he is not an arahant like me." Then when Kassapa had a huge crowd coming for a fire ceremony, he thought, "If the great monk does some miracle that these people see, he will become famous and I will not be so famous. If only the great monk were not to come tomorrow." The Buddha heard his thoughts and stayed away. Then next day when Kassapa asked him why he didn't come, and the Buddha told him, he again thought, "The great monk is very mighty and powerful. But he is not an arahant like me." The Buddha needed to wash a rag, and Sakka came and scooped out a pond for it to be washed and set down a large stone to scrub it with, and a deva living in a tree bent a branch for him to hang the rag to dry. The next morning, Kassapa saw the pond, stone and bent branch, and asked the Buddha about it, and the Buddha told him, and again Kassapa thought, "The great monk is very mighty and powerful. But he is not an arahant like me." One day, the monks with matted hair could not split the logs they needed for their fires. They thought it was so strange that it must be the Buddha's miraculous powers. The Buddha asked Kassapa, "Should the logs be split?" and when Kassapa answered yes, five hundred logs split instantly. Many more miraculous incidents happened, including a huge rainstorm and flood

which the Buddha held back all around him so he did not get wet, and Buddha rising up in the air and into a boat. Seeing these miracles, Kassapa had the same thought.

Finally the Buddha thought, "He will go on forever thinking like this. Suppose I give him a shock." So he said, "Kassapa, you are not an arahant nor are you on the way to becoming one. You are not doing anything to become an arahant." Kassapa bowed with his head at the Buddha's feet and asked to be ordained. Thereafter, the Buddha ordained him, his two brothers and their thousand students, who all shaved their heads and became his students.

Questions after the story:

1. What kind of lifestyle did Yasa have before he met the Buddha?
2. How did Yasa's father feel about Yasa becoming a monk?
3. What kind of lifestyle did the three Kassapas have before they met the Buddha?
4. What was in Kassapa's fire chamber?
5. What did Kassapa think when the Buddha showed him the nāga in the bowl?
6. Why would Kassapa think that he was an arahant, and greater than the Buddha?
7. What made Kassapa change his mind?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"*Sujīvam ahirikena kākasūrena dhaṃsinā, pakkhandinā pagabbhena saṇkiliṭṭhena jīvitam*."

"Easy is life for the shameless one who is as impudent as a crow, is backbiting and forward, arrogant and corrupt." (Dhammapada 244/18:10)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Kassapa thought he was an arahant because he had lived for so long as an ascetic in the forest. But he could not recognize the Buddha's greatness, even though he saw the Buddha's

powers. Kassapa did not want to notice the greatness of others because of his pride in his own accomplishment, his arrogance, his conceit; he thought he was better than everyone else. When did he start having humility? He did not have humility until the Buddha showed him many powers and finally told him directly that he was not an arahant. Kassapa is an example of too much pride, or arrogance. Yasa and his father were very wealthy and successful – did they become arrogant? No, they did not become arrogant; they were very humble when they met the Buddha. They are an example of **humility**, not letting success cause arrogance.

What if we have a talent, or we are good at doing something, shouldn't we be proud of ourselves? We notice when we are good at something, that we got a better score, that we are faster, more skilled, or know more than someone else. We get attention and rewards when we do something well, which makes us happy. The world is full of competition, where we get rewarded when we do better than others. The problem arises when we focus too much on comparing ourselves to others, when we often try to prove that we are better than someone else, when we show off, when we think we know everything better, or when we think that we are a better person than the other. These feelings lead to being blinded by pride like Kassapa so that we don't want to notice or admit the success of others. For example, if someone wins, we think he cheated, that others helped him or the score was unfair. Or, if we see someone getting attention for doing something well, we try to find something bad about the person. These feelings also lead to anger, jealousy and hatred. Then we may say bad things about them (called "backbiting"), insult them or act arrogantly toward them. We may act "impudent as a crow," as if we are great and they are not, by ignoring them or being disrespectful. Another problem is, if we think we know everything better than others, we can't learn from others.

If we have a talent, we do well at something, or we have something special, how can we avoid becoming arrogant? By developing humility, remembering that everyone has their own talents and skills, that everyone experiences successes and failures in life, that we have good days and bad days, that we are far from perfect, and that other people have helped us be successful. We can have good thoughts like: "I know about this, but there are many things I don't know," "I may be talented in this, but everyone has their own talents," "I may be intelligent, but I have much more to learn," "I feel thankful that my parents helped me," "I may have this right now, but I won't have it forever. Nothing is permanent," "I may look beautiful right now, but beauty is impermanent and not nearly as important as a pure mind." It is also better to compare ourselves with the way we were before than to compare ourselves with others. For example, it is better to think that we have improved rather than thinking that we did better than someone else.

Activity to reinforce the lesson: (next page)

Students consider whether the answers describe how they might think or act, then circle the answer that is the most noble way to think. When all students are finished, teachers then discuss the different answers, explaining why one is humble and how other answers are, or could be, arrogant, competitive, falsely humble, or neutral.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

ATTITUDE TEST

Consider whether the answers describe how you might think or act, then circle the answer that is the most noble way to think.

1. When I get a toy that I really like, I:
   (a) show it to my friends so they can see it
   (b) show it to my friends so they can share it
   (c) share it and remember that it will not always keep me happy
2. When I get an excellent score on a difficult test, I:
   (a) somehow let other students know my score
   (b) think about how I have improved my study habits
   (c) find out what other students' scores were
3. When I get an award, I:
   (a) think about all the people who helped me and taught me
   (b) want to tell my friends about it
   (c) know I deserved it
4. When I win or do well in a competition, I:
   (a) look forward to the next competition and want to win that, too
   (b) remember that everyone has different talents, we all win some and lose some
   (c) pretend it was no big deal
5. When I know I am good at doing something, I:
   (a) keep practicing it so I can improve
   (b) want to teach it to others
   (c) am thankful to those who helped me learn and I want to teach it to others
6. When others admire me and like my company, I:
   (a) think that I am more popular than someone I know
   (b) try to become more popular
   (c) know that popularity is just temporary, not as important as having good character

Lesson 12
Avoid Jealousy

LESSON 12

AVOID JEALOUSY

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever felt jealous when a friend wanted to be with someone else rather than with you?

STORY: MOGGALLĀNA AND SĀRIPUTTA

After the Buddha ordained the Kassapas and their 1000 students, they went with the Buddha to Rājagaha. The King of Magadha, King Bimbisāra, along with 120,000 people of the brahmin caste in his kingdom, came to visit the Buddha who instructed them in the Dharma. Most of them, including the king, fully understood the Dharma when they heard it, and all of them became followers of the Buddha. The king invited the Buddha and bhikkhus (monks) for breakfast the next day. After they ate, the king thought, "Where could the Buddha stay that is quiet and not too far from the town or too near?" He offered the Buddha and his Sangha (community of monks) the Bamboo Grove, Veluvana, which became the first Buddhist monastery.

Also staying in Rājagaha at that time was a wandering monk named Sañjaya with his 250 students. The two highest level students, Sāriputta (also called Upatissa) and Moggallāna (also called Kolita), had made a promise to each other that the first one to reach the Deathless (knowing the Truth and being released from the cycle of birth and death) would tell the other. One morning, one of the Buddha's monks, Venerable Assaji, went into Rājagaha with his bowl to get food (alms). He walked very gracefully, always looking down. Sāriputta saw him and thought Ven. Assaji must be an arahant.

After Ven. Assaji gathered his food, Sāriputta said to him, "Friend, you look serene and your skin is clear and

bright. Who is your teacher? Whose Dharma have you learned?" Ven. Assaji replied, "The Great Monk from the Sakyan clan is my teacher, and it is his Dharma that I learn." Sāriputta asked, "What does he teach?" Ven. Assaji humbly said, "I have only recently become a monk, friend, so I cannot teach you the Dharma in detail. The Perfect One has told us the cause of all things that arise, and what causes things to end." Sāriputta then fully realized that everything that arises must end.

Sāriputta went to his friend Moggallāna, who said to Sāriputta, "You look serene and your skin is clear and bright. Is it possible that you found the Deathless?" Sāriputta said, "Yes, I have found it," and told him what Ven. Assaji said. Moggallāna then also fully realized that everything that arises must end. He said, "Let us go to the Buddha. He is our teacher." Sāriputta said, "But friend, these 250 wandering monks are depending on us. We should tell them, and they can do as they like." They told the students, who said that they depended on Sāriputta and Moggallāna, so they also would go to the Buddha.

Sāriputta and Moggallāna then went to Sañjaya and told him what they were going to do. Sañjaya said, "Friends, don't go, let us three guide this community together." But Sāriputta and Moggallāna had decided to go to the Buddha, so they went with the 250 students to the Bamboo Grove where the Buddha and his Sangha was. Sañjaya was so upset that he felt that hot blood was gushing from his mouth.

The Buddha saw Sāriputta and Moggallāna coming in the distance, and said, "Here come these two friends. They will be my chief disciples, an auspicious pair." When they arrived, Sāriputta and Moggallāna bowed to the Buddha and asked to be ordained, and he immediately ordained them. A few days later, they became arahants.

By now, many well-known men in Magadha had become Buddhist monks. Some people did not like the men to leave their families. They thought that Buddha was causing women not to have husbands or children because

the men had become monks. When they saw the bhikkhus, they made fun of them, saying "Gotama the monk came to Magadha and led away all of Sañjaya's men; who will he lead away today?" When the bhikkhus told the Buddha about it, the Buddha said, "This will not last long, only seven days, and after seven days it will go away. When they say that, tell them 'Led by Dharma they are great heroes and Perfect Ones; when they are led by Dharma, where is the reason for jealousy?'" When the people mocked the bhikkhus again, the monks said what the Buddha told them to say. Then the people began to think, "The Sakyan monks lead by Dharma, it seems, not against Dharma." After seven days, they stopped mocking the bhikkhus.

Questions after the story:

1. What did Sāriputta notice about Venerable Assaji?
2. Why did Sāriputta and Moggallāna decide that the Buddha is their teacher?
3. How did Sañjaya feel when all of his students left to go to the Buddha?
4. What does "chief disciples" mean?
5. What does "auspicious" mean?
6. Do you think that the bhikkhus felt jealous when the Buddha announced that Moggallāna and Sāriputta will be his chief disciples? Why or why not?
7. Why did people make fun of the bhikkhus?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Paravajjānupassissa, niccaṃ ujjhānasaññino, āsavā tassa vaḍḍhanti, ārā so āsavakkhayā."

"He who seeks another person's faults, who is ever critical of others—his pain grows. He is far from the destruction of the pain."(Dhammapada 253/18:19)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Sañjaya was so upset that he felt like hot blood was gushing from his mouth when he lost his students. If they

had all suddenly died, do you think he would have felt the same way? If they died, he might feel sad, lonely and would miss them. But instead, he felt severe mental pain. He did not want them to leave, but he did not want to go with them to the Buddha. He probably felt that his students belonged to him, and he could not stand to see them go to another teacher whom they preferred rather than being with him. He did not want them to pay attention to another teacher and not to him. This is jealousy, a feeling that "he belongs to me, not to you," "get away- she is *my* friend, not yours!" or "don't pay attention to them, pay attention to me!" A truly holy person who is not jealous probably would have gone with his students to see the Buddha. Sañjaya was an example of a jealous person.

How do you think the bhikkhus felt when the Buddha, before even meeting Sāriputta and Moggallāna, said that they would be his chief disciples? Other bhikkhus may have wanted to be the special student of the Buddha, feeling "he's *my* teacher, he pays special attention to me." They may have not wanted him to give special attention to Sāriputta and Moggallāna. They could have felt jealous. But, if they understood the Dharma very well, they would not feel jealous.

Who else was jealous in the story? The people who thought the men should be married rather than become monks. They may have thought "These are *our* men, and the Buddha is stealing them away from us." So, they criticized the Buddha, hoping that he would feel bad about it and then leave their men alone.

Has a friend ever ignored you and become close friends with someone else? That happens to almost everyone at some time in life. Maybe we thought "What is so great about him (or her)?" Maybe we felt rejected; we don't like to think that we are not good enough, or inferior to the other person. So, we may have quickly tried to find out that the other person is not so great: we watched that person, talked to others about him or her, and tried to find out all the bad

things about him or her. In other words, we were "seeking another person's faults." Because of our jealousy, we may have had many negative thoughts about that person. We may have criticized, spoken unkindly or acted arrogantly to him or her. We may have said bad things about him or her.

How do you feel when a brother or sister gets more attention from your parent or other family member than you get? Have you ever felt jealous? When we feel jealous, we may criticize our brother or sister, or we may tell our parents about his or her misbehavior, hoping that we will then get more attention.

Do we really feel better when we criticize someone? The Buddha tells us that seeking another person's faults (noticing something bad, weak, ugly, or ignorant in a person), and being critical of others, increases our mental pain. Then why would we do this? Because we also cannot stand the pain of jealousy. When we are rejected and someone else gets all the attention, it hurts. We don't want to think that person is better than we are. We think that by criticizing that person, we make ourselves seem better than him or her, so then we will feel better about ourselves. But does it really make us any better? No, it makes us worse. We waste time trying to find faults, we worry if we don't find faults, we may even try to find faults that don't exist. We then develop a bad habit of finding fault, criticizing others. This increases our mental pain, makes the pain grow.

Knowing this, we can decide not to find fault, not to criticize, and just let friends go if they want to. We can find another friend, especially if we have good character—which includes not criticizing or saying bad things about others! Good people will like us more when we are happy, kind and peaceful, so then it is very easy to find really good friends. Similarly, we don't need to criticize our brother or sister to get attention; we will impress our parents more by our good character than by criticizing.

How can we stop criticizing and looking for faults? By noticing when we do it, and then quickly thinking of some

good things about the person instead.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

List of Criticisms and Praises

Students write the lesson's quotation of the Buddha at the top of a piece of paper, and then write, "Think and speak praises, not criticisms."

Underneath, draw a vertical line down the middle of the paper, making two columns. Title the left column "Criticisms" and in that column, list some typical criticisms against another person (for example, "talks too much"). Title the right column "Praises" and in that column, list typical phrases of admiration about another person (for example, "talks about interesting things").

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 13
Diligence

Lesson 13
DILIGENCE

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever wondered, "If I am really dedicated to Dharma, will I still have a normal life and fit in with my friends?"

Story: Return to Kapilavatthu

King Suddhodana heard that his son, who now had become the Buddha, was in Rājagaha, so he sent a message for his son to come back home to Kapilavatthu. The Buddha walked for two months with thousands of bhikkhus until they finally arrived in Kapilavatthu. Many people of Kapilavatthu were proud and did not feel like worshiping him. The Buddha knew this, so he made jets of fire and jets of water spray out from his arms and legs at the same time—this was known as the "Twin Miracle." When the people saw his miraculous power, they were convinced that he was indeed enlightened, and King Suddhodana and others bowed to him.

In Kapilavatthu, the Buddha and his monks went as usual to houses, and stood silently at the door holding their bowls for food. When King Suddhodana heard about it, he became annoyed and went to the Buddha and said, "Why do you disgrace me, son? Why are you begging for food? Why don't you take food in the palace?" The Buddha explained, "I am not putting you to shame, this is our custom." The king said, "What do you mean, 'our custom'? No one in our family had to beg for food." The Buddha replied, "That is not the custom of the royal family. It is the custom of the Buddhas. All former Buddhas lived by receiving food like this." The king then invited the Buddha to the palace for lunch.

When the Buddha came to the palace for lunch, he taught the Dharma by telling about one of his past births. Hearing this, the king became an anāgāmi, which is a person who has attained the third level to enlightenment, who has such purity and wisdom that he would never take another birth as a human or in lower worlds. His queen, the sister of the Buddha's mother, became a sotāpanna, which is a person who has attained the first level of enlightenment or "stream entry," who has such purity and wisdom that she would never be born in a lower world, and would live only a maximum of 7 lives as a human or in a heaven-world until she reaches enlightenment.

The Buddha's relatives and friends all came to see him, except Yasodharā, who was in her room, thinking, "He is now a Buddha. Should I go to him? If I have any virtues, then he will come here and I will show him my reverence." The Buddha asked where Yasodharā was and gave his bowl to the king, who told him that she was in her room. The Buddha went to her room with the king, Ven. Sāriputta and Ven. Moggallāna, telling them, "Let her respect me as she likes. Say nothing." Yasodharā went to him and bowed, holding his feet and placing her head on his feet. The Buddha kept quiet. Then she sat down. The king said, "When she heard that you wore orange robes, took only one meal per day, and avoided high seats, garlands and perfumes, she did the same. When relatives offered to support her, she would not even look at anyone, so virtuous was my daughter-in-law." The Buddha said, "Not only in this birth, but in a past birth, she protected me and was devoted and faithful to me," and he told the story of that birth.

The queen, the Buddha's aunt, had one son, the Buddha's half-brother, named Nanda. Everyone in the palace was getting ready for his marriage in a couple of days. When the Buddha got up to go back to the park, he gave his bowl to Nanda to hold. Nanda did not know what to do with the bowl, so he just followed the Buddha, waiting

for him to take back his bowl. As the Buddha left the palace, with Nanda following him, Nanda's bride called out to Nanda, "Come back soon, Prince." When they arrived at the park where the Buddha and his monks were staying, the Buddha asked him, "Would you like to leave the householder's life and become a monk?" Nanda was very much looking forward to his marriage, but he greatly admired the Buddha and did not want to be disrespectful. So he said "Yes," and the Buddha ordained him.

But Nanda kept thinking about his beautiful bride waiting for him to come back. He was very unhappy, and the other monks noticed that and told the Buddha. The Buddha then went to Nanda and showed him the body of a female monkey which had been burned. It was a very ugly sight. Then the Buddha showed Nanda some devas. Nanda thought that the devas were the most beautiful and happy sight he ever saw, and wished to be with them. The Buddha asked him, "Which are more beautiful, your bride or these devas?" Nanda replied, "My bride is like the burnt monkey compared to these devas." The Buddha said, "If you follow the Dharma as I teach, then you can be with them." Nanda then became happy being a monk, and he learned and practiced the Buddha's teachings very carefully.

On the seventh day after his arrival, the Buddha went again to his father's palace for lunch. Prince Rāhula, the son of the Buddha and Yasodharā, was now seven years old, and he had never seen his father. When the Buddha was at the king's palace, Yasodharā showed Rāhula the Buddha, with all the monks, and said, "That is your father, Rāhula. Go and ask for your inheritance, the property and wealth which a father gives to his son." Prince Rāhula walked up to the Buddha and said, "Even your shadow is pleasing to me, Bhante." The Buddha got up and went away, so Prince Rāhula followed him and said, "Give me my inheritance, Bhante." Rāhula asked again, and the third time he asked, the Buddha said, "I will give you the greatest wealth. Money is not the greatest wealth. Truth is the greatest wealth. Being

ordained as a monk you can find the Truth." The Buddha then asked Ven. Sāriputta to ordain little Prince Rāhula to be a monk.

Questions after the story:

1. Why did the people of Kapilavatthu not immediately bow to the Buddha when they saw him?
2. Why was the king annoyed when the Buddha went to houses to receive food?
3. What do "anāgāmi" and "sotāpanna" mean?
4. What did the king tell the Buddha about Yasodharā?
5. Why do you think the Buddha gave Nanda his bowl?
6. Why was Nanda unhappy?
7. How did the Buddha convince Nanda to be happy as a monk?
8. What did the Buddha give to his son Rāhula?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"*Appamādaratā hotha, sacittamanurakkhatha, duggā uddharathattānaṃ panke sattova kuñjaro.*"

"Delight in diligence! Guard well your thoughts. Pull yourself out of the mud of evil, just as an elephant pulls himself out of the mud." (Dhammapada 327/23:8)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

The Pali word "*appamāda*" means diligence, dedication, and alertness; doing something carefully with great interest, attention, effort and energy. If we play a sport, we play it with dedication—we love the sport, so we give it a lot of our attention and time. We are diligent in our practice of the sport. What does that mean? We listen carefully to the teacher or coach, we remember well and practice what he taught, we learn how to improve our skills, and we practice regularly and often and with all our effort. Then we become highly skilled in the sport.

The Buddha taught that we should practice Dharma in the same way, with great interest, attention, effort and energy.

How do we do that? We listen carefully to Dharma talks, we read about Dharma when we get a chance, we remember the teachings well, we remember to apply them every day, we meditate to train our mind, we learn how to improve our practice of Dharma, and we put all of our effort into it.

This is easy to say, but very difficult to do, like an elephant trying hard to pull himself out of the mud. Many people find that their friends are not so dedicated to the Dharma, or don't know much about it, so they keep their Dharma practice a secret from their friends. Have you ever felt embarrassed to bow in reverence, to meditate, or to be seen doing religious activities? Would you tell a friend that you are going to the temple? Do you mind being seen wearing traditional clothes that are not "in style"? Do you stay away from kids who don't act according to Dharma? Do you feel that if you do these things, you won't "fit in" with your friends and classmates?

The Buddha was not embarrassed to go to houses for donations of food, even though he knew that did not at all "fit in" with his family and childhood friends. They thought going to houses for food was only for poor beggars. But fitting in with the Dharma of the Buddhas, being dedicated to the custom of the Buddhas, was more important to him. Even Yasodharā, living in a palace, did not care to "fit in" with her friends, because it was more important to her to become dedicated to Buddhist practices like the monks, wearing orange robes, eating only once per day, and not wearing jewelry or perfumes.

Nanda was not ready to be so dedicated to Dharma; he wanted to get married and enjoy a wealthy family life. But the Buddha knew how important it was to practice Dharma with appamāda early in life, so he had to convince Nanda, in a way that he could understand, that there are much more wonderful things than just wealth and family. How did he do that? He showed Nanda the burnt monkey and the devas. The Buddha showed how important it is to be dedicated to Dharma even when we are very young, not only by

ordaining Nanda when he was about to be married, but also by ordaining little Prince Rāhula when he was just 7 years old.

Why must we be dedicated to Dharma when we are so young? Just like we must train and practice a lot over a long time to become skilled in a sport, we must train and control our mind, our mouth, and our actions to become skilled in Dharma. We never know what will happen in our lives. If we have not done meritorious deeds in our early life, then we may not be so lucky in the future. We get involved in school and other activities, and as adults we get involved in our jobs, our children and responsibilities. If we have not learned gradually to control our mind, it is more difficult to start later on in life. Then we are like a weak elephant who can't pull himself out of the mud.

Here is an example. What happens if we eat a lot of junk food when we are young? We get a habit of unhealthy eating. What happens then? When we are older we get overweight or illnesses. If we learn to eat healthy food when we are young, then it is easier to eat healthy food and stay healthy when we are older. How does that happen? By developing a good habit of healthy eating.

Similarly, if we are selfish, speak unkindly and think bad thoughts when we are young, what happens? We get bad habits, we don't think about doing merit, and then it is very difficult to change for the better when we are older. Then we are stuck in the "mud of evil" like the Buddha says. But if we make merit and learn to control our actions, mouth and mind when we are young, then what happens? It is easier to make even more merit and control our actions, mouth and mind even better when we are older. The merit and self-control will give us great happiness, peace and wisdom in the future.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Students draw a picture of an elephant pulling himself out of mud, and color with crayons, colored pencils or markers.

Then students write today's quotation of the Buddha neatly on the picture, first in pencil and then writing over it in marker or crayon.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 14
Avoid Possessiveness

LESSON 14

AVOID POSSESSIVENESS

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: If we own many nice things, will that make us happy?

STORY: BHADDIYA THE HAPPY MONK

After the Buddha came to Kapilavatthu, many princes of the Sakya clan became Buddhist monks. But two princes who were brothers, Mahānama and Anuruddha, had not. They were living in their palaces, enjoying entertainment. Mahānama one day said to Anuruddha, "Many Sakyan princes have become monks with the Buddha as their teacher, but no one in our family has. I wonder whether I should become a monk, too. What do you think?" Anuruddha said, "I have three palaces and all the comforts I want. I cannot become a homeless monk. You go be a monk." Mahānama said, "Let me tell you about household life when you become an adult. You must plough the field, plant the seeds, water the plants, drain away the extra water, pull out the weeds, cut and harvest the plants, gather and stack them, remove the straw, remove the chaff, sift it, store it, and then start all over again." Anuruddha said, "When is the work finished? When do we relax and enjoy what we have earned?" Mahānama said, "The work never finishes. There is no end to it. Our grandparents died before their work was done. I am going to become a monk."

After hearing that, Anuruddha went to his mother and said, "Mother, I want to become a monk. Please give me your permission." His mother said, "You two sons of mine are so dear and precious to me. If you die, I would lose you but I could not do anything about it. But why should I give permission to leave me when you are still alive?" When he asked again, she said, "If Bhaddiya the royal Sakyan

becomes a monk, then you may do so too." She said that because she knew that Bhaddiya, who was the governor and a friend of Anuruddha, would not want to be a monk. Anuruddha went to his friend Bhaddiya, and said, "I can only become a monk if you become a monk also." Bhaddiya said, "You go become a monk when you want to." Anuruddha pleaded, "Come, let's both go away from the householder's life and become monks." Bhaddiya stubbornly said, "I can't. I would do anything else for you, but I can't do that. You go become a monk."

When Anuruddha told him what his mother said, then Bhaddiya told him, "Wait seven years. At the end of seven years, both of us can become monks." Anuruddha said, "Seven years is too long, I can't wait seven years." Bhaddiya suggested six years, then five years, four years, and so on but Anuruddha would not wait that long. Finally Bhaddiya and Anuruddha agreed to wait seven days to become monks. On the seventh day, two cousins of the Buddha named Ānanda and Devadatta, and two other princes and Upāli the barber went along with Anuruddha and Bhaddiya to become monks.

When they arrived and greeted the Buddha, the princes said, "We are proud Sakyans. Upāli the barber has attended on us for a long time. Let him be ordained first so we can bow in reverence to him, and our Sakyan pride will be humbled." So the Buddha ordained Upāli, the princes bowed to Upāli, and then Buddha ordained the princes.

During the rainy season, the monks learned Dharma and practiced meditation, and Ven. Bhaddiya gained great wisdom. Ven. Anuruddha gained the divine eye like the Buddha, so he could see what others cannot see. Ven. Ānanda became a sotāpanna, and Ven. Devadatta got some superhuman powers.

But Ven. Bhaddiya started doing something peculiar. Whenever he went into the forest, under a tree or in an empty room, he constantly exclaimed, "Oh, happiness! Oh happiness!" Some bhikkhus could not understand this

behavior and told the Buddha, "He must be unsatisfied with the monk's life, or maybe he is remembering his former position as a ruling prince." The Buddha asked Ven. Bhaddiya about it. Ven. Bhaddiya said, "Bhante, when I was a royal prince, there was a guard inside and outside the palace, inside and outside the city, and inside and outside the district. Although I was so guarded and protected, I was afraid, anxious, suspicious and worried. But now, Bhante, when I go to the forest or under a tree or to an empty room, I don't feel afraid, anxious, suspicious or worried at all. I live relaxed, in quiet, just dependent on the food others give us, with my mind happy and peaceful." The Buddha understood, and said, "When you don't have conflict in your mind, you have no fear or sorrow, you are blissful."

Questions after the story:

1. Why didn't Anuruddha want to be a monk at first?
2. What made him decide to become a monk?
3. Why do you think that Bhaddiya did not want to be a monk?
4. Why did the Sakyan princes want Upāli to be ordained first?
5. Why was Ven. Bhaddiya so happy when he was a monk?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"*Susukhaṃ vata jīvāma, yesaṃ no natthi kiñcanaṃ, pītibhakkhā bhavissāma devā ābhassarā yathā*."

"We who do not possess anything live so happily. We live by joy like the Radiant Devas."

(Dhammapada 200/15:4)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Why do you think that Bhaddiya was afraid, anxious, suspicious and worried? Bhaddiya was a governor, and had many responsibilities. He had to protect and take care of many people; he was responsible for their safety and

welfare. If he made any mistake or failed to do something, what would happen? Many people would suffer or be angry. Some people were envious of his wealth, power and beautiful things. They would act polite and kind, but he could not trust them. People were friendly to him because they hoped to get gifts or a job from him, or become popular with the wealthy people. Greedy people wanted to take things away from him. He had so many people who depended on him or wanted something from him. So he worried that he might forget to do something or might make a mistake, or that someone may attack him, steal from him or ruin his things. He had many guards, but even so, he did not feel secure and happy.

When we own (possess) valuable things, we may feel happy when we get them, but how long does it last? Are you happy forever when you get something you like? No. We always will get upset, worried or angry about something sooner or later. As we have learned, life is dukkha. We worry about whether our things may break or get lost, damaged or stolen. Or we get bored with them. We may think, like Bhaddiya, that some of our friends are not genuine, and that other people don't like us because they are envious. When we are adults, we must work so hard to get nice things that we don't have enough time to really relax and enjoy them, just like Mahānama told Anuruddha. Even the wealthiest people have dukkha. If we only want to get expensive things in life, but we work so hard to get them and we are still not very happy, then are we really getting what we want from life? Mahānama, Anuruddha and Bhaddiya didn't think so, and they thought that the only way to avoid that disappointment is to become a monk.

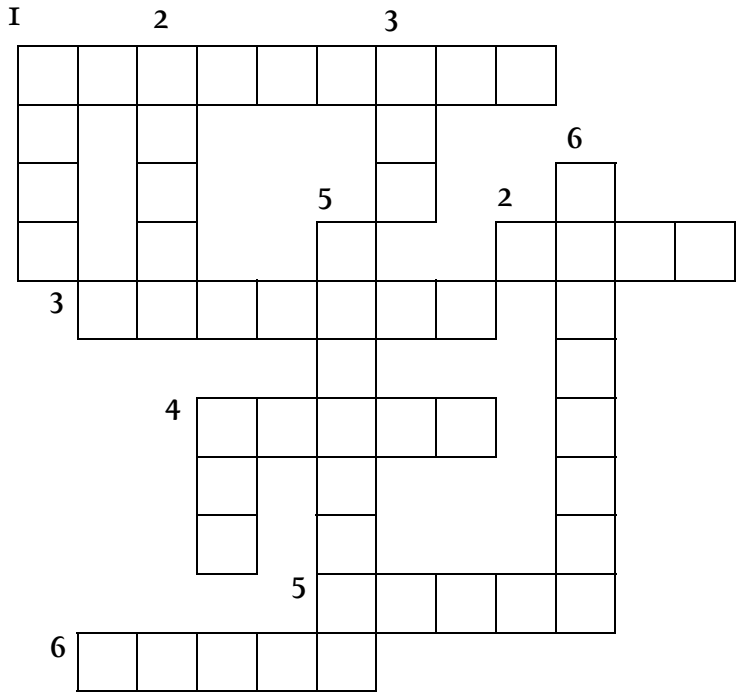
Is that true? The Buddha mentioned "we who do not possess anything live so happily." Does that mean that only monks and homeless people live happily? No. It is the *attitude* of not being possessive that makes a person happy. Possessiveness means having thoughts like "That's mine!" "My things are better than yours," "Don't mess up my

things," and "Don't touch my stuff." It means worrying about our things getting lost, broken, damaged or taken away from us, and anger or sadness when that happens. Possessiveness means having too much attachment to our things.

Suppose someone gave you a real baby elephant to keep as your own pet. You may be thrilled, but at the same time worried about where you can keep him, what you will feed him, what if he gets sick, what if someone steals him, what if he gets out of his pen. So many worries! But suppose that, instead, a wild baby elephant would walk up your street every day so you could see him often near your home. Wouldn't that be fun? You could enjoy him without the worry – without the possessive feelings and worries of owning him. So, we can enjoy what we see without thinking, "That's mine."

How can we have an attitude of *not* being possessive? How can we learn to have less attachment to our things? First, pay attention to our possessive thoughts: our worry that our things not get damaged, broken, lost or stolen. Pay attention to our possessive words: "Mine," "be careful with my things," "don't use my things," and "don't touch." Notice our possessive actions: hiding our things from others and not sharing. Second, determine whether it is reasonable to share or not, thinking "is there a good reason not to share it?" or "would my parents allow me to share it?" If it is reasonable to share, then we practice detaching from it, thinking, "Nothing in the world is mine forever; everything will be broken, damaged or gone at some point. If I think and behave according to Dharma, then good things, protection and happiness will come to me. It doesn't matter what happens to this thing. It will not keep me happy and will not end my dukkha." If we know from the time we are young that our things will not keep us happy, then we don't get so upset in the future if our things are lost, broken, damaged or stolen. Then we can experience the type of peace and happiness that Bhaddiya had.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:



WORD BOX:

MILKRICE	BODHI	JEALOUS	END	KONDANNA
NOBLE	BOW	NANDA	SICK	HAPPINESS
HELP	PRIDE			

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

CROSSWORD PUZZLE—REVIEW

Across:

1. What Bhaddiya felt when he became a monk and gave up his possessions
2. Prince Siddhattha saw an old man, a _____ man, a dead man, and a renunciant.
3. How Sañjaya felt when Moggallāna and Sāriputta left him to go to the Buddha.
4. The Buddha became enlightened under the _____ Tree, then looked at it for a week.
5. The Four _____ Truths.
6. _____ was going to get married but when the Buddha ordained him he was not happy.

Down:

1. To show our gratitude, we can _____ our parents.
2. Kassapa had too much _____ before he learned to be humble.
3. Everything that arises must _____.
4. To show reverence to the Buddha and to the monks, we _____ to them.
5. The first Arahant was Ven. _____.

6. What Sujātā offered to Siddhattha on the day he was to become enlightened.

Lesson 15
Truthfulness

LESSON 15

TRUTHFULNESS

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever been afraid to tell the truth because someone may be disappointed or angry at you if you told the truth?

STORY: VEN. RĀHULA AND THE DIPPER

The Buddha's son was ordained as a monk when he was only seven years old. He obeyed the older monks, was well disciplined, and was eager to learn. One day, when Ven. Rāhula was 11 years old, he saw the Buddha coming to visit. Ven. Rāhula prepared a seat for the Buddha and some water with a dipper to wash the feet. When the Buddha arrived, he washed his feet in the water, and Ven. Rāhula bowed to him and sat down. The Buddha poured a small amount of water in the water dipper and said, "Rāhula, do you see a small amount of water in the dipper?" Ven. Rāhula replied, "Yes, Bhante." The Buddha said, "Unless people are careful to avoid telling lies, they only have as little good in them as this little bit of water in the dipper."

The Buddha then threw the water away. He said, "Rāhula, do you see the small amount of water I threw away?" Ven. Rāhula said, "Yes, Bhante." The Buddha said, "Unless people are careful to avoid telling lies, the good in them is thrown away like this."

The Buddha then turned the dipper upside down. He said, "Rāhula, do you see the dipper upside down?" Ven. Rāhula said, "Yes, Bhante." The Buddha said, "Unless people are careful to avoid telling lies, the good in them is treated like this- overturned."

The Buddha then turned the dipper right side up. He said, "Rāhula, do you see the dipper now empty?" Ven. Rāhula said, "Yes, Bhante." The Buddha said, "Unless

people are careful to avoid telling lies, they are as empty of good as this. Anyone who is a liar does not care about his future, and he will do any evil act."

The Buddha continued, "Suppose a man rides a big elephant in battle, and the elephant fights with his four feet, his head, his ears, his tusks and even his tail, but not with his trunk. The man on his back would think, 'This elephant has not yet devoted his life to defending the king, because he is not making effort in all the ways that he can.' If the elephant uses his trunk also, then the man would think, 'Now the elephant has devoted his life to defending the king, because he is making effort in all the ways that he can. Now he needs no more training.' So, Rāhula, you must train yourself in this way. Following Dharma in some ways is not enough. You must follow Dharma in all the ways that you can. You must train yourself never to speak a lie even for a joke."

The Buddha asked, "Rāhula, what is a mirror for?" Ven. Rāhula answered, "To look at yourself, Bhante." The Buddha said, "In the same way, you should keep looking at yourself; look at the acts of your body, your speech and your mind. Look at each act, *before* you act, and think, 'Would this act lead to my own harm ? Would this act lead to harm to others? Would this act lead to harm to both myself and others?' Then you must not do that wrong act. Before you act, think, 'Would this act lead to no harm to me? Would this act lead to no harm to others? Would this act lead to no harm to me nor to others?' Then the act is good, you can do it. Also, *when* you are doing an act, think 'Is this act going to lead to my own harm? Is this act going to lead to harm to others?' If so, then stop doing that wrong act. Also, *after* you do an act, think about whether it was a good act or a bad act. If you realize that you have done a wrong act, then you must confess it to me or to the other monks, and not do it again."

Questions after the story:

1. What is the meaning of the little bit of water in the dipper?

2. What is the meaning of throwing away the water from the dipper?
3. What is the meaning of the dipper held upside down?
4. What is the meaning of the empty dipper held right side up?
5. What is the meaning of the elephant who uses his feet, head, ears, tusks and tail, but not his trunk?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Ekaṃ Dhammaṃ atītassa, musāvādissa jantuno, vitiṇṇaparalokassa, natthi pāpaṃ akāriyaṃ."

"For a liar who has violated the one Dharma virtue of truthfulness, he does not care about his future in his next lives, and he will do any evil act."

(Dhammapada 176/13:10)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Most of us avoid lying or false speech. That is the Fourth Precept: musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadam samādayami. Every religion teaches not to lie. So we know this is one of the most important virtues, to speak the truth and not to lie. But there may be many times when we are tempted to lie or speak falsely. Can you think of any examples? When we don't want to be punished. When we are worried that someone will be upset, angry or disappointed in us if we tell the truth. Or when we would be embarrassed to tell the truth. How do you feel if you lie in these situations? We might feel better for a while when we lie, because we avoided getting in trouble, or avoided getting embarrassed.

There are many different types of false speech. Can you think of some? Saying "I didn't do it" when we did something wrong. Saying "OK I will," and we really don't intend to. Saying "I'll call you tomorrow," and we don't intend to call. That is an untruth, a false promise. Saying, "I did it," when we didn't do it yet, but we are thinking that we *will* do it and they won't find out that we didn't do it yet—that is a lie, because we really did not do it.

Sometimes we may exaggerate—tell something more extreme than it really was to make it more interesting, but not true. Have you ever said that something happened but you really did not know for sure whether it happened? This may start gossip or spread rumors. Have you ever said you have done something that you have never really done before? That might be bragging. Has anyone ever told you something unusual or upsetting, and then laughed at you for believing it? We see this type of behavior on television sometimes. Or someone tells you something that makes you angry, to see your reaction, and then says "just joking." We may say things that sound nice but are dishonest, like "I like your haircut" when we think it looks horrible. These are all dishonest, types of false speech or lies.

Isn't it OK to tell little lies? So many people do. We may think it is OK to lie to prevent a friend from getting in trouble, or to prevent someone from getting angry at us and causing an argument. But the Buddha told Ven. Rāhula that all false speech, even lies that are jokes, should not be told.

Why do you think it is so important not to lie? False speech very easily becomes a bad habit. Some people have habits of making false promises and not being honest. Often, one lie leads to another one. If we lie, we may have to tell another lie to avoid getting caught in our first lie. We have to remember our lies and we may have to repeat them so we don't get caught lying. When we get away with saying little lies, then we tell more and more lies. We try to make our lies very convincing because we don't want to get caught lying. Then, as we get away with more and more lies, we become confident that we won't get caught. We become a skilled liar. We can remember the Buddha holding only a little water in the dipper—we may think we are good, but if we lie, we only have a little good in us. When we lie more, then the good in us will be thrown away.

Another reason to avoid false speech is that it hurts others. We know how much it hurts us when someone lies to us, or lies about us to others, or when someone tells us they

will do something and they don't, or when we get in trouble because of their lie. So we also should not hurt others by doing those things. Also, we know how much it hurts our parents if they find out we lied.

Another reason to avoid false speech is to maintain our self-respect. When we can't trust someone, when someone tends to speak falsely, how do we feel? We lose respect for him. Similarly, others lose respect for us if we lie, even if we say little lies. We can remember the Buddha holding the dipper upside down.

Another important reason to avoid lying is that it leads to other wrong behavior. We get tempted to do wrong things if we think we can just lie to avoid getting caught. We may enjoy the thrill of doing wrong things, and do more wrong things, lying to avoid getting caught. This is what the Buddha meant when he said that if we do not avoid telling lies, we will have no goodness in us, like the empty dipper, and when he said ". . . a liar . . . will do any evil act."

It is always best to avoid telling a lie. Instead, we can say the truth in a kind way, confess and apologize for our wrongdoing, explain the facts, or just stay silent. If we are afraid of telling the truth, we can say, "I don't want to upset you, but I want to tell you the truth." We can remember that good friends are impressed with us when we are truthful, honest, trustworthy, and when they can rely on our word. It is not worth it to try to get attention with false speech, whether jokes, gossip, false promises, exaggeration, or bragging. We should watch what we say, like looking at ourselves in a mirror, to make sure we do not say even small lies. Noticing when we speak falsely is important, because if we don't notice it, then we can't stop it from becoming a bad habit. We should not be afraid to admit to ourselves when we have lied, because that helps us to become more truthful.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

FILL IN THE BLANKS:

I SHOULD NOT LIE BECAUSE . . .

1. I will lose the __ __ __ __ __ __ __ __ in me.
2. Lying becomes a bad __ __ __ __ __.
3. "__ __ __ __ __ __ __ __ veramaṇī sikkhāpadam samādayami" is one of the 5 Precepts.
4. Good friends will lose __ __ __ __ __ __ __ for me.
5. I will have to __ __ __ __ __ __ __ __ my lies to avoid getting caught lying.
6. Other people will not __ __ __ __ __ me if I lie.
7. If I tell one lie, I may make up __ __ __ __ lies to avoid getting caught lying.
8. Lies __ __ __ __ others.
9. I would feel very __ __ __ __ __ __ __ if I got caught lying.
10. Lies lead to other __ __ __ __ __ behavior.

WORD BOX:

HURT TRUST REMEMBER GOODNESS WRONG
HABIT ASHAMED MUSAVADA MORE RESPECT

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 16
Generosity

Lesson 16
GENEROSITY

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: What did you give to your parents lately?

Story: Generosity of Anāthapiṇḍika

The Buddha and his bhikkhus were staying at the Bamboo Grove, Veluvana, but they had no building to live in. The bhikkhus slept under trees, in caves, or at burial grounds. A wealthy merchant (salesman) saw the monks staying outside, and one day he asked some of them, "Bhante, if I built some buildings for you to live in, would you live in them?" A bhikkhu answered, "The Blessed One has not allowed us to live in buildings." The merchant said, "Then, Bhante, ask the Buddha and tell me what he says." When the monks told the Buddha, he gave his permission for buildings to be built, and they told the merchant. In one day, the merchant had 60 small houses built for the monks, and he invited the Buddha and his bhikkhus for a meal at which he would present his gift of 60 buildings.

The merchant's brother-in-law, Anāthapiṇḍika, came to the merchant's house for some business, and heard the merchant directing his servants to get up early and prepare food. Anāthapiṇḍika thought it was strange that the merchant did not immediately drop everything and welcome him as he usually did, and thought that the merchant must be preparing for a wedding or a king's visit. When the merchant finally welcomed Anāthapiṇḍika, the merchant said he was preparing a meal for the Buddha and his Sangha of bhikkhus. Anāthapiṇḍika asked, "Did you say the *Buddha*?" The merchant said yes. Anāthapiṇḍika could not believe it, and said it is a very rare opportunity, and asked, "Is it possible to see the Buddha now?" The merchant

said no, that he should come tomorrow and see the Buddha in the morning.

Anāthapiṇḍika was very excited, thinking, "Tomorrow morning I will be able to see the fully enlightened Buddha!" He went to bed, but could not sleep, he was so excited. He got up three times, thinking it was dawn, and finally walked out of the house when it was still dark. Celestial beings opened the gate for him, and he walked out into the darkness. There were no lights, so he became afraid and thought of going back home. But a celestial being called Sivaka said, "100 elephants, 100 horses, 100 chariots, a hundred thousand ladies with beautiful gems and earrings, all these are not worth one part of one step forward now. Go forward!" The fear went away and Anāthapiṇḍika went to the Buddha, who saw him and called him by name. Anāthapiṇḍika bowed to him, and the Buddha taught him some Dharma. Anāthapiṇḍika then got the deep understanding that everything that arises must end. He was so happy, and said "That is wonderful! Please receive me as your follower; I take refuge in the Buddha as long as I live. Lord, please accept my invitation to you and the Sangha of bhikkhus for tomorrow's meal." The Buddha was silent, which meant that he accepted the invitation. Anāthapiṇḍika bowed and left, and the next morning, he prepared the meal at the merchant's house.

The next morning, the Buddha and his bhikkhus came to the merchant's house, where Anāthapiṇḍika served them the meal. When they finished eating, Anāthapiṇḍika asked the Buddha, "Bhante, will you and your Sangha of bhikkhus spend the rainy season with me at Sāvatthī?" The Buddha answered, "We are happy with rooms that are empty." Anāthapiṇḍika said, "I know, Bhante." The Buddha gave a Dharma talk, and then left.

Anāthapiṇḍika went back to his home town, Sāvatthī, and on the way he told people to make gardens and other places for monks to stay, and prepare food, because a Buddha had appeared in the world and will be coming on this road. Anāthapiṇḍika looked all around Sāvatthī for a

peaceful place for the Buddha and the bhikkhus to stay. He saw Prince Jeta's park, a large, beautiful and peaceful forest, the perfect place. He went to Prince Jeta and asked if he could use the park. Prince Jeta said, "The park cannot be given unless 100 thousand gold coins are spread over it." That was an enormous amount of money, almost all that Anāthapiṇḍika had. But he was determined to give a great gift to the Buddha and Sangha. So, he got 100 thousand gold coins and had them loaded in carts and taken to Prince Jeta's park. He covered most of the park with the gold coins, but there was a small part near the gate that was not covered. He ordered people to get some more gold to cover the space. Prince Jeta came out to the park to see what was happening, and thought, "This is no ordinary man, to spend this much money." He said to Anāthapiṇḍika, "That's enough, don't cover that space. Leave that for me to give as my gift." Anāthapiṇḍika thought that it is good if such a famous person learns the Dharma from the Buddha, so he agreed to leave the space for Prince Jeta to give as a gift.

Anāthapiṇḍika had buildings, terraces, gates, halls, walks, bathrooms, and ponds built in Jeta's Park. This became the famous monastery called Jetavana in the city of Sāvatthī.

The Buddha started his journey to Sāvatthī. As Anāthapiṇḍika had told them, the people on the road to Sāvatthī eagerly had buildings made for the monks to stay overnight. The people provided robes, food and medicine to the monks who helped instruct them how to make proper buildings for the Sangha. A poor tailor saw the people making buildings for the bhikkhus, and he wanted to make a building for them, too. So, he got some clay and made some bricks by himself, and started to build. Because he was not skilled in constructing buildings, the wall of his building was crooked and it fell down. He tried to fix it twice, and again it fell down twice. He was disappointed, and thought, "The bhikkhus are advising and instructing those wealthy people who give them buildings, robes and food. But I am poor, so no one helps me." The bhikkhus heard about the

poor tailor, and told the Buddha, who instructed them to allow and supervise people to make buildings, and to make sure that any damaged or broken buildings are repaired, so no one is treated unfairly. They continued their journey to Sāvatthī.

Questions after the story:

1. Where did the monks spend the night before the merchant built the 60 houses?
2. How did the merchant and Anāthapiṇḍika feel about serving the Buddha?
3. Why was Anāthapiṇḍika afraid when he left the house?
4. What type of rooms did the Buddha say he and the bhikkhus are happy with? Why?
5. What payment did Prince Jeta demand from Anāthapiṇḍika?
6. Why was Anāthapiṇḍika's payment not enough?
7. What was the name of the monastery built at Prince Jeta's park?
8. What happened when the poor tailor tried to build a building for the Buddha and Sangha?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Sukhā matteyyatā loke, atho petteyyatā sukhā, sukhā sāmaññatā loke, atho brahmaññatā sukhā."

"In this world, serving one's mother brings happiness, serving one's father brings happiness, serving the monks brings happiness, and serving the holy ones brings happiness." (Dhammapada 332/23:13)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Young people are usually not like Anāthapiṇḍika and the merchant because we don't have money like they have. We are more like the poor tailor, who didn't have much money or professional skills to make great expensive gifts. But, we can share what we do have and use our skills to make simple gifts. Who do we share and give gifts to? Our

friends? We give birthday gifts, we share toys, and we give them our time—we spend time with them. It is fun to spend time with friends and we want friends to like us, do things for us and invite us. So we like to give to them. But, that type of giving usually has some selfishness in it—we give because we want something in return: our friend's attention and to enjoy fun times with our friends.

What type of giving is unselfish—or selfless? In an earlier lesson, we talked about giving as a way of showing our gratitude—we are thankful for what we have been given, or for what we have, like the Buddha was thankful to the Bodhi Tree and Mucalinda the royal nāga for giving him shelter. Selfless giving also means giving without trying to get something in return.

Young people have time and a lot of energy. They can give their time and energy to help someone without thinking about getting attention, money, or rewards of any kind. This is called "selfless service."

How can you do selfless service? At home, for your parents! You can give your time and energy to help your parents even when they don't ask for it. You may be able to find some things that your parents would like you to do at home. As the Buddha said, serving our mother and father brings happiness. How does it bring happiness? First, our parents will be happy seeing us doing things to help them without being asked. When they are happy, don't we become happier, too? Second, when we know that we are doing good actions, we know that we are doing the right thing, so we become confident. If we are often lazy and not helpful, will others be pleased with us? Probably not. Third, we are showing our gratitude by selfless service to our parents for all the good they have done for us. Fourth, good actions, *puññakamma*, have good results in the future, as we know from the Law of Karma. So, selfless service may not be as much fun as being with our friends, but it gives us happiness now and in the future. Anāthapiṇḍika and the merchant could have spent their money on things that could have been more fun, but they spent it instead on the

holy ones—the Buddha and the Sangha.

How do we know what to do to help? We can look around and see what needs to be cleaned up, put away, prepared, or set up the way our parents like it to be done. We should first offer to do it, by saying "Would you like me to . . ." to make sure they approve of what we plan to do. We can see when they are working on something; if there is something we could do to help, we can offer to help. But remember, to be selfless service we are not hoping to get any money, privileges or other treats or rewards in return.

We also can give our time and energy to do selfless service for relatives, needy people, and at the temple. We can ask our parents how we can help.

We may find out that our service is more difficult than we thought, like Anāthapiṇḍika when he found that the 100,000 gold coins were not enough to cover the land. Like Anāthapiṇḍika, we should keep a good giving heart and not stop just because we have some obstacle or difficulty. If needed, we can ask our parents for guidance on how to complete the job. Or we could ask someone else to help us. It is good to encourage others to do selfless service, too.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Each student writes the quotation for today on a paper, and then underneath writes about 10 or 20 numbered lines to write a list. On the lines, students list things they can do as selfless service to their parents. If students cannot fill all the lines, then when they get home, they can ask their parents to suggest some things they would like their child to do to help. Then each student hangs the list in a conspicuous place at home, such as in the kitchen, to remember what they can give to their parents.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 17
Loving-Kindness

LESSON 17

LOVING-KINDNESS (METTĀ)

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever accidentally stepped on a tiny creature, such as an insect or a worm? How did you feel about it?

STORY: KAṬHINA

There were many bhikkhus in the Sangha, and they traveled in large groups from place to place by walking on foot, whether it was hot, cold or rainy weather. When the bhikkhus traveled in such large groups, they made a path on the ground, trampling the grass and other plants and creating muddy areas when it rained. The people in the villages noticed this, and observed that monks of other teachers stayed in one place during the rainy season and therefore did not trample the grass and make muddy paths. The people noticed that even birds stayed in their nests during rain. They complained about the Buddhist monks, and said that they were ruining the plants and harming the little creatures on the ground, like insects and worms, by trampling them.

The bhikkhus heard about the complaints, and went to tell the Buddha. The Buddha felt loving kindness to the small creatures and tender plants that were being trampled in the mud. And, he knew that it was difficult for the people to find the bhikkhus when they were so often traveling. But, the Buddha knew that it was important for the monks to travel around so that many people can hear the Dharma and have an opportunity to serve the monks.

He then decided to allow the monks to stay in one place for the rainy season (Vassa). From that time onward, the bhikkhus stayed in one place during the three or four months of Vassa. The people always knew where the

bhikkhus would be during the rainy season, so the people could easily visit them and hear them teach the Dharma. And the people could easily supply the monks with their needs, like food, shelter and medicine.

The Buddha set rules for the monks during the rainy season, requiring them to be in retreat, so they could not leave the place they were staying for more than 7 days, even if someone was sick.

A group of 30 bhikkhus wanted to visit the Buddha at Sāvatthī. On the way, the rainy season started, and they had to stay at a place called Sāketā on the way to Sāvatthī. They knew that the Buddha was close, but they could not travel to see him. After the three months rainy season, they started to travel, but the road was wet and full of puddles. Their robes became soaking wet and muddy, and they became uncomfortable and tired traveling in their wet robes.

When they finally reached the Buddha at Sāvatthī, they bowed to him. The Buddha asked, "Did you have any difficulties? Did you get enough food? Did you spend your retreat in peace, with friendly discussion without quarreling?" The monks responded, "We had no difficulties, we got enough food, we did not quarrel. But we could not reach Sāvatthī in time to be with you during the rainy season, so we stayed in Sāketā. You were so close, but we could not see you. We were anxious to see you, so we traveled here quickly, and now we are tired and wet." The Buddha noticed how wet and muddy the robes were, and how uncomfortable the monks must feel. He felt very kind and loving to these monks who obeyed his rules and were so disciplined.

The Buddha then announced that all monks who obeyed his rules and stayed in one place during the rainy season could accept new robes at the end of the rainy season. People could bring cloth for the monks' robes to the monks so they could change any wet and muddy robes. They could also receive from people the Eight Requisites (aṭṭha-parikkhāra) for monks: three robes, belt, bowl, razor,

needle and thread, and water strainer (to strain out insects and dirt from drinking water). This ceremony at the end of the rainy season when the people offer the robes and the Eight Requisites was called Kaṭhina.

Another tradition for Kaṭhina is that one monk in the group who performed his duties and discipline very well would be chosen by agreement of all the other monks to receive from the community a special robe (*cīvara*), which was stitched and dyed while monks are chanting. All robes were made from ten pieces of cloth stitched together, because one large piece of cloth is valuable and may get stolen. A robe was sometimes made from cloths put on dead bodies or pieces of cloth that were thrown away by others. The cloth pieces were washed carefully and dyed an orange, yellow or brown color.

Questions after the story:

1. Why did the monks travel around so much?
2. What happened on the ground when they traveled in the rain?
3. What did the Buddha think when he heard about the complaints of the people?
4. How did the Buddha feel toward the monks who had gotten wet and muddy?
5. What happens at the end of the rainy season?
6. Why are robes made of several pieces of cloth stitched together?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Apādakehi me mettāṃ, mettāṃ dvipādakehi me, catuppādehi me mettāṃ, mettāṃ bahuppādehi me."

"I give my loving-kindness to those with no feet, I give my loving-kindness to those with two feet, I give my loving-kindness to those with four feet, I give my loving-kindness to those with many feet." (Khandhaparitta)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

We say that the Pali word "*mettā*" means "loving-kindness," not just "love." Do you know why? It is because we may *think* we have love for someone, but if we do not speak words of kindness, act with kindness, or think of ways we can be kind to that person, we are not having genuine love. If we have real love, which includes kindness, then we speak words of kindness, act kindly, and think kind thoughts about the person.

How did the Buddha show mettā for the insects and worms that would be trampled by the monks, and for the people who complained about it? How did the Buddha show mettā for the people who could not find the bhikkhus because they were always traveling? How did the Buddha show mettā for the monks who were tired and wet when they arrived? How did the Buddha show mettā for monks who did their duties and discipline well during the rainy season?

It is easy to have mettā for friends and family, and cute animals. But can we also have mettā for people we don't know, or for people who are not friendly to us? Can we have mettā for someone who just upset us, or for someone who hates us? Can we have mettā for creatures like insects and snakes that we don't want to touch? Can we have mettā for fierce animals that we are afraid of? Can we have mettā for people who misbehave?

This is real mettā, to have loving-kindness to those beings who are not so loveable. Usually, we just don't think about having mettā for them; it's not very easy.

How do you feel if you step on an insect or tiny creature you don't like, like one with no feet or with many feet? If you were afraid it would bite or sting you, you might feel angry at it and hope it is destroyed. If you accidentally stepped on him, you may want to just forget about it. But if we do that, we get a habit of not caring about other creatures, and maybe not caring about other people. We then become uncaring and selfish.

Instead, we can remember that each tiny creature is afraid of pain and dying, just like us. He wants to live safely and get his food, like us. If we remember that, and respect his life, then we can have mettā to the tiny creature. We can wish him a good and happy rebirth. That way, we increase the love in our hearts. We can also think that way toward fierce animals and those we don't like to touch. We can understand that they are fierce, and that they have their type of body and ways of protecting themselves—like claws, big teeth, scales, or a stinger—because that is how they can survive, to get their food and avoid being hurt.

How can we have mettā to someone who we don't know, or who is not friendly to us? Many people who don't know us or who are not friendly to us would love us very much if they really knew us. They may ignore us because they cannot see the love in our hearts. Some people are shy, or envious, or judge us without really knowing us. We can smile at them, say some kind words, or help them in some way, and maybe they will smile back and become friendly. But if they don't, that's okay, they are just not ready to accept us yet, or, they are not happy. We can wish they become happy and more accepting and open-hearted.

How can we have mettā to someone who upset us or who hates us? We can think that if that person was a really happy and loving person, he would not upset us anymore, he would not treat us badly, he would not have any hatred. So, we can wish he becomes a really happy and loving person!

We can have mettā to people who misbehave, too. Should we be friendly with people who misbehave? We can be polite to them, but we should avoid them so we don't get involved in misbehavior too. But we can wish that they learn to behave better and make a better future for themselves, having compassion for them because they will have to suffer the results of their misbehavior. We should be careful not to wish that they suffer, though – that is unkind. Instead, we can wish that good things happen to them to give them happiness so they stop misbehaving.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Teacher prepares cardboard cut-outs of hearts and lotus blossoms. Each student, on a piece of paper, traces around a heart or a lotus flower cut-out, writes "Metta" inside the heart or lotus, and may color it. Around the heart or lotus, students draw people, animals, birds, reptiles, amphibians, insects, etc. Arrows may be drawn from the heart or lotus to the various beings around it, to represent mettā being sent from us to all beings.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 18
Avoid Vanity

LESSON 18

AVOID VANITY

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: How do you feel when you look in the mirror?

STORY: THE ORDER OF NUNS, KHEMĀ AND NANDĀ

When the Buddha went again to visit Kapilavatthu, his father, King Suddhodana had become sick and then died as an Arahant. Queen Gotamī was then alone. She went to visit the Buddha and said, "Bhante, it would be good if women could leave the householder life and be ordained into the Dharma and Discipline taught by you." The Buddha said, "Gotamī, do not ask for women to leave the householder life and be ordained." She asked three times, but he would not agree. Queen Gotamī bowed and left, feeling sad. She cut off her hair anyway and put on a robe like the monks. Several other women from the palace did the same, including Yashodharā, who had been the wife of Prince Siddhattha.

After the Buddha left Kapilavatthu, Queen Gotamī and the other women, with their hair shaven and wearing robes, walked the long distance to where the Buddha was staying. When they arrived, Queen Gotamī stood on the porch, her feet swollen and covered with dust. She was feeling very sad, with tears rolling down her cheeks. Ven. Ānanda saw her and felt great compassion for her, and gently asked why she was standing there. She explained that the Buddha would not allow women to be ordained into his Dharma and Discipline. Ven. Ānanda asked her to wait, and he went inside to the Buddha, saying, "Bhante, it would be good if women could be ordained into the Dharma and Discipline taught by you." The Buddha would not agree. Ven. Ānanda said, "Bhante, after women become ordained into Dharma and Discipline taught by you, are they able to become

Arahants?" The Buddha said, "They are, Ānanda." Ven. Ānanda said, "If they are, then since Gotamī was extremely helpful to you by being your foster mother when your own mother Queen Mahāmāyā died, it would be good if women could be ordained." The Buddha said, "If Gotamī accepts eight major rules, that will be her full ordination." Then he gave eight rules for women to be ordained as nuns, called bhikkhunīs. These eight rules were to make sure that the bhikkhunis fully respected the bhikkhus.

Ven. Ānanda then returned to Gotamī and told her what the Buddha had said. She responded very happily, accepting the eight rules like a person would accept a garland of flowers on her head. Ven. Ānanda told the Buddha that Gotamī, now Ven. Gotamī, had accepted the rules. The other women who traveled with Ven. Gotamī were ordained by the monks. The Sangha of Bhikkhunis was now formed.

Nandā, the daughter of Ven. Gotamī was extremely beautiful. She knew that the Buddha teaches that beauty is not important, and that he does not speak well about beauty, so she did not want to visit him. So she listened to the Buddha's teachings from others telling her what they heard. The Buddha one day said that a person should come personally to listen to his advice. When Nandā heard that, she went to see the Buddha for the first time. When she arrived, she saw a beautiful woman fanning the Buddha. This woman was an image created by the Buddha's powers for Nanda to see. The woman's appearance started to change. She started looking tired, then she looked older, wrinkles formed on her face, and her hair started to turn grey. Then she started looking extremely old and feeble. Nandā stared at her in disbelief, wondering about the Buddha's powers to create that image. Then she started to think deeply about getting old and losing beauty. She understood how attached she was to her beauty, and how painful it will be to lose her beauty, and she learned that to avoid that pain, she should not be so concerned about beauty.

A similar experience happened to Queen Khemā, the wife of King Bimbisāra. She had golden skin, and a perfect face and body. She was very proud of her beauty, and like Nanda, she did not want to visit the Buddha when she heard that he does not say good things about beauty. But she wanted to see the beautiful Bamboo Grove, so she went to see it. There she heard the Buddha's voice, a relaxed, kind and loving voice. She pulled a scarf over her face so she wouldn't be noticed, and she sat in the back of the crowd of people listening to Buddha teaching. The Buddha created an image of a most beautiful young lady fanning him. "That young lady is more beautiful than I am," Queen Khemā thought. But the image changed, and her beauty started to fade; she became wrinkled, grey-haired, and bent. Her smile turned into a toothless grin, she became thin and feeble, and finally she fell on the floor and died. Her body became decayed and then only the bones could be seen, and then the bones turned into dust. Queen Khemā was shocked by the image. She thought about how she would get old and die, too. She understood how her beauty was only temporary, she would surely lose it, so all the beauty that she was so proud of is ultimately useless. She learned that she must find a better focus in life than her beauty. So she asked her husband, King Bimbisāra, for permission to be a nun. The good king agreed, so she shaved her head, wore a robe and became ordained as a bhikkhuni, to dedicate her life to learning the Dharma from the Buddha.

Questions after the story:

1. What is a bhikkhunī?
2. Who was the first bhikkhunī?
3. Why did Nandā and Khemā not want to see the Buddha at first?
4. What did they see when they went to visit the Buddha?
5. Why did the Buddha make those images?
6. What did Nandā and Khemā learn?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Passa cittakataṃ bimbaṃ, arukāyaṃ samussitaṃ, āturaṃ bahusaṅkappaṃ, yassa natthi dhuvaṃ ṭhiti."

"See this dressed up beautiful body, but it is a mass of sores, held up by bones, it gets illnesses, and it is not permanent." (Dhammapada 147/11:2)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

In today's world, the beauty of the body is considered so important. People who have money spend a lot of time and money shopping for new clothes, jewelry and shoes, exercising and getting new haircuts and beauty treatments. It is good to exercise, be healthy, groom ourselves and dress neatly. But many teenagers, and even some younger students, are too concerned about how they look.

Nanda and Khemā were very vain. What does "vain" or "vanity" mean? Vanity means being proud of the way we appear, or being too concerned about how we look. It means not only feeling proud when we look attractive, but also feeling upset if we don't look so attractive; worrying and spending a lot of time thinking about how we look and comparing ourselves with how others look; wanting to look better than others, more fashionable, wealthier, fitter, so people will notice and admire us; criticizing how others look; and maybe even spending a lot of time and money to look more attractive.

The Buddha teaches us that when we are young, we should know that the beauty of the body is only temporary, and that inside the body we are not pretty at all! We are all full of bones, blood and other very unpleasant things. At any time we can get an illness, injury or disease that may make our body look unattractive. And if we live long, how will we look? Old and wrinkled, with grey hair, fat, baldness, or spotty and saggy skin. If we remember this, then we don't feel so attached to our looks, so we don't have so much vanity, like Nandā and Khemā. Then, we don't get upset

when we don't look so handsome or beautiful anymore—we can still be happy regardless of how we look.

Buddhist nuns (bhikkhunis) have shaven heads, which looks unusual on a woman. By shaving their heads and wearing robes, they are making sure they don't have vanity. They don't have to style their hair, shop, or think about what to wear. They don't have to worry about having a bad hair day! So, they can spend their time thinking wholesome thoughts and purifying their minds.

If we are not always thinking and worrying about how we look, then we don't spend too much money and time going shopping, we don't worry and waste time looking in the mirror and comparing ourselves with others. Then, we can have happier thoughts and have more money and time to spend on things that are more important. Can you think of some things that are more important?

Is it wrong to look beautiful or handsome? No, of course not. Even the Buddha was very attractive. People liked to look at his beautiful, peaceful and loving face, because he had an *inner* beauty. Similarly, before Ven. Moggallāna and Ven. Sāriputta met the Buddha, they saw the serenity in the face of Ven. Assaji, and the graceful and disciplined way that he walked, and they were attracted to that inner beauty. That is different from *outer* beauty, such as the beauty of Māra's daughters, who had beautiful faces and bodies, but evil minds.

When people have *inner* beauty, they have a smile that makes you happy and want to smile back. Their eyes sparkle with peace and friendliness, and their face glows with happiness. Someone with only *outer* beauty has a beautifully formed face, but it may often look arrogant, angry, aggressive, jealous, suspicious, gloomy, bored, mischievous, insecure, or not genuine. The smile may be a fake smile, an impish smile, a flirting smile, or a smirk. People with outer beauty are often popular, but if they don't have strong virtues, they cannot have inner beauty.

Other people may be jealous of someone with a peaceful inner beauty. But genuinely good people will always be attracted to someone with inner beauty. So, we can be popular with *good* people if we cultivate our *inner* beauty by practicing Dharma.

Activity to reinforce the lesson: (next page)

WORD SEARCH

Find 12 words from the lesson:

K E N N A B Q G E
H I M A G E S F I
E N U N Y A V A N
M O L D C U A N N
A O P A D T I M E
V A N I T Y N I R
P O P U L A R N O

WORD BOX:

KHEMANUN BEAUTY VANITY TIME FAN
VAIN POPULAR NANDA IMAGE INNER OLD

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 19
Obedience

LESSON 19

OBEDIENCE

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: When you really want to do something but your parents don't allow you, what do you do?

STORY: NĀGASAMĀLA AND MEGHIYA

One day the Buddha was walking on a long journey with Ven. Nāgasamāla. At one point, the road split into two directions, so they had to decide whether to follow the road going toward the right or to follow the road going toward the left. Ven. Nāgasamāla pointed to the road on the left and said, "Bhante, this is the way. Let's go this way." The Buddha pointed to the road on the right and replied, "This is the way, Nāgasamāla. Let's go this way."

But Ven. Nāgasamāla was sure that the road on the left was the correct way to their destination, and he again pointed to the left and said, "Bhante, that is the way." The Buddha again pointed to the right and said, "Nāgasamāla, this is the way."

Ven. Nāgasamāla was frustrated that the Buddha did not agree with him and he was very confident that he was correct, so he pointed to the left and firmly said, "Bhante, *that* is the way." The Buddha again pointed to the right and said, "Nāgasamāla, this is the way." The Buddha knew what danger was waiting on the road Ven. Nāgasamāla chose.

Ven. Nāgasamāla was holding the Buddha's bowl and outer robe. He was angry that the Buddha would not agree with him. He did not like to be told that he was wrong. He bent down to put the Buddha's bowl and outer robe on the ground. The Buddha did not get upset about this misbehavior, but just said, "May I have my bowl and robe?" Ven. Nāgasamāla did not answer and did not move. The

Buddha bent down and picked up his bowl and robe. He slowly walked alone up the road to the right.

Ven. Nāgasamāla walked alone, along the road to the left. He felt sure that the Buddha would notice his mistake and come quickly to the road on which Ven. Nāgasamāla was walking. He walked confidently without looking back. Suddenly, he heard a noise coming from the bushes next to the road, and the next moment, several rough-looking men appeared. One of them immediately hit him on the head and another one kicked him. One of them broke his bowl, slamming it down onto the road, and another took his robes and tore the one he was wearing. Ven. Nāgasamāla's head was bleeding and his robes were badly torn. He was afraid, and he turned around, wishing to be with the Buddha again. He walked very quickly with his torn robe and broken bowl, back to the split in the road and then walked along the road that the Buddha had chosen. He finally caught up to the Buddha and called out to him. The Buddha stopped, and Ven. Nāgasamāla bowed with deep reverence and told him what had happened. The Buddha said, "A wise man and a foolish man lived together. The wise men leave what they know is bad." The Buddha was hinting that with his wisdom he knew that the road Ven. Nāgasamāla chose was bad, and that someone who has not developed wisdom should follow the advice of a wise person.

On another day, when the Buddha was staying at Calika, Ven. Meghiya, who was his attendant, went to the Buddha and said, "Bhante, I want to go to Jantugrama for food." The Buddha replied, "It's time to do as you think is right, Meghiya." Ven. Meghiya took his bowl and went to Jantugrama, where some villagers put some food into his bowl. He then walked to the river, and saw a beautiful Mango grove. He thought, "This beautiful mango grove is a good place for a monk to stay for the spiritual struggle. If the Buddha allows it, I will come here to stay." He went to the Buddha and told him about it. The Buddha's reply was, "Wait, Meghiya, we are still alone. Wait until another monk

comes." Meghiya did not understand why the Buddha wanted to wait to give an answer. Ven. Meghiya said, "Bhante, you don't have anything left to do. If you will allow me, I want to stay at the mango grove for the spiritual struggle." For the second time, the Buddha's reply was, "Wait, Meghiya, we are still alone. Wait until another monk comes." But Ven. Meghiya insisted, and asked again. The Buddha knew that it was not the right time for Ven. Meghiya to be able to meditate well, but he replied, "Since you want to struggle, what can I say? It is time for you to do as you think is right."

Ven. Meghiya bowed and left to go to the mango grove, where he sat under a tree to meditate. He expected to have a peaceful mind now that he was in such a beautiful place. But that did not happen. He started to have many negative thoughts, horrible thoughts, and angry thoughts. He had thoughts about things he wanted. He even had thoughts of cruelty and ill will. He wondered why he, as a monk, sitting in a beautiful place, was being bothered by evil thoughts. In the evening, he went back to the Buddha and told him what happened. The Buddha said, "Meghiya, when a person has not yet reached the goal, five things will lead him toward the goal: having friends who are virtuous, being virtuous so he does not do even small misbehaviors, talking about Dharmic subjects, leaving unwholesome things, and wisdom that leads to the end of suffering." The Buddha said further, "Bad thoughts come and tempt the mind. Not understanding these thoughts, the mind chases after them. A man who understands these thoughts gets rid of them with mindfulness. And one who is enlightened is done with them all, because no more temptation stirs up his mind."

Questions after the story:

1. Why didn't Ven. Nāgasamāla agree with the Buddha about which road to take?
2. Why didn't Ven. Meghiya follow the Buddha's advice to wait?

3. How would you describe the personality of Ven. Nāgasamāla and Ven. Meghiya?
4. What happened to them when they did what they wanted to do, against the Buddha's advice?
5. What did Ven. Nāgasamāla and Ven. Meghiya learn?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Karaṇīyaṃ atthakusalena, yaṃ taṃ santaṃ padaṃ abhisamecca,
Sakko ujū ca sūjū ca, suvaco c'assa mudu anatimāni."

"One who does good, who wishes to skillfully attain peace, should act this way: One should be able, straight, upright, obedient, gentle and humble."

(Karanīyamettā Sutta)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

The Buddha teaches us that we should be obedient. Obedient to whom? Should we be obedient to our friends? Classmates? Strangers? Of course not—they may not be very wise and may lead us to do something wrong or foolish. But whom should we obey? Our parents, teachers, grandparents and other family elders. If we are obedient to them, we avoid many mistakes and problems in our lives. We may not always agree with them. We may think they don't understand modern society. We may think they are much more strict than other parents or teachers. But they have experience, wisdom, success and good values which they practiced and learned from. And they deeply care for us and our happiness. That is why we should obey them.

The Buddha teaches us not only to be obedient, but also to be *able*—not lazy, forgetful, irresponsible, or unwilling to learn or to follow directions when they ask us to do something. Can you think of some examples of how we make ourselves appear unable to do what we are supposed to do? An example of not being able and obedient is when asked to do something, we say "It's too hard to do," or "I can't do that myself" or "I don't know how to do it" rather than trying with our best effort.

The Buddha teaches us to be *straight and upright*—not "crooked," deceitful, misleading or pretending as a way of avoiding doing what we are told to do, or as a way of explaining why we should not or did not obey. Can you think of some examples? Some examples of not being straight and upright is lying, saying "I already did it" when it was not done or not fully done, "I forgot to do it" when we really didn't forget, "I can't find it" when we didn't try hard to look for it, or "It's not working" when there is nothing wrong with it.

The Buddha teaches us to be *gentle*—to gently and respectfully accept advice, orders and instructions from our parents, teachers and older relatives. This means we don't whine, beg (plead), raise our voice, make unpleasant faces or remarks, argue, question, or insist on our way. An example of not being gentle and obedient is Ven. Meghiya insisting on his way—going immediately to the mango grove—without waiting as the Buddha told him to do. Some other examples are, when asked to do something, to say "Why do I have to?" or "Can't I do it later?" or "I always have to . . ." or "But she didn't have to do it" or some other reason starting with the word "But . . . ." Hopefully you don't say these things!

Also, the Buddha teaches us to be *humble.* What does humble mean? Not to be arrogant, thinking we know better than our elders and teachers, like Ven. Nāgasamāla who thought he knew better than the Buddha. Sometimes, we may be correct. Sometimes, a parent or teacher may be incorrect. But as a son, daughter or student, it is our duty to be humble to our parents and teachers and to be obedient and to respect their advice even if we do not agree.

What should we do if our teacher, parent or elder has asked us to do something and we have a different idea? We can politely say, "Would it be OK if I . . . .?" and if the answer is no, we must accept "no" as the answer. What should we do if our teacher, parent or elder has asked us to do something and there is an honestly good reason why we cannot obey?

We can politely explain or show him or her the reason, but we should not argue, whine, plead, or insist on our way.

It may not be easy to follow the Buddha's teaching always, especially when we see other kids who are not so obedient. But being "able, straight, upright, obedient, gentle and humble" are some of the most important virtues for getting and keeping a good job, and therefore our success, peace and happiness in the future depends on our development of those virtues. We can only develop them if we remember and practice them when we are young.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

The popular game "Simon Says" changed to "Wise one says"—

Students stand up, facing one student who is the leader, who quickly gives the other students commands such as Wise one says touch your toes, Wise one says turn around, Wise one says touch your nose, Wise one says raise your hands, Wise one says hands on your hips, Wise one says jump, or Wise one says raise your right foot. Occasionally the student leader gives a command without saying "Wise one says." Students must obey immediately each command preceded by "Wise one says," but must not obey commands without it. Each student who obeys a command without "Wise one says" or who doesn't immediately obey a command with "Wise one says" must sit down and is out of the game. Commands can be given faster and faster to make the game more challenging. The last person out wins, and becomes the next leader. This game demonstrates obeying immediately the instructions of our parents, teachers and elders ("wise ones") and not blindly following what friends tell us to do.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 20
Avoid Angry Speech

Lesson 20
AVOID ANGRY SPEECH

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Has someone ever said angry words to you and you said angry words in return?

Story: River Rohiṇī

The Sakya clan lived in Kapilavatthu, the city where the Buddha grew up as Prince Siddhattha. The Sakyas got their water for drinking, bathing and watering their food crops from the River Rohiṇī. On the other side of the river lived the people of Koliya, who also used water from the River Rohiṇī for all of their needs. One year there was not much rain, and the dry weather caused the River Rohiṇī to flow with much less water than usual. The Koliyan farmers and Sakyan farmers needed a lot of water for their crops, and they were worried that there would not be enough and that their plants would die and there would not be enough food. The farmers of Koliya crossed the river to talk to the Sakyan farmers. The Koliyan farmers said, "We need enough water for our crops. Please stop using so much water. Let us grow all the crops and we will share the food with you." The Sakyan farmers mistrusted them, and said, "After you have harvested your food, we don't want to come begging from you. Our crops don't need that much water, so let us continue using the water." They were upset, thinking, "How dare they tell *us* to stop using water and depend on *them* for food." The Koliyan farmers were upset because the Kapilavatthu farmers didn't trust them and accept their offer. The farmers of both cities started arguing. Neither side would give in to the other, so they became more and more angry and they started shouting. They each started feeling very disgusted with the farmers of the other side.

Finally, in anger, a Koliyan farmer accused the people of Kapilavatthu of doing certain very improper actions. That was a terrible insult. The Sakyan farmers did not tolerate it. So a Sakyan farmer shouted that the Koliyas were lepers and poor people who lived in trees like animals.

The Koliyan farmers went away and reported the fight to the ministers of Koliya, who then reported the fight to the Koliyan royal family. The Sakyas reported the fight to the ministers of Kapilavatthu, who then reported the fight to the Sakyan royal family. The Sakyas and Koliyas were very angry when they heard about the insults, so they became totally disgusted with each other, and felt that they wanted to destroy the other and never have to see them again. So they each planned war against the other.

The Buddha woke up early in the morning and surveyed the world with his divine eye, as usual. He saw the danger of war between the two royal families, which were his closest relatives. He went to the River Rohiṇī and saw the armies of Kapilavatthu and of Koliya preparing for war. The Buddha went to the river and sat in the air over the river. When the armies saw the Buddha, and they put down their weapons and bowed to him.

The King of Kapilavatthu and the King of Koliya came and bowed to the Buddha. The Buddha said, "What is this fight about, great kings?" They replied, "I don't know, Bhante." The Buddha said, "Who does know?" The kings told him, "The generals of the armies." The Buddha went to the generals and asked the same questions, and the generals also did not know why they were fighting and said that the lieutenants would know. The Buddha asked the same questions to the lieutenants, who also did not know why they were fighting. The Buddha then went to the farmers, and asked them why they were fighting. The farmers of Koliya said, "Bhante, we are fighting because the farmers of Kapilavatthu are using too much water from the river. We may not have enough." The Sakyan farmers said, "Bhante, we are fighting because the farmers of Koliya think they are

entitled to more water, but they are using too much and they want more."

The Buddha went to the kings of Kapilavatthu and Koliya and asked them, "How much is water worth?" The kings agreed that water was worth very little. The Buddha asked, "How much are your people worth?" They replied that their people were most important, the most valuable. The Buddha said, "Is it right for you to destroy your people just for water, which has so little value?" The Buddha taught them about the harm of making enemies and hatred. He taught them that when they are anxious to get what they want, and they fight over it, insult each other and develop hatred, they live with the disease of unhappiness. After hearing him teach, 250 Sakyas and 250 Koliyas were ordained as monks.

Questions after the story:

1. Why did the Sakyas and Koliyas argue ?
2. What did they need the water for?
3. Why did they get so angry?
4. What happens when people get very angry when they are arguing?
5. What made the kings and armies so angry"
6. Did the kings really know the cause of the fight?
7. What did the Buddha teach the Sakyas and Koliyas?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Māvoca pharusaṃ kañci, vuttā paṭiṅvadeyyu taṃ, dukkhā hi sārambhakathā, paṭidaṇḍhā phuseyyu taṃ."

"Do not speak harshly to anyone, because if you do, they may speak harshly back to you. Angry speech hurts, and retaliation may overtake you."

(Dhammapada 133/10:5)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Everyone knows that arguments can get out of control, with shouting, insults and even hitting. What exactly is an insult?

Words that attack our character, intelligence, ability, the way we do something, or the way we look. It means saying something mean about you to your face. Can you think of some examples? "You can't even do *that*!" "you're fat," "you look like a . . . ," "you sound like a . . . , " "you watch baby shows on TV," "you act like a big baby," "you don't even know *that*?"

In the story, the argument started with a disagreement over water. Why? Because it was something they both wanted. When the other side didn't give them it, they wanted to force them to give it. So, what did they do? They started getting angry and shouting. They felt disgusted with each other. When did the anger grow to extreme anger? When they said painful insults to each other. Then they went to tell their own people about it, involving them in the fight. Why would they tell others? Maybe because they wanted help to take revenge. And the armies did agree to take revenge. Each clan wanted to take revenge on the other. Was it only because of the water? No, it was because of the terrible insults.

Insults cause feelings of not only anger, but also resentment, hatred, revenge, and ill will—wishing something bad would happen to a person. These are some of the most dangerous emotions—they can result in lifelong painful feelings, lifelong enemies, and possibly even killing. As the Buddha says, if we use angry speech or insults, the other person may insult us in return, which could provoke us to take revenge. We may say or do something we will later regret very much.

So it is very important to learn to stop arguments before they get to the point of angry speech and insults. It is also extremely important to learn how to react when someone insults us, so that we do not retaliate (take revenge) by using angry speech or insults. So, we learn to be peacemakers and not get angry when someone insults us.

How can we learn to be peacemakers and stop an argument? We can remember that it takes two people to

argue, so we *can* stop it. Our calmness is the best weapon – when we are calm, the other person notices how outrageous he is acting, and probably will stop. We can ignore the person, or say "I don't want to argue with you," "that's your opinion." Or, we can find a solution, like "let's share—you can have it first," or "let's clean it up together—I'll start." If we did something that the other person is complaining about, we can say "I'm sorry if I did something to upset you. How can I help you feel better?" If the person continues to shout at us, we can appear to agree with him, saying "yes," "uh huh" or "OK" to everything he says. What other things can you say that will discourage someone from arguing?

How can we learn not to get angry when someone insults us? We can remember that an insult is only what *that person* thinks because of his own ignorance, jealousy, anger or ill will. We should not allow that person's insult to bring us down to his level of anger and ill will. We can remember that we are good and they can't bring us down. We improve ourselves, we become stronger in our good character, if we can ignore insults, resist the urge to fight back, and avoid bad feelings. So the person insulting us is actually helping us to become better!

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Role play— Teachers make a list of controversial topics that are age-appropriate for students to discuss. Students divide into pairs, and each pair takes one of the topics for an argument. The partners argue opposite views on the argument, as if representing their "clan" or friends with the same view. One partner tries desperately to win the argument and resorts to angry and insulting speech, and the other partner uses his skill to avoid an angry argument and remain peaceful, using words that he would realistically use in talking with peers.

SUGGESTIONS FOR TOPICS OF ARGUMENT:

whether to require more hours per day at school but attend school 4 days a week

whether to be a vegetarian or not
whether students should be required to dissect animals in science class
whether to have a dress code or uniforms or no dress code at school
whether to raise the minimum age for driver's licenses
whether to broaden or tighten certain rules at school
whether to prohibit students from having jobs so they can study more
whether television is more helpful or more harmful to students

Teacher should instruct students not to use personal insults or bad language, but only silly or general insults for the purpose of the role play (e.g. "you all are clowns, losers, foolish, totally selfish, nerds, geeks, lepers, or obsessed with…, or "you all blabber nonsense").

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 21
Admit Mistakes

Lesson 21
ADMIT MISTAKES

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Did you ever do something wrong, and then you wondered whether you should admit that you did it?

Story: Quarrel at Kosambi

At the Buddha's monastery in Kosambi, there was one monk who was an expert in the Suttas taught by the Buddha, and another monk who was an expert in the monks' disciplinary rules (the Vinaya) taught by the Buddha. One day, the sutta expert went to the bathroom and left a pot of clean water in the bathroom. The Vinaya expert found it, and asked the sutta expert, "Did you leave a pot of water in the bathroom?" The Sutta expert said, "Yes." The Vinaya expert said, "You didn't know that it is a violation of the rules?" The Sutta expert said, "No." The Vinaya expert said, "It is a violation, friend." The Sutta expert said, "Then I will admit my mistake." The Vinaya expert said, "But if you did it unintentionally or because of forgetfulness, it's not a violation." The Sutta expert thought to himself, "OK then I did not commit any violation."

The Vinaya expert told his students, "The Sutta expert does not know when he has committed a violation." Then those students told the Sutta expert's students, "Your teacher violated the rules, but he thinks that he didn't." They told their teacher what the Vinaya expert's students had told them. The Sutta expert replied, "At first, the Vinaya expert said there was no violation. Now he says it is a violation. He is a liar." The Sutta expert's students told the Vinaya expert's students, "Your teacher is a liar."

The Vinaya expert had a discussion among the monks, and they agreed to suspend the Sutta expert for his violation

of the rules. The Sutta expert did not think that he committed a violation, and he thought that it was wrong for him to be suspended. Some monks supported him and agreed that he should not have been suspended. There was now a big disagreement among the monks. The monks who supported the Vinaya expert told the others not to support a suspended monk, but the others supported the Sutta expert anyway.

One of the monks told the Buddha about this big disagreement. The Buddha went to the monks who supported the Vinaya expert and said:"Bhikkhus, don't suspend a bhikkhu just because you think he should be suspended. It is a very serious matter to divide the Sangha. So, don't suspend a monk if he does not see it as a violation, because it will lead to disagreements, arguments, and bad actions. You should respect the other monks."

The Buddha then went to the monks who supported the Sutta expert, and said, "Bhikkhus, don't think that when a violation is committed you don't have to apologize or fix the problem just because you think that you did not do a violation. If a monk violates a rule but does not think it is wrong, other monks will see that it is wrong. So, a bhikkhu who violates a rule should admit the violation, to be considerate of the others. If he doesn't, there will be disagreements, arguments, and bad actions."

Questions after the story:

1. What violation did the Vinaya expert think that the Sutta expert committed?
2. Do you think the Vinaya expert should have complained about such a small thing?
3. Did the Sutta expert admit his mistake?
4. Then what did the Vinaya expert say?
5. Did the Sutta expert then think he committed a violation of the rules?
6. What happened after the Vinaya expert told his students that the Sutta expert violated the rules?

7. Do you think the Sutta expert should tell others that the Vinaya expert is a liar?
8. Do you think the students of the monks did anything wrong?
9. What did the Buddha teach each group?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Na paresaṃ vilomāni, na paresaṃ katākataṃ, attano va avekkheyya, katāni akatāni ca."

"Do not find fault with others, do not watch what others do or did not do. But let us see our own acts, what we do and what we fail to do." (Dhammapada 50/4:7)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Everyone makes mistakes, right? We all have weaknesses and faults. No one is perfect always. So, should we ignore our mistakes? Should we expect others to ignore our mistakes? No. As the Buddha taught the monks, if we do something wrong, or if we didn't do something we should have done, we should admit our fault (that we did something wrong or made a mistake) and apologize. Our apology should be very sincere, not just an automatic "Sorry."

As we learned from the story, we should apologize even if we are not sure we really did something wrong, so that others don't get upset with us. That doesn't mean that we should apologize for something we did not do. We can say, "If I did something wrong, I am very sorry." If we did something wrong but honestly did not intend to do something wrong, should we apologize? Yes. For example, we can say, "I didn't intend to hurt you, but I am very sorry that I hurt you." We can hurt someone very much even if we did not intend to hurt them. In some situations it may be difficult to admit fault and say "I'm sorry," but that is the way to be friendly and peaceful. Others can easily forgive us. They may think that we are arrogant and uncaring if we don't. It is also better to apologize than to give excuses.

When someone else does something wrong and they get in trouble, do you like to tell your friends about it? Even the students of the Sutta and Vinaya experts liked to tell the other students about the wrongdoing of others—their teacher. Why do we enjoy it when others do wrong things or make mistakes? Maybe because we feel better about ourselves. We think, "Oooooh, you did something bad. *I* wouldn't do *that*." But the Buddha teaches us *not* to look for others' mistakes and wrongdoing. He teaches us to look for our *own* mistakes and wrongdoing. When you point your your finger at someone, what happens to the other fingers? Try it. Three fingers are pointing back at you. That means when you point out someone else's wrong, then you should look three times more at your own wrongdoing. What do you think about that? Do you like to pay attention to your mistakes and misbehavior? Most people don't like to do that! We don't like to feel guilty or think about what we do wrong. And we don't like to admit to others what we do wrong. We don't like to make mistakes, and we don't want to feel we are bad, clumsy or ignorant. We want to feel good about ourselves.

But can we really feel good about ourselves if we just ignore our mistakes and wrongdoing? That is like pretending we are good when we are not, or like wearing clean clothes and pretending we are clean when we didn't take a bath. That is being dishonest with ourselves. The only way we can get clean is to admit to ourselves that we didn't take a bath, and then take a bath, right? Pretending we took a bath won't get us clean!

Similarly, when we make a mistake or do something wrong, we should admit we did it, apologize *and* fix the problem: do what we should have done, or find a way to help undo the wrong. If we broke or lost someone's toy, we should admit it, apologize, and get it repaired, get him a new one, or give him one of your toys of equal value. If we upset someone, we should do something special that shows we care about her very much.

When we are honest with ourselves, noticing our mistakes and wrongdoing, then we can stop doing wrong and stop making those mistakes. If we ignore our mistakes and wrongdoing, what happens? We will continue making them. Noticing our mistakes turns into a good habit of correcting ourselves. The more mistakes we notice, the more we can correct ourselves, and the better we become. Then we don't have to worry about getting in trouble. That is the best way to *really* feel good about ourselves!

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Noting our mistakes— Each student writes a list of actions they did that were not good, and good things that they should have done but didn't do, over the past week. The teacher can prompt with suggestions: Did you have any arguments with sisters or brothers? Did you do everything your parents asked you to do without being told twice? Did you keep your room clean every day? Did you help your parents? Did you finish all of your homework every day? Did you watch too much TV? Did you say anything that was untrue? Did you say any angry words? Did a teacher have to ask you to stop talking in class? Were you late to a class? Did you complain to your parents about what they gave you or what they didn't give you?

Students make a grid with the list as the y-axis and the days of the week as the x-axis, so there is a box for each item on the list for each day of the week. During the next week, each day the students check any boxes on the grid to note any mistakes made that day. They can add any new mistakes to the list. They bring the grid with them to the next class.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 22
Avoid Bad Company

Lesson 22
AVOID BAD COMPANY

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Did you ever wonder whether you might get in trouble if you associate with a certain kid or certain group of kids?

Story: Quarrel at Kosambi Part 2

The Buddha taught the monks at Kosambi that they should admit their mistakes, even if they are not sure they are wrong, and warned them about the fighting that might result if they don't. After he taught them about it, he went away from the monks. Then, the bickering among the monks got worse. They argued loudly and forcefully, and hurt each other's feelings with angry speech and insults. They could not resolve the disagreement.

One of the monks went to the Buddha, bowed to him, and described what was going on at the monastery—the bickering, arguing, angry words, bad feelings, and stubborn refusal to end the arguments. The monk said, "Bhante, it would be good if you would go to visit those monks with compassion." The Buddha silently agreed to visit. He went to the monks at Kosambi and told them to stop their arguing and quarreling. One monk said, "Bhante, you are the master of Dharma, please stay here and live pleasantly. Don't concern yourself with this. We are the ones who will be known for this disputing and quarreling." Again the Buddha told the monks to stop, and the monk gave the same response. After the Buddha told them to stop for the third time, and the monks did not agree to stop, the Buddha thought, "These monks seem obsessed. It is impossible to make them understand the wrong that they are doing." Then he left.

In the morning, after he went with his bowl to the village to receive food, he sat down, and said aloud, "When many voices are shouting, no one thinks, 'I'm being a fool, I was part of this fight, I helped cause this.' They forget to speak with wisdom, their minds are obsessed with talking, they don't control their mouths. They don't even know what causes them to act like that. They think, 'He did something bad to me,' and feel hatred. But that hatred is never calmed by hatred. Hatred is calmed by controlling ourselves, by understanding, forgiving and forgetting the wrong done to us. If you can find a wise friend who leads a virtuous life, then keep company with him, joyfully and mindfully, and you can overcome danger. If you cannot find a wise friend who leads a virtuous life, then, like a king who leaves behind a conquered kingdom, or like a lone elephant in the forest, you should go your way alone. There is no friendship with fools. Walk alone, and harm no one, and you will have no conflict. Be like an elephant alone in the forest."

Then the Buddha went away to another village, to the Eastern Bamboo Park. When he arrived, the park security guard saw the Buddha coming and tried to prevent him from coming in so no one would disturb the three monks living there. Ven. Anuruddha told him to let the Buddha in, that he is their teacher. Ven Anuruddha called the other two monks, and they prepared a seat for the Buddha. He asked them whether they were well, comfortable and had enough food. He also asked whether they lived in harmony with each other, viewing each other with kind eyes. They said "Yes, Bhante." He asked Ven. Anuruddha, "How do you do that?" Ven Anuruddha answered, "I think it is so fortunate that I am living with such friends in the holy life. I have acts, words and thoughts of loving-kindness to these other monks always. I think, why should I do what I want to do, why not do what they want to do." When the Buddha asked the other two monks how they got along, they said the same thing. The Buddha asked them whether they were diligent in their practice and self-controlled, and they said yes, and

he asked them how they did so. They said that whoever arrives first from the village with their food sets out the seats, water, and garbage bucket, and whoever arrives last cleans up after the meal. They said that whoever notices that something needs to be done does it, and that they help each other. After the Buddha talked about Dharma with them, he left.

He sat alone and thought about how he had lived in discomfort, pestered by the monks at Kosambi who were arguing and fighting, and now that he was alone, he was living peacefully. He saw an elephant who had been pestered by the other elephants in the herd, who also came there to live alone.

In Kosambi, the villagers noticed that the Buddha had left Kosambi, and they thought, "These monks here bothered the Buddha until he left. Let's ignore them and not honor or respect them anymore, and let's not give them any more food. Then they will either leave or correct themselves with the Buddha." Sure enough, the Kosambi monks decided to visit the Buddha and settle their quarrel. The Sutta expert, who had been suspended, thought about what had happened: "I *did* violate the rules, and I *was* properly suspended," and he told his friends that. They all went together to the Buddha, and because he admitted his wrongdoing, the Buddha told him his suspension was over and he was reinstated back into the Sangha. The quarrel was over.

Questions after the story:

1. What did the Buddha do when the monks would not stop fighting?
2. The Buddha taught that hatred is never calmed by what?
3. How do we calm hatred?
4. If we can't find a wise and virtuous friend, what does the Buddha say we should do?
5. How did Ven. Anuruddha and the other two monks

live so peacefully together?
6. What animal did the Buddha see in the forest when he was alone?
7. What happened at Kosambi after the Buddha left?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"No ce labhetha nipakaṃ sahāyaṃ, saddhiṃ caraṃ sādhuvihāridhīraṃ, rājā va raṭṭhaṃ vijitaṃ pahāya, eko care mātaṅgaraññe va nāgo."

"If you cannot find a wise friend who leads a virtuous life, then, like a king who leaves a conquered kingdom, or like a lone elephant in the forest, you should go your way alone." (Dhammapada 329/23:10)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Do you have wise friends who lead virtuous lives? What does that mean? A friend who does not harm others, steal, lie, or misbehave, who is honest, trustworthy, disciplined, tolerant, compassionate and respectful. Are your friends like Ven. Anuruddha and his friends? Do you easily agree on what to do, because each of you is willing to do what the other wants to do? Do you each see what needs to be done and help each other? Do you all act and speak kindly to each other? Usually at school or in our neighborhood, there are some kids who are virtuous and who we can be friends with.

But sometimes we find that the kids around us are not that way. Maybe they like to argue and fight, like the monks at Kosambi. Maybe they misbehave in other ways. What should we do? The Buddha tells us to "go our way alone," like a lone elephant, or a king who leaves a kingdom. Why did he say like an *elephant* or a *king*? Because we respect kings and elephants very much. And if you leave misbehaved kids alone and stay away from them, then you are being very honorable, too. Rather than thinking of yourself as unpopular or not worthy of friends, you are doing the best thing for yourself, and you are worthy of

great respect by good people. Soon you will find virtuous friends to be with, particularly those who are learning Dharma, like you are.

What if we are with kids who misbehave in some ways, but they are fun to be with—should we just hope they get better? As we learned in an earlier lesson, other people's misbehavior influences us no matter how sure we are that we can be a good example, or that we will not get drawn into misbehavior. One person's misbehavior very easily spreads to others who associate with him or her, leading them into wrong acts, bad talk or bad thoughts. When it seems difficult to stay away from those kids, we can remember how difficult it was for Prince Siddhattha to leave his wife and new baby, and after he became the Buddha, how he stayed alone in the forest when other monks misbehaved.

Sometimes, a friend who we thought was virtuous starts to misbehave. Should we just ignore it and hope he or she stops misbehaving? Should we say something to him or her about it? It depends on the situation. If it is serious misbehavior, we should stay away. If it is something not so serious, we can gently point it out in a way that is not arrogant but shows that we don't agree with it. For example, we can say, "I don't think you should lie." If he or she disagrees with us, that indicates that he or she intends to continue to misbehave, and is a signal for us to stay away. When you stay away from a friend, they may get the message, like the Kosambi monks got the message to stop misbehaving when the villagers stayed away and did not take care of them. Then they might either stop misbehaving or find other friends.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Clay sculpture — Teacher brings a piece of clay ("Fimo" or other modeling clay) for each student, toothpicks and popsicle sticks for shaping the clay, plastic placemats for easy-clean-up work surfaces, and maybe also an example of a clay elephant or toy elephant. Each student shapes the clay

into an elephant. Eyes can be made with tiny beads or seeds. Ears can be made by flattening two small balls of clay and sticking them onto the head using popsicle sticks. Rolling pieces of clay into the shape of a rope, then sticking them on the body, creates trunk, tail and tusks.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā!
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 23
Confidence

Lesson 23
CONFIDENCE

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Did you ever think, "I'm just a regular person, I don't think I could ever be a great holy person?"

Story: Aṅgulimāla

A boy called Ahiṃsaka, which means "one who does no harm," grew up to be a robber and murderer in the kingdom of Kosala. He was violent and did not seem to care about any living beings. When he murdered someone, he cut off a finger and wore it on a necklace of many fingers around his neck, so he was then called Aṅgulimāla, which means finger-necklace. The people of all villages and towns in the area heard about him and were frightened. They traveled only in large groups to avoid being murdered, and avoided going on one certain road where Aṅgulimāla was often hiding.

One morning, the Buddha went to the town of Sāvatthī to receive food, and after his meal, he started walking down that certain road where Aṅgulimāla often killed people. Several people saw the Buddha walking on that road, and each one told him not to go on that road because the robber Aṅgulimāla is there, and even groups of 40 men have been killed on that road by him. But the Buddha just continued walking on the road in silence.

Aṅgulimāla saw the Buddha coming, and he was surprised that a monk would come alone. He thought, "Why not kill this monk, too." With his sword and bows and arrows, he started running up to the Buddha. Aṅgulimāla ran as fast as he could, but he could not run fast enough to reach the Buddha. But the Buddha was walking slowly! Aṅgulimāla thought, "I can run and catch an elephant, a

horse or a deer, but I cannot catch up to this monk who is just walking!" This was because of the Buddha's powers.

Finally, after running as fast as he could possibly go, panting, sweating and gasping for breath, while the Buddha only walked, he called out, "Stop, monk! Stop!" The Buddha said, "I have stopped, Aṅgulimāla. You stop also." Aṅgulimāla was confused; he did not know what the Buddha meant. He said, "While you are walking, you tell me you have stopped, but when I stop, you say I have not stopped. Monk, what do you mean by that? How can you have stopped and I haven't?" The Buddha answered, "I have stopped forever doing violence to any living being. But you have no self control toward anything. That is why you have not stopped."

Aṅgulimāla had a sudden change of mind. He said, "Finally, a wise man I can revere, this monk has appeared here in this forest. I will surely give up all evil, hearing him speak the Dharma." Aṅgulimāla threw away his weapons and bowed to the Buddha's feet, and asked the Buddha to ordain him as a monk.

The Buddha only said, "Come, bhikkhu." And that was how he was ordained. Aṅgulimāla became the Buddha's attendant monk. The people in the towns and villages did not know this, however. They went to King Pasenadi to demand that the terrible robber Aṅgulimāla be destroyed. So, King Pasenadi with 500 other men went out on horseback, to try to find and destroy Aṅgulimāla. They saw the Buddha, who asked the king what was wrong. The king told the Buddha about the murderer Aṅgulimāla with his finger-necklace, and the king's plan to put an end to him. The Buddha said, "Dear king, if you saw that Aṅgulimāla had shaved his head, put on a monk's robe, gotten ordained, and followed all of the monks' rules, living the holy life, would you still do that to him?" The king said, "I would bow and treat him properly as a monk, but he is evil, so how could he have such virtue and self-control?" Just then, the Buddha pointed to Aṅgulimāla and said, "There is Aṅgulimāla."

The king was shocked. The Buddha said, "Don't be afraid, there is nothing to fear." The king said, "Let the noble monk allow me to look after all of his needs." Ven. Aṅgulimāla said he didn't need anything. King Pasenadi said how wonderful it is that the Buddha could calm and quieten such a person who was so out of control, without any weapons or punishment.

One morning, Ven. Aṅgulimāla went with his bowl to receive food, and he saw a woman who was in terrible distress with a deformed child.[2] He thought, "What horrible things people must suffer," and went to the Buddha and told him what he saw. The Buddha told him to go and say to that woman, "Since I was born, I have never purposely taken the life of a living being. By that truth, may you and the child have peace." Ven. Aṅgulimāla said, "Bhante, wouldn't I be lying? I purposely took the lives of many living beings." The Buddha said, "Tell her that since you were born with the noble birth you have never purposely taken the life of a living being." So, Ven. Aṅgulimāla went to the woman and said, "Sister, since I was born with the noble birth I have never purposely taken the life of a living being. By that truth, may you and your child have peace." And the woman and her child felt very peaceful from that time onward. Ven Aṅgulimāla sat alone, meditating, completely controlling his mind, and then realized Truth. He knew that he would have no more births and he became an Arahant.

One day, he went out to receive food, and people threw rocks and sticks at him, making his head bleed; his bowl was broken, and his robes were torn. When he got back, the Buddha said, "You must take this pain. You are experiencing the results of the acts you did before. You

2. The teacher may exercise discretion as to whether to tell this according to the traditional story of the woman in pain trying to give birth to a child who is turned around in the womb, and then giving birth successfully after Aṅgulimala told her what the Buddha instructed him to say.

could have experienced the results of your kamma for many, many years in hell."

When Ven. Aṅgulimāla was alone, he thought, "One who lived recklessly, but is never again reckless, one who did bad deeds but now buries them with good deeds, one who as a young monk has devotion to the Buddha's Dharma, he lights up the world like a full moon. Let my enemies hear the Dharma, let them serve the people who serve the Dharma because they are at peace. Let my enemies hear about forbearance and kindness. Then they would not wish to harm me, they would not want to hurt other beings but would guard and protect them. So let my enemies attain peace. I was obnoxious in the past, but I am innocent now. My name Ahiṃsaka is now true, I don't hurt anyone. Although I was the robber Aṅgulimāla, I went for refuge to the Buddha. I did so many acts that would have led to births in horrible places, but I now will have no more births. Don't be reckless and run after desires; that is foolish. But diligently meditate to reach the highest bliss."

Questions after the story:

1. Why was the Buddha not afraid of Aṅgulimāla?
2. Why couldn't Aṅgulimāla run up to the Buddha and kill him?
3. What did the Buddha mean when he said that he has stopped and told Aṅgulimāla to stop, but the Buddha was walking and Aṅgulimāla had already stopped running?
4. Why did Aṅgulimāla throw his weapons away and want to be ordained?
5. What happened when King Pasenadi saw Aṅgulimāla as a monk?
6. What did the Buddha tell Ven. Aṅgulimāla to say to the woman with her child?
7. Why did people throw rocks and sticks at Ven Aṅgulimāla?

8. How did the Buddha explain the pain Ven. Aṅgulimāla had to suffer?
9. What did Ven. Aṅgulimāla wish for his enemies?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Yassa pāpam kataṃ kammaṃ, kusalena pithīyathi, so imaṃ lokaṃ pabhāseti, abbhā mutto va candimā."

"He who by good deeds covers the evil he has done, illuminates this world like the moon freed from clouds." (Dhammapada 173/13:7)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

What do you think made Aṅgulimāla change from a robber and murderer to a monk? He had confidence in the Buddha. He saw that the Buddha's power from not harming any living beings was much greater and stronger than Aṅgulimāla's own physical strength and evil power over others. He realized that he was out of control—he did not have self-control, so his mind was weak. The Buddha had no fear, he did not hate Aṅgulimāla, and the Buddha had great wisdom and self-control. Aṅgulimāla admired that, and had confidence that the Buddha could help him.

Why did the Buddha advise Aṅgulimāla to tell the woman that he has never taken the life of any being since he was born with the noble birth, and that by the truth of those words, may she have peace? Maybe Aṅgulimāla would be worried and guilty about his terrible past and therefore wouldn't be brave enough to say those words. He had to admit that since his *birth*, he had taken many lives. But since his *noble birth*—his birth from a man to a monk—he had never taken a life. He had done only good deeds since then. So, by saying those words, he would realize that he is a new person, a good person, not the person he was in the past. So without any worry, with complete confidence, he could bless the woman and bring peace to her.

But, Ven. Aṅgulimāla also had to realize that past kamma does not disappear when a person becomes good.

He must suffer the results of it. So, he had to suffer the pain and embarrassment of people throwing things at him in disgust. If he had not done good deeds (*puññakamma*) and become a pure person, he would have gone to hell for a very long time for his misbehavior. But because he became very pure, he had to endure much less pain resulting from his past kamma.

So, what did Aṅgulimāla gain when he met the Buddha, and again when he blessed the woman? He gained confidence: confidence that the Buddha's teaching could help him, and confidence that he had a new life as a good person following Dharma. So, he had great confidence in the Dharma. We can see from this story that even if we have misbehaved, we can have confidence that following the Dharma can turn us around to be absolutely good, peaceful and happy. We should never give up on ourselves; we should not feel that we can never live a holy life. If Aṅgulimāla can do it, so can we!

But that means we must be diligent—keep trying—to avoid all evil, do good deeds, and cleanse our mind, as the Buddha has said. How do we avoid all evil? We *notice* when we do wrong acts, say angry words, and have bad thoughts, and stop them. We stay away from bad influences—misbehaved people, violent TV, and places where people are likely to misbehave. How do we do good deeds and cleanse our mind? We have virtuous friends, we keep busy with good actions, we read wholesome books, we learn and practice Dharma. If we do these things, we can have confidence, like Aṅgulimāla, that we will be happy and peaceful with a good "bright" future, like the moon coming out from the clouds.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Each student writes the quotation of Buddha on paper. On one half of the paper, each student draws a picture of Aṅgulimāla before he met the Buddha, and on the other half, Aṅgulimāla after he met the Buddha.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Like Ven. Aṅgulimāla, we can wish that those people who have hurt us will hear the Dharma and become peaceful, and not want to harm us or anyone anymore. May they have happy minds also!

Lesson 24
Forbearance

Lesson 24
FORBEARANCE

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Has anyone ever said or done something unkind, cruel or uncaring to you so you wanted to "get him back" or punish him for what he did?

Story: Sundarī

The Buddha and his bhikkhus were living at Jetavana Monastery at Sāvatthī, where the people had great reverence for them and provided all of their needs—food, robes, shelter and medicines. But there were some wandering ascetics who were not so well cared-for. They felt envious that the people of the town cared more for the Buddha and the Sangha than for them. Among those ascetics was a wandering lady ascetic named Sundarī, who was beautiful and young. The ascetics said to her, "Sister, will you do a favor for us, your relatives?" She answered, "What would you like me to do? I would do anything for my relatives, even give up my life for them." They said, "Visit Jetavana Monastery often." She agreed. She knew what they wanted her to do—to make it seem that she was secretly and privately visiting with the Buddha. That would ruin his reputation, so the people of Sāvatthī would stop caring for him and his bhikkhus, and care for the ascetics instead.

Sundarī dressed nicely and went to Jetavana Monastery in the evening, when the people were leaving the monastery to go home. They thought it was unusual for a lady to go alone to the monastery after the program was over. After she passed them, she went to the ascetics' homes. Early in the morning, when the people were coming to see the Buddha, she was seen walking from the Jetavana Monastery, so it appeared that she had spent the night with the Buddha.

After a few days, when many people had seen her going to Jetavana Monastery in the evening and returning in the morning, the ascetics had her killed and buried in a hole in a ditch near Jetavana Monastery. The ascetics went to King Pasenadi and reported to him that they could not find Sundarī. When the king asked where she might be, they said she may be at Jetavana Monastery. So the king told them to look for her there.

The ascetics went to the monastery and searched all around, and then dug her body up out of the hole. They put her on a stretcher and carried her into the town of Sāvatthī, shouting "Look at what the followers of Gotama have done! These sons of the Sakyas are shameless wicked liars who do evil things. They claim to practice Dharma, speak truth and be virtuous—but they are not monks, they are not leading a religious life, they are not holy men. How can they do this to her and then kill her?"

Then the people of Sāvatthī were horrified and angry. When they saw the Buddha's monks, they repeated what the ascetics had said, shouted insults and nasty accusations at them, and called them bad names. The bhikkhus were embarrassed and upset and reported to the Buddha what was happening.

The Buddha said, "This noise won't last long. It will only last seven days. When people insult you, say this: "The liar goes to the hell-world, also he, having done wrong, who says 'I did not do it.' People who do such bad actions have that destiny in the next life."

When the bhikkhus went out again, the people insulted them again, and the bhikkhus calmly told them what the Buddha taught them to say: "The liar goes to the hell-world, also he, having done wrong, who says 'I did not do it.' People who do such bad actions have that destiny in the next life." When the people heard that, they thought, "These bhikkhus, the sons of the Sakyas, must not have done this horrible thing." Sure enough, after seven days, the insults and shouting stopped. Several bhikkhus went to the

Buddha, who said, "When harsh words are spoken, just endure them with an undisturbed mind."

Later, the king and people of Sāvatthī found out that the ascetics had hired someone to kill Sundarī and put her body at Jetavana Monastery. The ascetics were punished by the king, and the Buddha and the Sangha were again highly honored and well taken care of.

Questions after the story:

1. Why were the ascetics envious of the Buddha and his monks?
2. Why did the ascetics ask Sundarī to go to Jetavana Monastery?
3. Why do you think they had her killed?
4. Was their plan successful?
5. What did the Buddha tell the monks to do when people said terrible things about them?
6. How long did the Buddha say the problem would last?
7. What advice did the Buddha have when harsh words are spoken?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Abhūtavādī nirayaṃ upeti, yo vāpi katvā na karomī' ti cāha ubho pi te pecca samā bhavanti, nihīnakammā manujā parattha."

"The liar goes to the hell-world, also he, having done wrong, who says 'I did not do it.' People who do such bad actions have the same destiny in the next life."

(Dhammapada 306/22:1)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

When someone does or says something unkind, uncaring or cruel to us, it is painful. How would you feel if someone humiliated you or shamed you in front of your friends, like the ascetics and people of Sāvatthī did to the bhikkhus? The ascetics shamed the Buddha and bhikkhus in front of the whole town of Sāvatthī, including their friends and

supporters. How does a normal person react when he is shamed like that, or if his family or friend is shamed like that? He might feel so angry that he wants to immediately hurt those who did that, or somehow punish them and make them feel bad for such cruel behavior. His mind would become very disturbed and obsessed with thoughts of revenge and plans of how to do it.

So, sometimes, it is very difficult to do what the Buddha said when very harsh words are spoken, to "just endure them with an undisturbed mind." What did we learn from previous lessons not to do when someone argues, insults us or shouts at us? We should not argue, and not speak angry or insulting words. We learned that insults cause feelings of anger, hatred, revenge, and ill will, which can result in long-lasting pain and possibly violence. If we use angry speech or insults, then what happens? The other person might insult us back or do something else to upset us, which could provoke us to take revenge, and do things that we will regret later.

What if someone does something very unfair or abusive to you, or says something bad about you to others, how do you feel? We may feel angry, hateful, or revengeful. We want to stop that person from ever doing it again. We want to prove to him how wrong and bad he is, or punish him. Our minds become irritated and focused on how we will "teach him a lesson," "get him back for what he did." These are revengeful thoughts. With these thoughts, we might do something that we will regret later.

How can we avoid that? How can we control our minds when we are so upset and angry? It is best not to talk to the person who upset us, because it is likely to become an argument or a fight. We are not as calm and self-controlled as the bhikkhus, so we probably should not say to others that liars will go to a hell-world; they may feel insulted and attack us. Instead, there are some things that we can *do*, and some things that we can *think*, to control our mind, mouth, and actions.

Here are some things that we can do: (1) quickly walk away from the person to show that we will not listen to him any more and to prevent ourselves from saying or doing something in revenge; (2) get a drink of water or juice to cool down our emotions; (3) do some work to keep busy; (4) listen to music that makes us feel happy; (5) write in a diary or journal; (6) read a good book; or (7) take a walk outside. Can you think of some other things that may help calm your mind?

Even if we do these things, we also need to get rid of revengeful and angry thoughts. How? We can remember not to allow a person's cruelty to bring us down to his level of anger and ill will. Remember that we are good and that person can't bring us down. Remember that our calmness is the best weapon against him. He did the bad act, so by the Law of Karma, what will happen? He will get exactly what he deserves—the bad result of that action, sooner or later. If he says bad things about us or is abusive or unfair to us, those are not *our* words and deeds, they are *his*—so let him keep them! Don't think about them! They are his problem, his weakness. As the Buddha said, a liar and people who do bad actions will go to a hell-world. So *we* don't need to punish him, because his own kamma will punish him. If we try to punish him, then what happens to us? Then *we* will suffer the result of that revengeful deed. Also, we should not *wish* for him to suffer—that is ill will. Instead, we can have compassion for him for the pain he will suffer, and for the unhappiness he has now that makes him want to hurt another person. And we should not gossip about the person.

If we control ourselves by resisting the urge to punish him, insult him or use angry words, then we are practicing *forbearance* (*khanti*), which makes us stronger. Is it true that if we walk away from rather than fight or argue with someone who is cruel to us that we are *stronger*? Who was stronger, Aṅgulimāla or the Buddha? Aṅgulimāla had a strong body but the Buddha was much stronger overall because he had

the enormous strength of self-control. Aṅgulimāla totally gave in to the Buddha. When we control our emotions, our mouth, or minds, then we are much stronger than if we shout and fight. So, if someone is cruel to us, and we are self-controlled and don't take revenge—don't shout, argue or fight back—then he is actually helping us become stronger, to have forbearance (*khanti*), and to have better character!

Activity to reinforce the lesson: (next page)

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

MULTIPLE CHOICE—CIRCLE THE BEST ANSWER:

1. If a person insults your best friend, it is best for you to:
   a. say she or he will go to a hell-world
   b. walk away from your friend
   c. tell your friend to fight back
   d. walk with your friend away from that person
2. If someone calls you bad names, it is best to:
   a. think about some bad names you could call him
   c. ignore him
   b. enjoy thoughts of how he will feel in a hell-world
   d. think about the person
3. If you feel very angry for what someone said about you, it is better to:
   a. call a friend and tell her how bad that person is
   b. drink water and read a good book
   c. think about how to punish that person
   d. think about that person
4. You can make yourself strong by:
   a. having forbearance
   b. having self-control
   c. not fighting back
   d. a, b, and c
5. If you are thinking about punishing someone for hurting you, change your thoughts by:
   a. listening to music
   b. thinking about how bad he is
   c. doing some homework
   d. a and c
6. Forbearance means:
   a. helping others
   b. not taking revenge
   c. resisting the urge to shout at someone
   d. b and c
7. If a person says or does something bad to you:
   a. his words and acts belong to him
   b. you can gossip about him
   c. you must suffer from his bad words and acts
   d. if he doesn't believe in kamma he won't suffer

Lesson 25
Meditation

Lesson 25
MEDITATION

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever thought, meditation is difficult and is not very helpful to me?

Story: Soṇa Kolivisa

In a village in the land of Magadha in India lived the Kolivisa clan. A millionaire in the Kolivisa clan had a son named Soṇa. From the time he was born, little Soṇa received lavish gifts and had every luxury. He had three mansions, and he even had 60 nurses to take care of him. He never had to do any kind of work at all. His skin was so soft and delicate that even his feet were completely soft. They were so soft that there was very soft hair growing on the bottom of his feet. That was very unusual, and people were amazed when they saw it. So to protect his feet from getting rough and losing the hair on them, he never walked on the ground. If he became upset, he would often threaten to walk on the ground, so people just did whatever he wanted.

King Bimbisāra, the King of Magadha, invited a person from each of the 80,000 villages in Magadha to visit him, and also invited Soṇa. To prepare Soṇa for the visit, his parents told him, "King Bimbisāra wants to see your feet. But you cannot disrespect him by stretching your feet toward him. Instead, show him your feet by sitting cross-legged in front of him, with the bottoms of your feet turned up so he can see them."

The Kolivisa family had servants carry Soṇa to the King's palace on a palanquin (a little carriage held on their shoulders). Soṇa bowed to the king and sat in front of him as his parents told him to do, and the king saw the soft hair growing on Soṇa's feet. The king was amazed. Then the king

spoke to the big crowd of people, including Soṇa. He instructed them about what goals they should accomplish in their lives. At the end of his speech, he told them to see the Buddha, who will instruct them about goals they should accomplish for future lives.

So the 80,000 people from the villages went with Soṇa to see the Buddha. When they arrived there, the Buddha taught them that happiness comes from reducing desires, not running after desires. After the dharma talk, the people took refuge in the Buddha, the Dharma and the Sangha, and went back home. But Soṇa wanted to stay. He asked the Buddha to be ordained as a monk. The Buddha said he could if his parents agreed. He got permission from his parents, and then got ordained.

Soṇa was very eager to experience the happiness that the Buddha was talking about. He had experienced every kind of pleasure and wealth that he could ask for, but he had not experienced real happiness. So he went to find a lonely place out in the forest to meditate. As he walked in the forest, he tried to be constantly mindful. He sat down at a nice place and closed his eyes and tried to concentrate and calm his mind. He sat for a long time and tried and tried to concentrate his mind, but his mind just kept thinking about all sorts of things. So, he tried walking meditation. He walked slowly and mindfully until his tender feet got blisters and then began to bleed. Still, he could not calm his mind enough to experience real happiness.

Day after day, Soṇa went to the same beautiful place in the forest to meditate. He sat and tried to meditate, but his mind would not calm down much. He tried walking meditation, but his thoughts would not slow down. He just kept thinking and thinking, not meditating. He became frustrated, and thought, "This is no use. I tried so hard to meditate. But I didn't get the happiness I was hoping for. I should just return to life with my family. I can offer food and things to the monks to make merit. That will give me at least some happiness."

On the day he felt like giving up being a monk, the Buddha came to visit Soṇa in his meditation place. Soṇa offered him a seat and bowed to him. The Buddha said, "Soṇa, weren't you thinking that you tried very hard to meditate, but your heart was not at peace, and that you didn't get the happiness that you wished for? And that you wanted to return to your family and give food and necessities to the monks to make merit?" Soṇa replied, "Yes, Bhante." The Buddha said, "You used to play the lute [a stringed instrument], didn't you? Weren't you a good lute player?" Soṇa nodded. The Buddha said, "If the strings are too tight, does the lute sound nice?" Soṇa replied, "No, Bhante." The Buddha continued, "If the strings are too loose, does the lute sound nice?" Soṇa replied, "No, Bhante." The Buddha said, "If the strings are not too tight or too loose, does the lute sound nice?" "Yes, Bhante." The Buddha asked, "Soṇa, why didn't you experience happiness? You are straining too hard. Trying too hard leads to agitation. Not trying hard enough leads to laziness. Meditate in a relaxed way, but without laziness. Try again. You will get good results." The Buddha paused, and then asked, "Will you stay as a monk and try again?"

Soṇa agreed, and the next day, he sat to meditate. This time, he did not force his mind to stay still. Instead, he watched his thoughts, and let them come and go. When his thoughts started going too fast, and he noticed that he wasn't watching them come and go anymore, he paid attention to his breathing. He noticed everything about his breathing. His mind became more and more calm, until he could watch each thought arising and going away. His mind became still. He felt not even the slightest worry, anxiety, displeasure, discomfort, expectation, or desire. He felt complete happiness. Now, finally, he could meditate.

Questions after the story:

1. What kind of lifestyle did Soṇa have when he was growing up?

2. What did his parents tell him not to do when he meets the king? Why?
3. Whom did the king tell the crowd of people to see?
4. Why did Soṇa want to be ordained?
5. What happened when he went out in the forest?
6. What happened to his feet when he did walking meditation?
7. What did the Buddha say was the reason Soṇa could not meditate well?
8. What leads to agitation when you are trying to meditate?
9. What leads to laziness when you are trying to meditate?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Suppabuddhaṃ pabujjhānti sadā Gotamasāvakā,
yesaṃ divā ca ratto ca, bhāvanāya rato mano."

"Those students of Gotama always awaken happily, whose minds delight in the practice of meditation by day and night."

(Dhammapada 301/21:12)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

The Buddha talks about the delight in practicing meditation. "*Bhāvana*" is the Pali word for meditation. Are you delighted about meditation? Do you awaken happily? Maybe you are like Soṇa Kolivisa, in that you haven't discovered the happiness of meditation yet. You are trying but it really isn't working for you. Maybe you are a bit too lazy when you try to meditate, so you feel sleepy or you just daydream, maybe thinking about what you want to do later, or thinking about others around you. Or maybe you are trying too hard, trying to force your mind to focus, and getting annoyed when you get distracted with many thoughts, so you give up.

Meditation is like a sport or skill that takes a lot of practice to learn. If we want to learn to play a sport, just like

if we want to learn to meditate, we need a teacher to guide us, and regular practice. The best way to have regular practice is to spend a few moments *each day* – maybe just a minute or two – in meditation, at the same time in your morning or evening routine. Choose the best time for you: when you get out of bed or just after you finish getting dressed in the morning, or just before bed in the evening. When it is such a short time, and at the same time every day, you cannot say that you don't have enough time, or that you forgot. When you do this daily, then you will have a lifelong habit of meditation, which is sure to lead to success and happiness.

It is best to have a certain place for meditation, which is quiet, neat and clean. A shrine in your house is an ideal place. You can make a small shrine in your bedroom by putting a small Buddha or other religious statue or picture on a nightstand, bookcase or small table, and keeping that area clean and free of clutter and worldly things. You can sit cross-legged on the floor, your spine and upper buttocks supported by a small pillow or folded blanket.

The next thing we need is effort (*viriya*) and diligence (*appamāda*). Do you remember what *appamāda* means? We learned in a previous lesson that *appamāda* means dedication, diligence and alertness; doing something carefully with great interest, effort, energy and attention. We should not just sit, close our eyes and get it overwith, or pretend to meditate but just daydream. We should sit in proper meditation position, remember how our teacher taught us to meditate and do our best to follow those instructions.

What do we mean by effort (*viriya*)? It means perseverance, persistent effort, when you determine to do something and keep trying, struggling, overcoming difficulties and failures, not giving up. We talked about this in the lesson about Siddhattha not getting enlightened even after six years practicing extreme self-torture as an ascetic in the forest, and still trying to become enlightened. We don't

have to do that to practice meditation! We only need to practice a little bit of meditation regularly and not give up, even if it is not fun and not giving us happiness yet. We bathe and brush our teeth every day, and that is not particularly fun, but we do it to clean our body and mouth. You will be glad that you did, so you don't have rotting teeth and diseases when you grow up! Similarly, we need to clean our mind every day by meditation. That little bit of effort every day helps us control our mind and concentrate.

We don't get immediate success—we can't suddenly concentrate really well when we first start meditating. But we may notice over time that we can study better, that we don't get as agitated as we used to, that we have more patience and more understanding, that we can more calmly handle difficulties. Meditation helps us avoid stress, anger and anxiety, so we can think more calmly and clearly. When we are a little older, we will be so glad we did, so we can experience real happiness and wisdom. It is very important to remember that even if we stop meditation for awhile, we should get back to a regular meditation, and not give up. Meditation is not easy, but it is well worth all the effort.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Walking meditation: Students stand with their backs toward a wall, not too close to each other. Teacher demonstrates walking very slowly, naturally, but not so slow as to lose balance or feel silly, without exaggerating any movements or dragging the feet. Then the teacher instructs them, in a very soothing voice, to just stand with eyes closed, and pay close attention to breathing, noticing every sensation of breathing. Teacher then instructs them to notice the feeling of their feet on the floor, to notice the feeling of the toes on the floor, then the front of the feet, then the heels on the floor. Teacher instructs them to notice how their body is balanced on their feet, and then to notice how it feels to lean forward just a tiny bit, and then to again stand straight up again. Teacher then instructs them to open their eyes, and slowly raise one

foot slightly, and notice how that feels in the leg to raise the foot, then smoothly move the foot forward in a normal small step and place the foot down on the floor, noticing how it feels for the foot to touch the floor again. Teacher instructs them the same way for the next step. Students are instructed to continue walking at their own pace, not looking at other students or looking around, just keep focused on how it feels to walk very slowly. Keeping the voice very soothing, teacher coaches them to feel sensations in their foot, as each part of the foot touches the floor, moves forward and touches the floor, feel sensations in their leg, their upper leg, lower leg, ankle, how their body balances with each new step, notice the arms and hands and fingers, notice when they are breathing in, and when they are breathing out. Then let students do walking meditation in silence for a little while.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 26
Merit

Lesson 26
MERIT

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Why is it important to make merit?

Story: Visākhā

Visākhā was the daughter of a millionaire. Her grandfather heard that the Buddha was arriving in their city, and he told his grand-daughter Visākhā to bring all of her friends and servants to welcome the Buddha. Although she was a young girl, when she heard the Buddha teach the Dharma, she fully understood and became a stream-enterer, a sotāpanna, the first level of enlightenment. When she was 15 or 16 years old, she was extremely beautiful and got married to Puññavaddhana, the son of the millionaire Migāra. Her husband and his family were not followers of the Buddha but followed other religious teachers. Visākhā was taught all the proper manners of being a good wife, like respecting her husband's parents and offering them food first.

Visākhā was very kind and devoted to the Buddha and Dharma. Migāra did not like her devotion to the Buddha; he preferred his own religious teachers. One morning, he was sitting in his fancy chair eating his rice-porridge, and Visākhā was fanning him. A bhikkhu came to the door to receive food. Visākhā moved out of the way so Migāra could see the monk, but Migāra pretended not to notice him. Migāra kept his face down, enjoying his porridge. Visākhā felt disgusted with his behavior. She thought, "How could he just ignore a monk at the door?" She wondered what to do. If she also ignored the monk, or turned him away, that would be rude and disrespectful to a monk, which she did not want to do. If she served food to the monk, that would be disrespectful to Migāra, her father-in-law, and would be

disobeying his rules. So she said to the bhikkhu, "Bhante, you may go away. My father-in-law is eating stale food." Migāra looked at her in anger and disbelief, thinking, "She has disgraced the family!"

Migāra ordered the servants: "Take away the food. Chase that girl out of the house. She says I am eating garbage." But all of the servants respected and admired Visākhā very much, so they did not dare move or do anything against her. Visākhā politely said, "Dear father, there is no good reason why I should go away. Eight people from my clan were sent with me to stay here at your house to report any misbehavior of mine. Please call them and have them investigate whether I am guilty of misbehavior."

Migāra called the eight people from Visākhā's clan, and described what happened, saying "While I was eating my porridge, this girl said what I was eating was unclean. She has misbehaved and should be asked to leave." Then Visākhā explained, "Sirs, when my father-in-law ignored the bhikkhu at the door and kept eating, he was not getting merit in this life. He was enjoying the merit of past lives, which is what made him wealthy in this life. Enjoying old merits from past lives without making fresh new merits is like eating old stale food. So I told the monk to go away, and that he was eating stale food." The eight men from her clan agreed that she was innocent and had not misbehaved. Migāra then agreed that she was not guilty of being rude.

Migāra tried to find fault with her for other incidences, too, but no one else would find that she misbehaved. She planned to leave his house anyway, as he first had asked her to do. But Migāra's attitude toward her changed, and he asked her to forgive him. She said., "Dear father, I pardon you, but I will only stay if I can serve the monks as I like, since my family and I have complete faith in the Buddha." Migāra agreed, and after some time, he invited the Buddha to his home and became a great follower of the Buddha also.

Visākhā was not only devoted to the Buddha, Dharma and Sangha, but she was extremely generous. She thought

about what they might need, saw what was needed, and gave generously. She spent a large amount of money to buy land and build a monastery with 500 rooms, called the Pubbārāma Monastery, for the Buddha and Sangha. She asked the Buddha to allow her to make eight offerings: bathing clothes for monks, bathing robes for nuns, meals for visiting bhikkhus, meals for resident bhikkhus, food for sick bhikkhus, food for monks attending sick monks, medicine, and gruel (porridge) which is healthy food for the bhikkhus. She helped the nuns in many ways, also. When she thought about bhikkhus using her gifts and becoming Arahants, she felt enormously happy and peaceful and could then concentrate her mind well in meditation.

Questions after the story:

1. Why did Migāra not like Visākhā's devotion to the Buddha?
2. Why didn't Migāra welcome and give food to the bhikkhu?
3. Why didn't Visākhā serve food to the monk?
4. What did Visākhā say to the bhikkhu?
5. What did Visākhā mean when she said Migāra is eating stale food?
6. What happened to Migāra?
7. What kind of person was Visākhā?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Puññaṃ ce puriso kayirā, kayirāth' etaṃ punappunaṃ, tamhi chandaṃ kayirātha, sukho puññassa uccayo."

"If one does good deeds, then do it again and again; take delight in merit, for accumulation of merit leads to happiness."

(Dhammapada 118/9:3)

"Pāpo' pi passati bhadram, yāva pāpaṃ na paccati, yadā ca paccati pāpaṃ, atha pāpo pāpāni passati."

"As long as the evil act does not ripen, the evil-doer feels fine, but when the evil act ripens then he feels the painful result of his evil deed." (Dhammapada 119/9:4)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Each of us is fortunate to have a healthy body, an intelligent mind, a nice family, good teachers, and to be able to learn and practice Dharma. Does everyone have such good fortune? No. Some people don't have all of these things. Many people are suffering with illness, poverty, worry, unhappiness, bad environment, problems in the family, abuse, conflicts or even war. Also, there are many beings suffering in hell-worlds. Why do we have such good fortune? We have done many good deeds in the past, and we had good virtues and lived with good morals in past lives. That is called "good kamma" or "*puññakamma*" which causes good results (*vipāka*)—health, wealth, success and happiness. Does that mean we will always have good fortune?

No. As the Buddha says, everything is impermanent, including good fortune. Everything changes, and nothing lasts forever. We don't know what we have done in our many past lives, so we don't know what will happen in this life. Most people do a lot of things to enjoy themselves, without thinking much about what they can do for others. They do some good deeds, many not-so-good deeds, and some bad deeds. We may have lived many lives like that in the past. Now we are getting the results of our good deeds. We don't know when the results of those good deeds will run out, or when we will get the results of our not-so-good and bad deeds, our "bad kammas."

What happens if we run out of results of our good deeds? Then we only have results of bad kammas to experience. Just like a car runs out of gas when we use up the gas in the tank and don't refill it, we run out of good fortune when we use up our good kammas and don't refill with more good kammas. And then when we run out, we

experience suffering. When we are suffering, it may be difficult to start doing good deeds. It is difficult to do them when we are sick, poor, depressed, injured, or having other big problems. Visākhā pointed out that Migāra was wealthy because of his merits, good kammas, the good deeds done in past lives, so he was enjoying the results of those. But he does not know when those results will end or when the results of his past bad deeds will start taking effect. He was like a crab in a pot of water. He is happy and dancing around in the cool water in the pot, thinking that everything is great. But when the fire is turned on under the pot, the poor crab suffers and gets cooked. When Migāra's bad kammas take effect, he will suffer like the crab getting cooked.

We too may have done some foolish bad deeds in past lives and maybe in this life. What do we mean by "bad deeds" or "*pāpakamma*"? Being unkind and selfish, hurting others with our words or deeds, fighting, being greedy and not generous, taking things from others and not returning them, lying, and misbehaving in many types of ways. We may not have been punished for our bad deeds and may not have experienced anything horrible afterward, so we may have thought we could do some more wrongdoing and nothing bad would happen. Like the Buddha says, as long as an evil deed has not "ripened" (caused a bad result), we may think it is OK to do, and enjoy doing it again, because nothing goes wrong for us. So we may have been dancing like a crab in a pot, too. But, like the Buddha says, when the evil deed ripens, maybe a long time or many lives later, we will experience the suffering (*dukkha*) from it.

What can we do about that? Do we have to live our lives afraid of bad things that might happen because of our past deeds? No! As we learned before, everyone goes through difficulties and experiences dukkha (suffering). That is part of life. But we can also decrease the dukkha (suffering) that we must experience from our past deeds, and we can avoid having more bad events happen in our future.

How do we avoid having more bad events happen in the future? We stop doing wrong deeds (*pāpakamma*) and do more good deeds (*puññakamma*), by following dharma. Like Anāthapiṇḍika and Visākhā, we give what we can, and help others, which is *puññakamma*, good deeds. And, we follow Dharma by being honest, kind, compassionate, humble, tolerant, peaceful, self-controlled, and practicing the other morals we have learned about. That way, we have the results of the good deeds (*vipāka*) in our future, and, as the Buddha says, the good deeds lead to happiness.

How can we decrease the *dukkha* we must experience from our past bad kammas? What if we must experience illness, injury, loss, problems, abuse, conflicts, and failures? Like Ven. Aṅgulimāla, we can have confidence that we are now good people practicing Dharma. He became a great monk and therefore avoided going to hell-worlds for his misbehavior, but he had to experience the abuse from people who still hated him. So, his suffering was greatly decreased. Like Ven. Soṇa Kolivisa, we can meditate, which itself will give us happiness, and which will enable us to calmly handle difficulties with wisdom.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Draw the Crab in the Pot: Each student writes today's quotation of Buddha on paper and draws a picture of a crab in a pot of water with a fire lit under it. Watercolor paints may be used to color the picture.

Closing chant:

Sabbe satā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

Lesson 27
Selfless Service

Lesson 27
SELFLESS SERVICE

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever been asked to help clean up something and you thought it was too messy to clean up?

Story: The Sick Monk

There was once a bhikkhu who had an illness called dysentery, which causes terrible uncontrollable diarrhea. The bhikkhu was extremely weak and always thirsty because of the illness. Because the diarrhea became uncontrollable, and he was too weak to walk to the bathroom, which was not close to his room, he had accidents. So, he lay on the floor on a mat in his soiled robes.

The Buddha, along with Ven. Ānanda, visited the monastery where the sick monk was staying. Ven. Ānanda was the Buddha's attendant, who stayed near the Buddha to attend to whatever need the Buddha had. He often traveled with the Buddha. The Buddha walked through the monastery with Ven. Ānanda and saw the sick monk lying on his mat. The Buddha asked him, "What sickness do you have?" The bhikkhu answered, "Dysentery, Bhante." The Buddha asked, "Isn't there anyone to help you?" The bhikkhu answered, "No, Bhante." The Buddha was surprised, and asked, "Why don't the other monks help you?" The bhikkhu looked uncomfortable, and said, "I don't help them, so they don't help me."

The Buddha turned to Ven. Ānanda, and said, "Ānanda, get a bucket of water. Let's wash him." Ven. Ānanda immediately brought the water. The Buddha arranged the sick monk so he could be washed, and then he poured water from the bucket onto the sick monk, and Ven. Ānanda washed him thoroughly. They made a clean bed for

him, and lifted him up onto the bed.

The Buddha called all the bhikkhus at the monastery to a meeting, and asked them, "Bhikkhus, is there a sick monk in this monastery?" They answered that there was. He asked what his illness was, and they knew it was dysentery. The Buddha asked whether there was anyone to take care of the sick monk, and they said, "No, Bhante." He asked why they didn't take care of him, and they admitted, "Bhante, he is of no use to the monks, so that is why they don't take care of him." The Buddha said, "You don't have your parents to take care of you, so if you don't take care of each other, who will take care of you?" The Buddha concluded, "If you would take care of me, then take care of anyone else who is sick."

Questions after the story:

1. What very special job did Ven. Ānanda have?
2. What was wrong with the monk lying on the mat?
3. What did the Buddha do when he saw him?
4. Why do you think the Buddha himself and Ven. Ānanda washed the monk?
5. Why didn't the other monks take care of him?
6. What did the Buddha teach the monks?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Hitvā ratiṃ ca aratiṃ ca, sītibhūtaṃ nirūpadhiṃ,
sabbalokābhibhūṃ vīraṃ, tamahaṃ brūmi brāhmaṇaṃ."

"He who has given up likes and dislikes has become tranquil, and is like a hero who has conquered all the worlds—he is a true holy man."(Dhammapada 418/26:36)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

The monks in the story probably did not want to be bothered with caring for the sick monk, because it would take a lot of time and effort, and it was disgusting to clean up. They thought that since the monk wasn't any help to them, they didn't need to help him. Those are selfish

feelings. What do we mean by "selfish feelings"? Selfishness means to do only what you feel like doing, to avoid doing what you don't want to do, to ignore someone who needs help, or to only help when it will get you what you want. We might pretend we didn't see something that should be done, something that should be cleaned up, someone who could use some help. Or we might complain if we are asked to do something that we don't feel like doing. We might think that someone else should do it. We might think, like the monks did, that we won't get anything in return for our service. Or—the famous excuse—we might say we're too busy. Can you think of some other excuses you or others make to avoid having to help?

How can we stop those selfish thoughts? The Buddha said "if you would take care of me, then take care of anyone else." So when we see something that needs to be done, we should think that if we would help the Buddha to do it, then we can help our family members, teachers, friends, and others to do it. If someone in our family is sick, we can offer to help in whatever ways we can. That is what the Buddha would expect us to do. We can think about the merit, *puññakamma*, that we must do so that we can have a good future. But even better, it is good to help because we have loving-kindness (*mettā*) and compassion (*karuṇā*) toward others. We serve them and help them because we want them to be happy. That means we don't think about how others are going to "pay us back" and help us in return. This is "selfless service," doing something helpful, some service, for someone without wanting something in return.

What if we really don't like to do it at all? What if there is a really unpleasant service that needs to be done? When you are disgusted with something, what do you say? Maybe you say "eeew" or "yucky." Maybe Ven. Ānanda could have thought, "I don't want to clean up or even get near that smelly sick monk." But he did it anyway. How can we also overcome feelings of disgust or unpleasantness? The Buddha teaches that "he who overcomes likes and dislikes

becomes tranquil" (peaceful), and is a hero and a holy person. How do we do that? We learn to think good thoughts instead. For example, if we see a dead animal, we can notice its nice fur or wish it a good rebirth. That does not mean we touch or get near something that might harm us—a dead animal may have harmful bacteria that can make us sick. If we see a sick person, instead of thinking "you look awful," we can think compassionate thoughts, wishing the person feels better, and offer to bring him a drink of water. If we see a very old person, instead of staring at her missing teeth, bent back or bony hands, we can notice how soft her hands are, how kind her eyes look, how gently she talks, or feel compassion that she can't walk, can't eat easily, or has sad eyes. If we see something that needs to be done that we normally would rather not do, such as arranging people's shoes neatly at the temple, cleaning up baby sister's or brother's mess, or picking up any trash spilled in the yard—we do it anyway, remembering the Buddha's advice, that if you would do it for him, then do it for others. This gives us a good habit of doing selfless service.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Take the students to visit with the elderly in a home for the aged or, if the group of students is very small, to visit with a lonely elderly person or a bedridden patient in a hospice.

If planned in advance with the facility, and if appropriate, students can sing devotional songs or chant some religious verses, and/or may make and/or bring small gifts, cards, or snack food items.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

We can especially wish all the people in the world who have illnesses to feel better and be happy.

Lesson 28
Courage

Lesson 28
COURAGE

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever been really scared—terrified?

Story: Sopāka

A little boy named Sopāka was born to parents who were very poor. He was a very kind-hearted and innocent boy. When Sopāka was seven years old, his father died. Later, his mother got married to a man who was then Sopāka's stepfather. The stepfather was an angry, cruel man who always scolded and shouted at Sopāka, and even beat him, because the stepfather thought Sopāka was just another responsibility that he didn't want to have. He knew Sopāka's mother loved the boy very much, so he couldn't just get rid of Sopāka. This frustrated the stepfather even more.

One evening, he had an idea. He asked Sopāka to go for a walk with him. Sopāka noticed that he had a kind voice, and thought maybe his mother had asked the stepfather to be nice to him. He innocently thought that his stepfather may have become a better person.

So he went with his stepfather out of the house. As they walked near the cemetery, Sopāka walked closer to his stepfather, scared of seeing the awful-looking dead bodies there. But his stepfather stepped into the graveyard. Sopāka wondered why he was going there, but he dared not wait alone outside. So he walked in also. The stepfather walked near some smelly dead bodies and took out a rope. Sopāka wondered what was going on, but he was so afraid of the dead bodies that he went very close to his stepfather. He watched his stepfather tie the rope around one of the dead bodies and then reach the rope toward Sopāka. In horror, too shocked and confused to know what to do, Sopāka

watched his stepfather tie the other end of the rope tightly around both of Sopāka's hands. When he realized what happened, he wailed, "Oh father, don't do this to me, please! I'm scared!" But the stepfather walked away. "Don't leave me here, I'm scared!!" Sopāka cried. He tried to break free, but the rope was very thick and tightly tied around his hands. He tried to walk away, but he couldn't pull the heavy dead body on the other end of the rope. He was stuck there, and absolutely terrified.

It was very dark, and there were noises of animals nearby in the jungle, maybe tigers or leopards. He cried louder and called out as loud as he could for help. But there was no one. He was totally alone.

But through his tears, he saw a bright light. Could it be someone's torch? No, it was much brighter than that. Then he heard a kind voice calling his name. Was he imagining it? The kind voice called his name again, saying "Don't be afraid, I am here to help you." Then suddenly the rope that bound his wrists so tightly became loose and fell off. He saw a holy man in robes, with long earlobes and the kindest, most loving face he had ever seen, surrounded by a bright light. He thought that he was in the cemetery, but suddenly he was sitting in a building with the holy man. It was the Buddha, who by his supernatural power had broken the ropes and suddenly transported Sopāka to the Jetavana Monastery, far away from the cemetery. He was given a bath, some clean clothes and some food. He was silent, amazed, and couldn't believe what had happened.

Meanwhile, the stepfather returned to the house, and immediately Sopāka's mother asked, "Where is my son?" The stepfather acted surprised and said, "He ran home before me. I thought he would be here." The mother was so upset, she looked everywhere for him, calling out for him, but it was no use. So she cried all night, and thought, "People say that the Buddha knows everything. Maybe he can tell me where my son is." So she went early in the morning to Jetavana Monastery, and walked into the temple.

The Buddha saw her looking so worried with tears on her face, and asked, "Sister, why are you crying?" She answered, sobbing, "My only son, he went with my husband for a walk last night but didn't come home. He's been missing all night."

The Buddha said softly, "Sister, your son is here, safe with me." Sopāka's mother didn't understand what he meant, and the Buddha said, "Here, let me show you." He led Sopāka's mother to another room and pointed to a young monk, his head cleanly shaven, wearing robes, with a happy radiant face. It was Sopāka! He had now become a monk! His mother was so relieved that he was safe, and that he could live a holy life free from the abuse of the stepfather.

The Buddha gave a Dharma talk, mentioning that it is no use looking for children or family members without looking for the path to Nibbāna. Sopāka's mother then became a follower of the Buddha and went home.

Questions after the story:

1. What type of person was the stepfather?
2. What type of person was Sopāka?
3. Why did Sopāka go with his stepfather for a walk?
4. Why did he go with his stepfather into the cemetery?
5. What happened when Sopāka was alone in the cemetery?
6. Why did the stepfather leave Sopāka tied to a dead body in the cemetery?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Pāṇimhi ce vano nāssa, hareyya pāṇinā visaṃ, nābbaṇam visamanveti; natthi pāpaṃ akubbato."

"If on the hand there is no wound, one may even carry poison in it. Poison does not affect the hand without any wounds. In the same way, no evil happens to one who does no evil act."

(Dhammapada 124/9:9)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Poor Sopāka was in a terrible situation—left alone in a cemetery. He could have suffered for days in anguish and horror and then slowly died. But suddenly, after only a short time in the cemetery, his unfortunate situation changed dramatically. As cruel as the stepfather was, with an act that was sure to get rid of Sopāka in a most horrible way, he couldn't destroy little Sopāka or even make him suffer for long. Why? The Buddha saved him with miraculous powers. Do you think that the Buddha saved everyone who was unhappy or suffering? Would he use his supernatural powers to bring just anyone to the temple?

In the past lessons, we learned about the Law of Karma, that if we do bad deeds (*pāpakamma*), we will suffer the bad results of those deeds sooner or later, and if we do good deeds (*puññakamma*), what happens? We will enjoy the good results of those deeds, sooner or later. What if Sopāka was an evil person who did many bad deeds? He would have to suffer the bad results. Maybe he would have died in the cemetery. But Sopāka was a good person, kind-hearted and innocent. Maybe he had some bad kammas from past lives that resulted in being abused by his stepfather. But his past kammas were not so bad that he had to die alone in a cemetery. He only had to suffer a little while before the Buddha saved him. And then he had a most fortunate life as a monk, living in a monastery with the Buddha. He was fully protected by the Buddha, Dharma and Sangha. No matter what the cruel stepfather would try to do, he could not even touch Sopāka anymore. Sopāka would never have to be afraid again.

Once he was with the Buddha, practicing the Dharma, Sopāka was a person who could not be affected by evil; he was totally protected. The Buddha teaches that no evil happens to those people who do no evil acts. He compares this to a person whose hand is protected by healthy skin, who can hold poison in his hand but not be poisoned. The

poison cannot get inside the body because the skin protects it. What happens if a person has a wound on his hand and holds poison in it? He will be easily poisoned. The poison can seep into the weak part of the skin – the wound—and the person suffers and may die.

Similarly, if we have a weak part of our character, then evil done by others can badly affect us. What does that mean, a weak part of our character? It means having hatred, greed, envy, anger, selfishness, or other negative attitudes. If someone does something unfair to us, and we have hateful feelings, then you can see that evil comes into us – we have many negative thoughts and maybe hateful words or acts. If instead we do not become hateful, then no evil comes to us. When the person is unfair to us, like the healthy hand holding poison, we don't let it get to us, we don't get badly affected by it because we don't become hateful.

In addition, as it is often said, the Dharma protects us—the more we follow Dharma, the less evil can affect us. If we are really practicing Dharma, not doing any bad acts and not saying unkind things, then we don't have to be afraid of bad things happening to us. Why? Because we are protected by the Dharma, by our good acts, words and thoughts. But, like Sopāka and Ven. Aṅgulimāla, we will have to suffer the results of our bad deeds done in *past* lives. We can endure them with courage, knowing that we are not doing any more bad deeds (*pāpakamma*) in this life, and that we have a great and happy future.

Activity to reinforce the lesson: (next page)

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

We can think about all the people who are afraid of different things, and wish that their fears go away and they become happy and peaceful.

REVIEW QUIZ—CIRCLE THE BEST ANSWER:

1. When Sundarī and some ascetics tried to ruin the Buddha's reputation, and the villagers insulted the bhikkhus, what did the Buddha tell them to do?
   a) go away
   b) tell the Buddha
   c) tell them that those who lie and do wrong but say they didn't will suffer
   d) insult them

2. What can you do to avoid trouble when someone insults you?
   a) tell the teacher
   b) feel embarrassed
   c) tell the person to be quiet
   d) be quiet and remember that you are a good person

3. Why didn't the other monks take care of the sick monk?
   a) the sick monk didn't help them
   b) they didn't know how to take care of him
   c) they didn't know he was sick
   d) the sickness was too disgusting

4. What kind of people should we help?
   a) monks
   b) parents
   c) people who didn't help us
   d) kids we don't know
   e) a through d

5. Visākhā gave gifts to the Sangha—which of these did she NOT give?
   a) monastery
   b) medicine
   c) gems
   d) food
   e) bathing robes
   f) meals

6. If we do merit (*puññakamma*), then we get:
   a) protection
   b) courage

c) happiness
d) good future
e) less suffering
f) confidence
g) a through e
h) a through f

7. When should we do merit?
   a) when we are old enough
   b) whenever we can
   c) when our parents ask us to
   d) when we have to
   e) a and c

8. What do we need to meditate?
   a) effort (*viriya*)
   b) courage
   c) quiet clean place
   d) diligence (*appamāda*)
   e) a, b and d
   f) a, c and d
   g) b and c
   h) a, b and c

9. If we do something wrong, we should:
   a) not talk about it
   b) fix the problem we caused
   c) tell all our friends
   d) admit we did it
   e) apologize
   f) a and b
   g) b, d and e
   h) c and e

Lesson 29
Control Anger

Lesson 29
CONTROL ANGER

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever gotten so angry that you did something that you regret?

Story: Devadattas Anger

Devadatta, a cousin of the Buddha, was a Sakyan prince who, as a child, had shot a swan and argued with Prince Siddhattha over who owned the swan. He later was ordained as a Buddhist monk. After having been a monk for many years, he still had desires for power, admiration and honor. He thought, "If a very wealthy person becomes devoted to me, I will get power, honor and whatever I desire." So he went to visit Prince Ajātasattu, the son of the good and powerful King Bimbisāra. When he arrived, Devadatta used his psychic powers to appear in a disguise as a small boy with snakes around his body, to impress the prince. Prince Ajātasattu was scared, guessing that this was some type of powerful being. Devadatta said, "Are you afraid?" Prince Ajātasattu said, "Yes. Who are you?" He replied, "I am Devadatta." The Prince said, "Then please show yourself in your true form." Devadatta then appeared in his normal form as a monk.

The Prince was very impressed, and thought that Devadatta was a great monk to have such powers. So, he served Devadatta with great devotion and gave him many gifts. Devadatta then felt very honored and famous, to have the great Prince Ajātasattu serving him so well. But now that he had this desire fulfilled, he wanted something else—to rule the Sangha. But these desires caused his psychic powers to disappear.

The bhikkhus heard about Devadatta's fame, gifts and honor, and told the Buddha, who said, "Devadatta's gifts,

fame and honor will cause his goodness to decrease; they are for his own self-destruction."

One day, Devadatta approached the Buddha while he was surrounded by a huge crowd of followers, and said, "Bhante, you are getting old and weak. You should rest, relax and enjoy your accomplishments. I'll take care of the Sangha." The Buddha answered, "That's not necessary, Devadatta. Don't think about taking charge of the Sangha." Devadatta asked a second and then a third time, and then the Buddha said, "I would not let even Sāriputta and Moggallāna take care of the Sangha. How can I let the Sangha be ruled by you?" Devadatta reeled in anger, feeling shamed while Moggallāna and Sāriputta were praised. He silently bowed to the Buddha and left.

With his desire to rule the Sangha frustrated, and having been so insulted, Devadatta had such anger in his mind that he started to have terrible thoughts of hatred and revenge. He went to Prince Ajātasattu and suggested that the Prince may not live long, and then would not get to rule as king, so he should become king soon by killing his father King Bimbisāra. Then Devadatta planned to become the new Buddha by killing Gotama Buddha. So Prince Ajātasattu, convinced that Devadatta was powerful and therefore good, followed his advice and went into the king's inner palace with a knife on his leg. But the guards caught him, and questioned what he was doing. He admitted he intended to kill his father, the king. They asked who prompted him to do that, and Prince Ajātasattu said, "Ven. Devadatta did so." The prince was taken to the king, who asked, "Why do you want to kill me?" The prince replied, "I want the kingdom." So the king gave him the kingdom.

Devadatta asked Ajātasattu to send some men to kill the Buddha. The man who was supposed to kill the Buddha went to where the Buddha was, but he became scared, and his body froze. The Buddha called the man, who put down his weapons, bowed to the Buddha and admitted his foolish and evil intent to kill him. The Buddha said that since he

knew and admitted his mistake, he was forgiven. He heard the Buddha teach the Dharma, and he became a follower of the Buddha.

When he heard what had happened, Devadatta decided to kill the Buddha himself. He climbed up Vulture Peak Rock when the Buddha was walking in the shade of the rock. Devadatta pushed a huge stone down so it would hit and kill the Buddha. As it rolled down, the stone was caught between two parts of the rock, and only a sharp piece of the stone fell and cut the Buddha's foot so that it bled. The Buddha looked up and told Devadatta that was a very bad kamma. Devadatta did not seem to care, as he soon had another plan.

He went to the stable where a man-killing elephant named Nālāgiri was, and announced to the elephant-keepers that he and the king could increase their pay and food, and said, "When the monk Gotama comes down the road, let this elephant loose." The next day, when the Buddha and a group of bhikkhus went to the city to receive food, the elephant-keepers saw them coming and let Nālāgiri loose on the road. Nālāgiri raised up his trunk, tail and ears and charged toward the Buddha. The bhikkhus quickly warned the Buddha to turn back, but the Buddha said, "It is impossible for a Buddha's life to be taken by violence." People nearby looked to see what would happen. The Buddha thought only of loving-kindness toward Nālāgiri, and then the elephant lowered his trunk and walked up to him. The Buddha patted Nālāgiri's forehead. Nālāgiri picked up the dust from around the Buddha's feet and sprinkled it on his head, and quietly walked back to his stable, now a tamed peaceful elephant. The people of the town found out how Devadatta had tried to kill the Buddha, and Devadatta's fame and honor faded away.

Questions after the story:

1. Why did Devadatta visit Prince Ajātasattu?
2. What did Devadatta desire?

3. Why did he become so angry at the Buddha?
4. How did Devadatta try to kill the Buddha?
5. Why couldn't he kill the Buddha?
6. How did the Buddha tame Nālāgiri?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Paradukkhūpadānena, attano sukhamicchati, verasaṃsagga-saṃsaṭṭho, verā so na parimuccati."

"Entangled by the bonds of anger, he who seeks his own happiness by causing pain to others is never free from anger."

(Dhammapada 291/21:2)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Devadatta had desires that most people have—he wanted to be admired, he wanted popular or powerful people to like him, he wanted to have nice things, and he wanted to show off how popular he was. So with these desires, he became friends with Prince Ajātasattu for selfish reasons. But, when the Prince gave him what he wanted, was he happy? Not for long. As we know, one desire leads to another. Getting what we want does not ever make us happy for long. There is always something else we want. So then Devadatta wanted to rule the Sangha. But the Buddha refused his request, and his desire was frustrated, leading to anger.

When we get angry, are we able to think clearly? Usually not. Anger makes our mind so disturbed that we cannot concentrate or enjoy anything. We think about how we can get what we want, who has what we want, and who is blocking us from getting what we want. We envy those who have what we want, we feel aggressive toward those who prevent us from getting what we want, we feel revengeful toward those who took something away from us, and we think of ways to force or trick others into giving us what we want. These thoughts make us forget Dharma, forget ways to calm down and be happy.

Entangled by our feelings of anger, we only get more

desires, frustrations, and anger. We want to get some *things*, we want to get others to do what we want, or we want to hurt someone who took what we like, or who prevented us from getting what we want. We think we will only be happy if we get our way. So we say and do things to get what we want. If we speak according to our thoughts, what kind of things would we say? Angry words, insults, and bad talk about others. If we act according to our thoughts, what might we do? Fight, steal, or do something else to hurt others. Because of the anger, we don't think clearly. We foolishly think that if we manipulate or hurt others to get our way, we'll be happier. These are all bad kammas, *pāpakamma*—we know what that leads to!

So, the underlying cause of all of this trouble is desire. If we can be more content and less agitated by desire, then we can control our anger and avoid so much trouble and suffering. How can we be more content? Naturally we want to be comfortable and get what we need. Everyone has those desires. But we have to recognize what we really need and what is not really necessary. Do we want something just because our friend has it? Do we want something new because we are bored with what we have? These are the kinds of questions we ask ourselves to see whether something is really necessary.

Activities to reinforce the lesson: (next page)

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

CHOOSE A OR B:

A. FLOWCHART - Draw a flowchart on paper on how a desire can result in harming someone, and an unpleasant future.

The first box is labeled "desire," with two arrows coming from that box leading to boxes marked "desire fulfilled " and "desire not fulfilled."

The "desire fulfilled" box has one arrow leading to the first box.

The "desire not fulfilled" box has one arrow leading to a box labeled "frustration."

The "frustration" box has one arrow leading to a box labeled "anger."

The "anger" box has three arrows:

(1) leading to a box marked "hatred of person preventing me from getting what I want";
(2) leading to a box marked "envy of people who have what I want"; and
(3) leading to a box marked "stealing or use of force, threats or lies to get what I want."

The last of these three boxes (3) has one arrow leading to a box marked "others get angry at me." Boxes (1) and (2) (hatred and envy) have arrows leading to a box marked "ill will toward others."

Finally, the boxes marked "others get angry at me" and "ill will" lead to a box marked "angry words, harmful deeds."

The latter box (angry words, harmful deeds) has one arrow leading to a box labeled "results of bad kammas: suffering, unhappy future, unhappy rebirth."

B. LIST OF WAYS TO CONTROL ANGER

List on paper possible ways to control anger, then post the list in your bedroom so it can be referred to when you feel angry. Here are some suggestions:

Close eyes	Chant or say a prayer
Drink cold water or juice	Drink milk & feel thankful to the cows who provided it
Avoid people who upset me	Remember calmness is best weapon
Take a walk	Breathe deeply – breathe out anger, breathe in peace
Listen to music	Remember anger wastes my energy
Lie down	Think of good qualities of the person who upset me
Clean my room	Look in mirror, decide not to look angry
Go outside, enjoy nature	Tell a friend how I feel, try to laugh about it
Take a bath or shower	Write in a journal or diary
Read a book	Sing or play a musical instrument
Do homework	Draw a picture or cartoon
Count to ten before talking	Remember that someone who hurts others is hurting inside and creates bad kamma

Lesson 30
Avoid Conflict

Lesson 30
AVOID CONFLICT

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: In your school, do you have cliques, or groups of kids who are not friendly with other kids outside the group?

Story: Devadatta Divides the Sangha

After Devadatta lost his reputation trying to kill the Buddha, he didn't want the Buddha to have all the honor, respect and attention. So he thought of how he could destroy it. He talked to his friend Kokālika, and said, "Let's create a disagreement in that monk Gotama's Sangha." Kokālika replied, "The monk Gotama is very powerful, so how can we do that?" Devadatta already had an idea: "Let's ask five requests that would lead to a monk's greater self-control. He won't grant these requests, but people will see that we are superior to them, because they admire self-control."

So Devadatta went with monks who were his followers to visit the Buddha. They bowed, and Devadatta said, "You teach that it is good to have few wishes, to be content, and to get rid of impurities. Here are five ways that will lead to these things: (1) bhikkhus live in the forest their whole life, not in villages; (2) they only beg for food, not receive food at people's homes; (3) they only wear rags sewn together into robes, and not accept robes from laypersons; (4) they only live at the foot of a tree, not in a building; and (5) they eat no fish or meat or else they get punished." The Buddha said, "Let him who wishes to live in the forest and him who wishes to live in a village do so, let him who wishes to beg for food and him who wishes to eat at houses do so, let him who wishes to wear rags and him who wishes to wear robes from householders do so, and let him who wishes to live at the root of a tree do so but not during the rainy season. Fish

and meat may be eaten if it is not seen or heard or suspected to have been killed for the monk personally."

Devadatta was happy that his plan worked, saying "The Buddha does not grant these five requests." He and his followers bowed and left. Devadatta went to the town, Rājagaha, and told the people there about the five rules that the Buddha refused to accept and told them that he and his followers vowed to obey the rules. Some people were persuaded by Devadatta, thinking, "These monks are really self-controlled, but the monk Gotama likes to have luxuries."

The bhikkhus heard about it, and reported it to the Buddha, who then asked Devadatta, "Are you trying to create a disagreement in the Sangha?" Devadatta admitted that was what he was doing. The Buddha told him, "Don't create a disagreement in the Sangha. It is a very bad kamma leading to life in a hell-world. But reuniting the Sangha leads to great merit and rebirth in a heaven-world."

In the morning, when Ven. Ānanda went out to receive food in the town, Devadatta saw him and said, "Friend Ānanda, from today I will carry on with my sangha apart from the Sangha of the Buddha." Devadatta then met with many monks and had them vote on whether they would follow the five extra rules of Devadatta. Five hundred new monks voted in favor of his rules. So Devadatta took these 500 monks with him to another town. Ven. Sāriputta and Ven. Moggallāna told the Buddha about what Devadatta had done. The Buddha told them to go to them before they are ruined. Ven. Sāriputta and Ven. Moggallāna traveled to where Devadatta was teaching a large crowd, including the 500 monks. Devadatta announced, "See, bhikkhus, I am teaching the Dharma well. Even the chief disciples of the monk Gotama have come to me." Kokālika warned Devadatta not to trust them, but Devadatta said they were welcome since they came to hear his teaching. After he taught for awhile, he invited Ven. Sāriputta to teach for awhile, since Devadatta's back was hurting. Devadatta then

lay down in the same posture like the Buddha usually laid down, and he fell asleep.

Ven. Sāriputta taught Dharma to the crowd, and then Ven. Moggallāna gave Dharma teachings. Hearing them, the crowd fully understood the Buddha's teaching that all that arises must end. Then Ven. Sāriputta said he was going back to the Buddha and whoever believes the Buddha's Dharma is welcome to join him. When Ven. Sāriputta and Ven. Moggallāna got up to leave, the 500 monks came with them. Kokālika saw what happened and woke up Devadatta, saying, "See, you shouldn't have trusted them." Devadatta was so angry and jealous that he felt as if hot blood was pouring from his mouth.

When Ven. Sāriputta and Ven. Moggallāna arrived back at the Buddha's monastery, the Buddha told them that Devadatta will die a miserable death because he tried to imitate the Buddha. He said that Devadatta's mind is obsessed with getting things, being famous, and being honored, and worried about not getting things, not being famous, not being honored, and thinking about evil wishes and evil friends. He said that these things will lead to unhappy rebirths.

Questions after the story:

1. Why did Devadatta want to create a disagreement in the Sangha?
2. What were his five rules?
3. Did the Buddha agree to those rules?
4. What did Devadatta do when the Buddha did not accept the rules?
5. Why did some people like Devadatta's rules?
6. What did the Buddha say would happen to Devadatta?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Jayaṃ veraṃ pāsavati, dukkhaṃ seti parājito, upasanto sukhaṃ seti, hitvā jayaparājayaṃ."

"Victory causes enemies; the defeated live in pain. Happily the peaceful ones live, rejecting both victory and defeat." (Dhammapada 201/15:5)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

Devadatta had strong desires to be famous, a great Dharma teacher, honored and respected, with many students. In other words, he wanted to be popular. He was still angry at the Buddha for not letting him lead the Sangha, which made him feel unimportant and unworthy. So he also felt revengeful. He thought he would be happy if he could ruin the Buddha's reputation and become the great important leader of monks. So he tried to divide up the monks, so the Buddha and his followers would be the enemy and the loser, and he would be the great famous monk, the winner. He wanted to "win" the monks over to be under his leadership by a trick of making them think he was better, more disciplined, than the Buddha.

Do you know people who want to be popular and who are egoistic, self-centered and arrogant? These are the conditions that lead a person to manipulate others, or to control them. This kind of person is selfish—he doesn't care much about how happy people are, as long as they admire him and do what he wants them to do. He may say or do things to impress them, or to make them stay away from his rivals. So he tries to make others look bad, says bad things about them, insults them, laughs at them and spreads rumors. Being self-centered, he may have the best clothes and newest gadgets. He may imitate the style of music or movie stars, like Devadatta tried to imitate the Buddha. Because of his confidence and style, others admire him and hope he will be their friend. A clique, or group of friends forms, who follow this person, who are influenced by this person. He or she often controls what they do, and controls who their friends are. Similarly, the 500 monks were like a clique, greatly influenced by Devadatta, until Ven. Sāriputta and Ven. Moggallāna came and taught them.

Are you in a clique, or have you ever tried to be part of one? Some cliques may start conflicts with others who are not part of the group. Sometimes these groups engage in misbehavior, daring deeds, bullying or fights. If a person who is part of the group doesn't cooperate or join in, he may be ridiculed, rejected, or insulted. This is peer pressure. These types of cliques are not true friends, because they are not based on loving-kindness and compassion. We should be very aware of who our real friends are, not be led into following people with wrong ideas, like the 500 monks were fooled into following Devadatta.

We should remember that it is not important to win or lose popularity, or win or lose admiration of a clique. Trying to win popularity leads to conflicts, and it leads to painful feelings when we don't win against a rival, or when we win but worry that a rival will try to attack us in some way.

Activity to reinforce the lesson: (next page)

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

MATCHING

For each group of words, draw a line from each word in the first column to the correct description in the second column:

GROUP A:

Ven. Sāriputta	Robe offering ceremony at end of Rainy Season
Ven. Aṅgulimāla	Generous man who donated a monastery
Ven. Ānanda	Cousin of the Buddha who hated him
Visākhā	A chief disciple of the Buddha
Anāthapiṇḍika	Generous woman who donated a monastery & monks' food
Sopāka	Buddha's attendant who helped wash a sick monk
Gotamī	Murderer who became a great monk
Rāhula	Boy who was left in the cemetery
Devadatta	Siddhattha's foster mother who was the first bhikkhuni
Kathina	Prince Siddhattha's son

GROUP B:

Forbearance	Too much concern about how we look
Merit	The opposite of revenge
Humility	Personal quality we gain if we practice Dharma
Diligence	Admiring good qualities
Vanity	Earned by good deeds and practicing Dharma
Reverence	Opposite of arrogance
Confidence	Doing with great interest and attention

Lesson 31
Avoid Wasting Opportunity

Lesson 31
AVOID WASTING OPPORTUNITY

Opening chants, meditation and review of last lesson.

Question to think about before the story: Have you ever felt too lazy to go some place, but then later you wished you had gone?

Story: The Passing Away of the Buddha

When the Buddha was 80 years old, during the rainy season he got very sick with severe pain that could take his life. The Buddha thought, "It is not good to pass away without telling the bhikkhus." So he made the illness disappear and he recovered.

Ven. Ānanda saw that he looked healthier, and felt relieved. He said, "Bhante, I am used to seeing you look healthy and comfortable. When you were sick, I felt weak, I couldn't think clearly. But I knew that you would not pass away into Nibbāna without giving instructions to the bhikkhus." The Buddha replied, "Ānanda, what does the Sangha expect from me? I taught Dharma without keeping anything secret. I am old, my body is like an old cart that needs repairs. It is only comfortable with extra effort; I must concentrate my mind so I don't think of the body and its feelings. So, each of you should make the Dharma your refuge, by being mindful, fully aware, giving up greed."

One day, Ven. Ānanda was alone with the Buddha, who said, "Ānanda, anyone who like me has developed the four ways leading to success could, if he wished, live for a very long time. I have completely mastered them, so if I wish, I could live longer." This was a hint to Ven. Ānanda to ask the Buddha to live much longer. Ven. Ānanda didn't get the hint; he wasn't paying full attention. The Buddha repeated himself twice, but Ven. Ānanda still didn't get it. The Buddha said that Ven. Ānanda could leave, so he did.

Māra came and encouraged the Buddha to pass into Parinirvana. The Buddha told him that in three months, he would pass away into Parinirvana, the final goal. Just then, an earthquake occurred, because the Buddha had given up the will to live. Ven. Ānanda asked the Buddha why there was an earthquake, and when the Buddha told him, he suddenly remembered what the Buddha had said about living longer. Ven. Ānanda said "Bhante, live longer for the welfare and happiness of the people, from your compassion." The Buddha told him, "Don't ask me now, the time to ask has passed. I gave you the hint, but you didn't ask, so I gave up the will to live and I cannot go back on those words." He told him to call all of the bhikkhus in the monastery.

The Buddha told them, "I taught you the things which I know directly. You must learn, study and practice them, so the holy life will last long for the good of many people, with compassion for the world. All things must get old and pass away. In three months, the Buddha will pass away and I will attain Parinirvana." But he explained that the Dharma does not age, does not wear out.

One bhikkhu, Ven Dhammarāma, did not go to visit the Buddha in his last days, so the others thought he didn't care about the Buddha. When the Buddha called Ven. Dhammarāma to come, he explained to the Buddha that the best way to honor him is to become an arahant before the Buddha passes away. The Buddha praised him, saying "He who loves me should follow the example of Dhammarāma. He honors me most who practices my teachings best."

The Buddha became very weak and sick with terrible pains, but he did not complain. He traveled to the village of Kusināra. The Buddha told Ānanda to announce in Kusināra that in the last part of the night, he will pass into Parinirvana, so the people won't be sad that they missed seeing it.

But even while people were grieving that the Buddha was leaving forever, a wandering ascetic named Suibhadda

came to visit the Buddha. Subhadda heard that the Buddha would be passing away, but he had a question and wanted the Buddha to teach the Dharma to answer it. Ven. Ānanda tried to stop him, saying, "Friend, do not trouble the Buddha, he is weary." The Buddha heard him, and told Ven. Ānanda not to stop Subhadda from asking his question. Subhadda approached the Buddha, asked his question, and the Buddha answered it. Subhadda then took refuge in the Buddha, Dharma and Sangha. The Buddha told Ven. Ānanda to ordain him into the Sangha, and he later became an Arahant.

The Buddha's last words were: "Bhikkhus, it is the nature of all things to dissolve. Attain perfection by diligence."

Questions after the story:

1. Why did the Buddha make his illness disappear?
2. Why didn't Ven. Ānanda ask the Buddha to live longer when the Buddha first hinted to him?
3. Why do you think Māra wanted the Buddha to pass into Parinibbāna?
4. Why did Ven. Dhammarāma not come to see the Buddha?
5. What is the best way to honor the Buddha?
6. Why did the Buddha allow Subhadda to see him even in the last moments of life?

Quotation of Buddha about the moral of the story:

"Uttiṭṭhite nappamajjeyya, dhammaṃ sucaritaṃ care, dhammacāri sukhaṃ seti, asmiṃ loke paramhi ca."

"Wake up! Be diligent! Lead a righteous life. He who lives practicing the Dharma lives happily both in this world and the next."

(Dhammapada 168/13:2)

Application of the moral(s) in the story to our daily lives:

One of the most important teachings of the Buddha is that all things that arise must end. The body, even the Buddha's body, gets old and has to end. We hope that we will grow very old before we die, but we never know for sure when our life will end. So, the Buddha taught us to make the best use of our time while we are alive in this body. In other words, we should not waste time. How do we waste time now? Watching TV, playing electronic games, seeing movies, talking on the phone? We should wake up and notice what we are really *doing* with our time. We can take some time for play, sports and recreation, but we should not overdo it.

The Buddha taught us by his example not to waste any time. He gave many teachings even in his very last days when he was in extreme pain. Even when he had only a few moments left before he was to pass away, he met with a new devotee, taught him Dharma and had him ordained! Yet even Ven. Ānanda, a great monk, thought that the Buddha should just relax in peace in his last few moments of life. This shows how just a few moments of effort can make such an enormous difference. Another example of not wasting time is Ven. Dhammarāma, who wanted to spend his time practicing Dharma the best way he could, so that he could become an arahant. So for him, that meant not even spending time to visit with the Buddha.

Another lesson from this story is not to waste opportunities. Ven. Ānanda had the opportunity to make a really big difference—to cause the Buddha to live much longer. The Buddha could have guided many more people if he had lived longer. But Ven. Ānanda wasted this great opportunity because he wasn't paying close attention. There are so many opportunities to help someone, to be friendly, to show someone we care, to do some selfless service. How many opportunities have we lost because we weren't paying close attention? We may never know, because we weren't paying attention and no one told us what we missed.

The Buddha's last words were advice not just for the monks, but for everyone: to be diligent. What does "diligence" mean? To do something with great interest, attention and effort. These words emphasize how important it is to pay attention to what should be done and do it well. We assume that we have plenty of time, the rest of our lives, to become more virtuous, to make merit (*puññakamma*), and to control our minds. But as we have learned in earlier lessons, we form habits by what we do now. It is very difficult to change our habits when we are older. If we have good habits now, living according to Dharma and meditating, then it is much easier to maintain them and improve ourselves when we are older.

Activity to reinforce the lesson:

Decorating alarm clocks:

Teacher brings a small alarm clock for each student, and art supplies such as glue, markers, yarn, fabric scraps, felt pieces, buttons, sequins, ribbon, glitter glue. Each student is given a clock. Materials such as felt, fabric, popsicle sticks, ribbons, etc., may be glued to the clock. The message "Don't Waste Time" is written in marker or glitter glue on suitable material to be glued to the clock.

Closing chant:

Sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
May all beings have happy minds!

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Acknowledgements iv
Contents v
Introduction ix
Opening Chants xv
Meditation xvi
List of Sources xviii

1. MORAL VALUE: REVERENCE
   Story: Birth of Prince Siddhattha 3
2. MORAL VALUE: COMPASSION
   Story: Prince Siddhattha's Childhood 11
3. MORAL VALUE: AVOID ARGUMENTS
   Story: Devadatta and the Swan 19
4. MORAL VALUE: UNDERSTAND SUFFERING
   Story: The Four Signs 27
5. MORAL VALUE: AVOID BAD INFLUENCE
   Story: Leaving Home 35
6. MORAL VALUE: SELF-CONTROL
   Story: The Ascetic Life 43
7. MORAL VALUE: EFFORT
   Story: Māra's Challenge and Sujātā's Offering 51
8. MORAL VALUE: UNDERSTAND THE PATH AND GOAL
   Story: Enlightenment 59
9. MORAL VALUE: GRATITUDE
   Story: The First 7 Weeks After Enlightenment 67
10. MORAL VALUE: SHOW GRATITUDE
    Story: Deciding to Teach 75
11. MORAL VALUE: HUMILITY
    Story: Yasa and the Kassapas 85
12. MORAL VALUE: AVOID JEALOUSY
    Story: Moggallāna and Sāriputta 95
13. MORAL VALUE: DILIGENCE
    Story: Return to Kapilavatthu 103
14. MORAL VALUE: AVOID POSSESSIVENESS
    Story: Bhaddiya the Happy Monk 113
15. MORAL VALUE: TRUTHFULNESS
    Story: Ven. Rāhula and the Dipper 123

16. MORAL VALUE: GENEROSITY
Story: Generosity of Anāthapiṇḍika 131
17. MORAL VALUE: LOVING-KINDNESS (METTĀ)
Story: Kaṭhina 139
18. MORAL VALUE: AVOID VANITY
Story: The Order of Nuns, Khemā and Nandā 147
19. MORAL VALUE: OBEDIENCE
Story: Nāgasamāla and Meghiya 155
20. MORAL VALUE: AVOID ANGRY SPEECH
Story: River Rohini? 163
21. MORAL VALUE: ADMIT MISTAKES
Story: Quarrel at Kosambi 171
22. MORAL VALUE: AVOID BAD COMPANY
Story: Quarrel at Kosambi Part 2 179
23. MORAL VALUE: CONFIDENCE
Story: Aṅgulimāla 187
24. MORAL VALUE: FORBEARANCE
Story: Sundarī 197
25. MORAL VALUE: MEDITATION
Story: Soṇa Kolivisa 207
26. MORAL VALUE: MERIT
Story: Visākhā 217
27. MORAL VALUE: SELFLESS SERVICE
Story: The Sick Monk 225
28. MORAL VALUE: COURAGE
Story: Sopāka 231
29. MORAL VALUE: CONTROL ANGER
Story: Devadatta's Anger 241
30. MORAL VALUE: AVOID CONFLICT
Story: Devadatta Divides the Sangha 251
31. MORAL VALUE: AVOID WASTING OPPORTUNITY
Story: The Passing Away of the Buddha 259